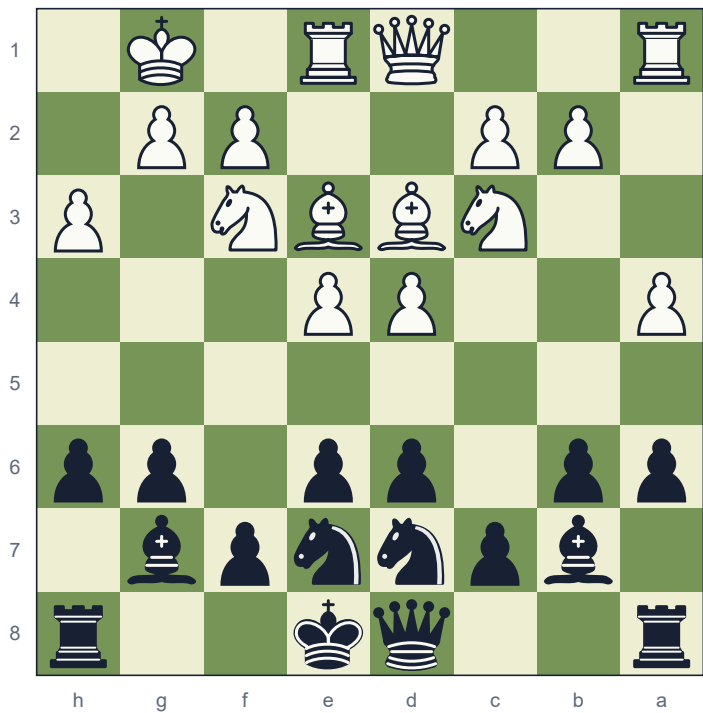


Hippopotamus as Black

A complete practical curriculum from the ground up

The Hippo is a restrained double fianchetto: often ...b6, ...Bb7, ...g6, ...Bg7, ...d6, ...e6, ...Nd7 and ...Ne7, with ...a6 and ...h6 only when useful. Black concedes space and frequently an objective edge. Timely departures from the full formation are essential.



The reference position - White to move

YOUR PERSPECTIVE
Black is at the bottom of every diagram.
Coordinates remain explicit and all pieces stay upright.

WHAT YOU WILL LEARN
24 opening branches, six middlegame laboratories, 48 exercises with explained answers, and a 12-week practice plan. Each subject also appears in one combined volume.

START HERE

Read this booklet first. Then learn one line from each family in Booklet 01. Use 02 for plans, 03 for practice positions, 04 for retrieval and 05 for study schedules and reference.

How to use this course

YOUR FIRST PASS

Use a real or digital board. Read the foundations, then learn only the first line of each opening family. Play slow practice games before trying to remember every variation. A useful opening lesson ends with a decision you can explain, not a string of moves you can recite.

YOUR SECOND PASS

Return to the branch your opponent actually played. Replay it from move one and stop before each move by your side. Name the threat, two plausible replies and the reason for your choice. Check the printed continuation only after committing to an answer.

YOUR THIRD PASS

Use the middlegame laboratories and exercise book. These are original illustrative positions and engine-assisted continuations, not attributed master games. Switch colors in training so you experience the opponent's space, defensive resources and attacking chances.

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This is a broad practical curriculum from basic rules to common opening decisions, middlegames and typical transitions. Chess has too many legal branches for a finite course to exhaust. The course teaches a decision process for unfamiliar replies and marks alternatives, warnings and entry-route boundaries explicitly.

The board and the object of the game

COORDINATES

Files are a through h from White's left to right. Ranks are 1 through 8 from White's side toward Black. A square such as e4 has one file letter and one rank number. White has a light square at the near right corner, h1. Black-oriented diagrams reverse the coordinate display, not the movement rules.

URNS AND CHECK

White moves first; the players alternate one move each. A move may not leave your own king attacked. Check means that the king is attacked; answer by moving the king, capturing the attacker or blocking a line attack when possible. A knight check cannot be blocked.

CHECKMATE AND STALEMATE

Checkmate means the player to move is in check and has no legal reply. Stalemate means the player has no legal move but is not in check; it is a draw. Before announcing mate, examine every king move, capture and possible block. Kings are never actually captured.

MATERIAL IS A GUIDE

For beginner decisions, a pawn is roughly 1, a knight or bishop 3, a rook 5 and a queen 9. These are rough comparisons, not a scoring rule. A king has no exchange value. Activity, safety, passed pawns and immediate tactics can outweigh a small material difference.

How the pieces move

ROOK AND BISHOP

A rook moves along a rank or file. A bishop moves diagonally and stays on its starting square color. Neither can jump over any piece. A sliding piece controls only as far as the first occupied square on each ray; do not count an attack through your own pawn.

QUEEN AND KNIGHT

A queen combines rook and bishop movement. A knight moves two squares in one direction and one at right angles, changing square color. The knight may jump over pieces. A knight on f3 can move to d2, d4, e1, e5, g1, g5, h2 or h4 if the destination and king-safety rules allow.

KING

A king moves one square in any direction and cannot enter an attacked square. The kings cannot stand next to each other. A pinned enemy piece can still restrict the king's legal squares; the rules about attacked squares are more subtle than whether that enemy piece could legally move away from its own king.

PAWN

White pawns move toward higher rank numbers; Black pawns toward lower. A pawn moves one square straight ahead into an empty square, or two from its starting rank if both squares are empty. It captures one square diagonally forward. It cannot move backward or capture straight ahead.

Castling, promotion and en passant

CASTLING

Castling moves the king two squares toward a rook and places that rook on the square the king crossed. The king and that rook must never have moved, the intervening squares must be empty, and the king must not be in check or cross or land on an attacked square. A rook being attacked does not by itself prevent castling.

RIGHTS DO NOT RETURN

If a king or rook moves out and back, the relevant castling right is still lost. A king moved to f1 in the King's Gambit must coordinate its rooks another way. In queenless positions the loss of castling may be less serious, but the legal right remains lost.

PROMOTION

A pawn reaching the last rank must promote to a queen, rook, bishop or knight of its color. It need not choose a previously captured piece. A second queen is legal. Underpromotion can avoid stalemate or create a knight fork, so inspect the exact position before always choosing a queen.

EN PASSANT

Immediately after an opposing pawn advances two squares from its starting rank and lands beside your pawn on your fifth rank, you may capture it as though it had advanced one square. The opportunity lasts only for your next move. The capture is illegal if removing those pawns exposes your own king to check.

Reading moves and navigating branches

ALGEBRAIC NOTATION

K means king, Q queen, R rook, B bishop and N knight. Pawns have no piece letter: e4 is a pawn move. Bc4 means a bishop moves to c4. Nxe5 captures on e5. exd5 is an e-file pawn capturing on d5. A plus sign is check; # is checkmate; O-O is kingside castling and O-O-O queenside castling.

WHICH PIECE MOVED

If two identical pieces can legally reach the same square, notation distinguishes them: Nbd2 means the knight from the b-file; R1e2 means the rook from rank 1. The board, not the notation alone, determines which capture or check is legal. Promotion is written e8=Q, with + or # when appropriate.

MOVE NUMBERS

1.e4 e5 is White's first move and Black's first reply. A line beginning 7...Nf6 starts with Black's seventh move. All main opening lines in this course begin at the initial position; laboratory continuations display their starting diagram and exact move number.

ONE LINE IS NOT FORCED

An example to move ten is one route through the position. It is not a claim that every reply is compulsory. The authored anchor and its illustrative continuation are distinguished. Each line has an ID that also appears in the PGN files and exercises.

Your thinking routine on every move

1. INSPECT THE LAST MOVE

Ask what the opponent's move changed. Did it attack a piece, unmask a bishop, release a rook file, threaten mate or leave something undefended? A remembered opening move is only a candidate until it survives this inspection.

2. EXAMINE FORCING MOVES

Check all checks, serious captures and direct threats for both sides. Calculate the opponent's best reply, not the reply you hope for. Stop the line at a position you can assess: material, king safety and the resulting pawn structure.

3. GENERATE CANDIDATES

Usually compare two or three useful moves: one forcing move, one developing or improving move, and one central response if relevant. In a cramped position ask which exchange or pawn break creates room. In an attacking position ask whether the center can open against your king.

4. BLUNDER CHECK

Before moving, visualize the new position. Is your queen or another piece loose? Have you removed a defender or opened a diagonal to your king? Can the opponent answer with a check, fork or intermediate capture? A ten-second check often saves more points than memorizing another opening branch.

Center, development and time

OCCUPY AND INFLUENCE

Pawns on d4 and e4 occupy central space; bishops and knights can influence those squares from a distance. A restrained setup needs a plan to challenge the opponent's center. Space becomes useful when it gives your pieces safe squares and restricts the opponent.

DEVELOPMENT

Bring knights and bishops into useful play, protect the king and connect the rooks. Avoid moving the same piece repeatedly without a concrete gain. An exception must be explained: a queen retreat in the Scandinavian or a knight escape in the King's Gambit can be compulsory.

A TEMPO

A tempo is one move of useful time. Attacking a queen while developing often gains time, but a check that helps the opponent develop can fail to do so. Count actual useful moves and threats instead of assuming every attack is a gain.

OPENING THE CENTER

If your king is safer and your pieces are ready, opening files can exploit a development lead. If your king is exposed, central exchanges may be dangerous. A closed center often allows maneuvering or a wing attack, but first verify that the opponent cannot open it with a pawn break.

Pawn structures and planning vocabulary

BREAK AND TENSION

A pawn break challenges an enemy pawn structure: c4 against d5 or ...c5 against d4. Tension exists when pawns can capture each other but neither side has committed. Before exchanging, ask which pieces become active, which file opens and which pawn becomes weak.

CHAIN AND BASE

A pawn chain is a diagonal line of mutually supporting pawns. In a white d4-e5 chain, d4 is the base and e5 the head. An attack on either end may work, but the calculation differs: ...c5 usually challenges d4, while ...f6 challenges e5.

WEAK SQUARES AND OUTPOSTS

A square is a useful outpost when a piece can occupy it securely and create meaningful pressure, often because enemy pawns cannot chase it. An outpost with no targets may be less valuable than a flexible central piece. Check whether exchanges eliminate its support.

FILES, DIAGONALS AND LEVERS

A file without pawns is open; one with no pawn of your color is half-open for you. A fianchetto bishop can be excellent on an open diagonal and restricted behind blocked pawns. A lever changes that reality. Name the pawn move that makes your plan possible.

Playing, recording and analyzing a game

CHOOSE A USEFUL TIME CONTROL

For course practice use at least 15 minutes with an increment, or a longer control if available. Blitz is useful for pattern recognition after the basic decisions are learned. It is a poor substitute for calculating an unfamiliar sharp opening carefully.

ANALYZE YOURSELF FIRST

After the game, mark the first unfamiliar position and write your candidates without an engine. Identify the first important mistake, not only the final blunder. Separate opening memory, tactical calculation, strategic judgment and time-management errors.

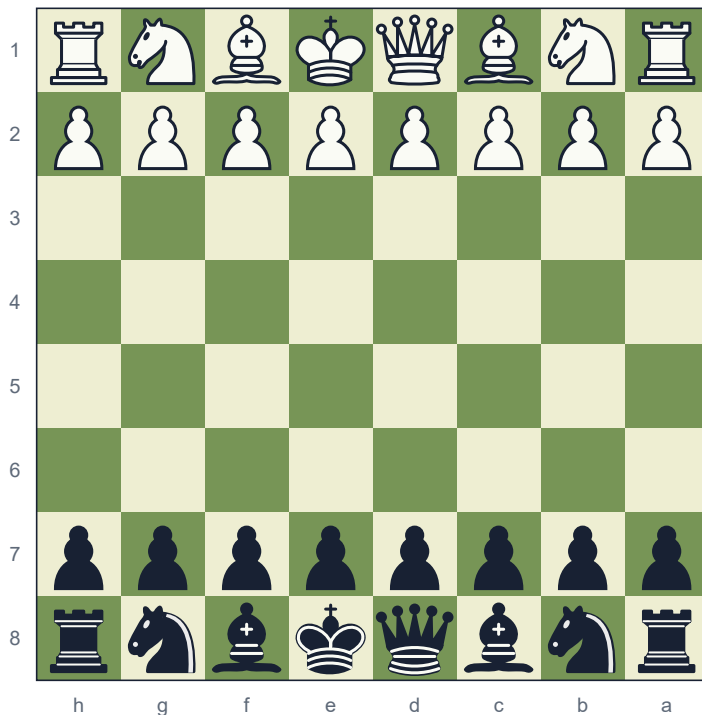
THEN USE THE TOOLS

Compare the game with the matching line ID. Use an engine to test forcing variations and examine a stronger defensive reply. An engine number is evidence from a finite search, not a verbal explanation. Write one sentence that tells you what to do differently next time.

BUILD A SMALL ERROR NOTEBOOK

Keep the position, your move, a better candidate, the opponent's key reply and one lesson. Revisit it after one day, three days, a week and a month. Add the position to your repertoire only when you can explain it without the answer visible.

Read the diagram before the moves



White to move

A RELIABLE FIRST SCAN

Find both kings, name the side to move and locate all pawns in the center. Then inspect checks, captures and direct threats.

ORIENTATION

Your course side is at the bottom. On a Black-oriented board, files read h to a along the bottom; pawns still move according to their color and rank numbers.

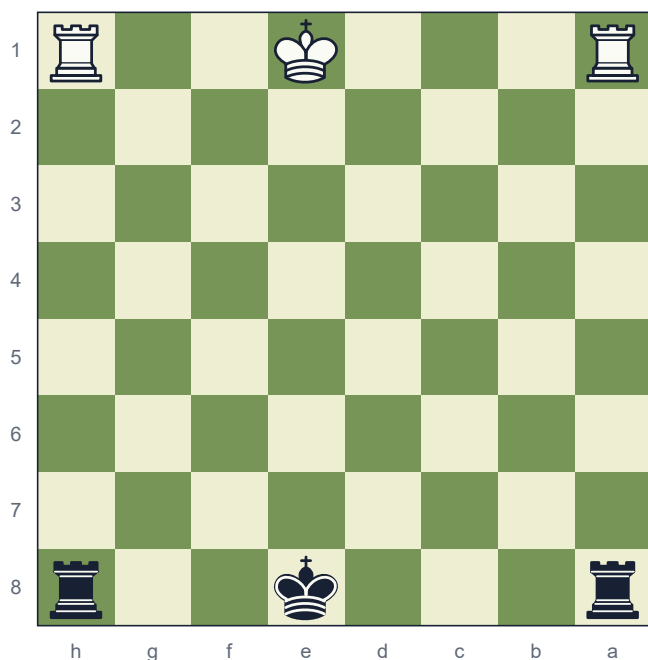
PRACTICE WITHOUT MOVING

Find e4, d5, f7 and b2. Name the piece that begins on each of b1, c1, f8 and g8. From the initial position, count White's legal pawn moves and knight moves: 16 pawn moves and 4 knight moves.

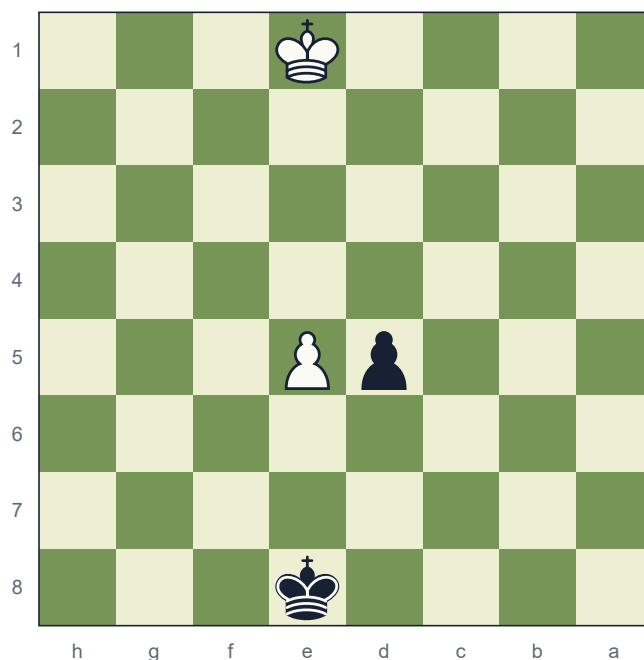
ANSWER THE REAL POSITION

A board caption always states whose move it is and whether the king is in check. You may not ignore check to finish development. In the initial position, bishops and rooks are blocked by friendly pieces.

Castling and en passant on a board



White to move - castling geometry



White to move - en passant available

LEFT: CASTLING GEOMETRY

With the rights recorded in this teaching position, White may castle O-O or O-O-O. The king crosses f1 or d1 and lands on g1 or c1; the rook lands on f1 or d1. Empty squares alone are not enough in a real game: check previous king/rook moves and attacked king squares.

RIGHT: IMMEDIATE EN PASSANT

Black has just played ...d7-d5. White can play exd6 en passant: the white pawn lands on d6 and the black pawn is removed from d5. If White plays another move, the special capture is no longer available.

TRAINING QUESTION

Why can a knight jump over a piece but a bishop cannot? Why can a rook be attacked during legal castling while the king cannot cross an attacked square? Explain the movement rule before using it in an opening.

Your first moves, explained

1... G6

Prepares a fianchetto and changes the long diagonal. Check the bishop and corner rook before assuming the next developing move is safe.

2... BG7

Completes the kingside fianchetto. Before placing the bishop, check that an opposing bishop cannot capture it along an open diagonal.

3... D6

Supports a restrained central formation and opens one bishop diagonal while possibly blocking another. Plan the later pawn break.

4... A6

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

5... B6

Prepares a fianchetto and changes the long diagonal. Check the bishop and corner rook before assuming the next developing move is safe.

BEFORE YOU MEMORIZE

The reference route is one example. Reconstruct it, then change one opposing move and explain why the next automatic setup move might need to change.

Your first moves, explained / continued

6... BB7

Completes the queenside fianchetto and points toward e4. Count the diagonal's blockers before claiming immediate pressure.

7... E6

Supports a restrained central formation and opens one bishop diagonal while possibly blocking another. Plan the later pawn break.

8... ND7

Develops a knight toward central supporting squares. Keep a useful onward route so the compact setup does not become overcrowded.

9... H6

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

10... NE7

Develops the king knight while keeping the f-pawn flexible. It may support a central break or move toward g6 or c6 if safe.

BEFORE YOU MEMORIZE

The reference route is one example. Reconstruct it, then change one opposing move and explain why the next automatic setup move might need to change.

Repertoire map / 1

BUILDING THE FORMATION AGAINST A CLASSICAL CENTER

Start with HB-01. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

HB-01 The full formation as a study position

The formation is a starting point for decisions.

HB-02 White chooses Be2

Quiet opponents can win by restricting every break.

HB-03 White develops Be3 and Qd2

Identify the opponent's king choice before fixing yours.

HB-04 White fianchettoes the king bishop

Opening a diagonal can activate both bishops.

HB-05 White keeps the c-pawn on c2

Watch the next central expansion, not only the current one.

HB-06 An early queen exchange option

Once the center opens, leave the formation mindset.

Repertoire map / 2

LARGE CENTERS AND EARLY PAWN ATTACKS

Start with HB-07. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

HB-07 The three-pawn center

More opposing space demands earlier central action.

HB-08 The four-pawn center

Against four pawns, finish development and challenge them.

HB-09 The Austrian-style f4 center

Counterplay must arrive before the center breaks open.

HB-10 An immediate h-pawn attack

Stopping one lever creates a new contact to monitor.

HB-11 White plays g4 early

Counter a wing attack through the center when it is safe.

HB-12 White advances e5 early

Respond to a central break immediately.

Repertoire map / 3

OTHER FIRST MOVES AND POSITIONAL SYSTEMS

Start with HB-13. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

HB-13 Against the London bishop

The bishop on f4 changes the e5 square.

HB-14 Against the Colle structure

A prepared e4 changes the pace of the game.

HB-15 Against the English Opening

Flexible opposing pawns require flexible development.

HB-16 Against the Reti

Expect the opponent to change structures.

HB-17 Against the Bird

Identify which central square the f-pawn supports.

HB-18 Against 1.b3

Check the long diagonal before completing a fianchetto.

Repertoire map / 4

PAWN-BREAK CHOICES AND PARTIAL FORMATIONS

Start with HB-19. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

HB-19 Prepare ...c5 with development

Prepare the break and calculate its consequences.

HB-20 Use ...d5 to challenge e4

A central break is a concrete transformation, not a slogan.

HB-21 White closes with d5

A closed bishop needs a future pawn break.

HB-22 Meet the e5 advance by exchanging

Compare blocking with exchanging before fixing the center.

HB-23 A queenside space grab with a4

If a break is restrained, choose another useful plan.

HB-24 White tries Bh6

Check the knight's square before a queen recapture.

Building the formation against a classical center

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HB-01 - This illustrative route shows the recognizable formation when White develops quietly. The knights avoid blocking the fianchetto bishops, but Black has used many pawn tempi and is still uncastled.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Decide on king safety and a central break. Examine ...c5 against d4 and ...d5 against e4; neither move is compulsory or safe in every version.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White owns more space and can prepare d5, e5 or a wing attack. Finishing the diagram is not a strategic achievement if Black then has no active move.

RECOGNITION TEST

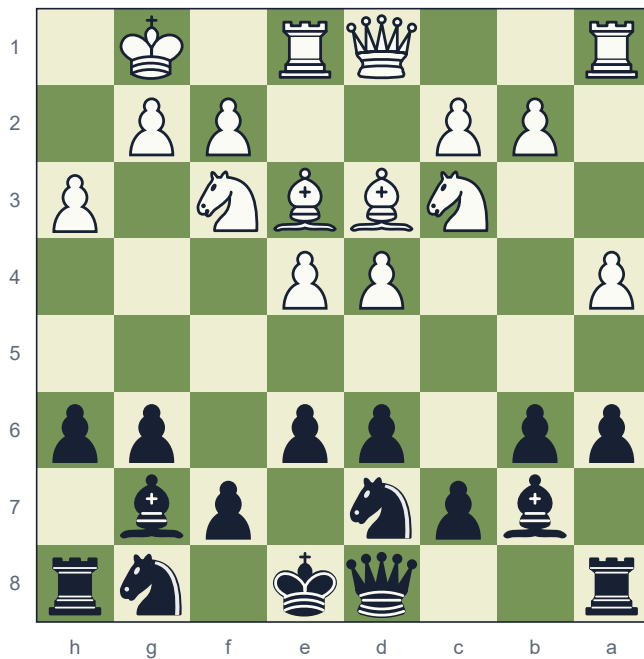
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HB-01 / The full formation as a study position

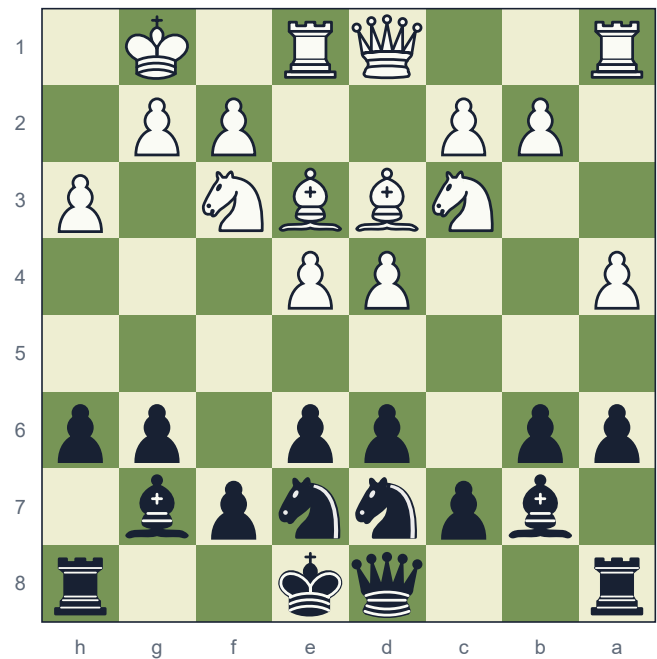
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 a6 5. Bd3 b6 6. O-O Bb7 7. Re1 e6 8. a4 Nd7 9. h3 h6 10. Be3 Ne7

The anchor is the complete printed sequence.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

This illustrative route shows the recognizable formation when White develops quietly. The knights avoid blocking the fianchetto bishops, but Black has used many pawn tempi and is still uncastled.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Decide on king safety and a central break. Examine ...c5 against d4 and ...d5 against e4; neither move is compulsory or safe in every version.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White owns more space and can prepare d5, e5 or a wing attack. Finishing the diagram is not a strategic achievement if Black then has no active move.

REMEMBER The formation is a starting point for decisions.

HB-02 / White chooses Be2

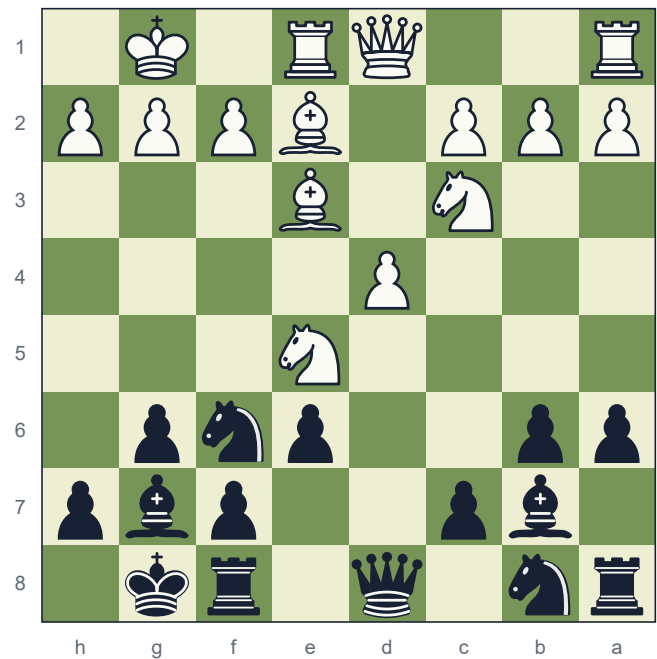
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 a6 5. Be2 b6 6. O-O Bb7 7. Re1 e6 8. Be3 Nf6 9. e5 dxe5 10. Nxe5 O-O

Authored anchor ends after 7... e6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The bishop on e2 is less directly aimed at h7 than on d3, but White can support a central advance without exposing pieces. Black preserves flexibility.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...Nd7 and assess ...Ne7 or ...Nf6 from the actual center. If a central exchange opens a bishop diagonal, calculate it before making another wing pawn move.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White may use Bf1, a4 and d5 to squeeze. A lack of immediate threats is not permission for unlimited waiting.

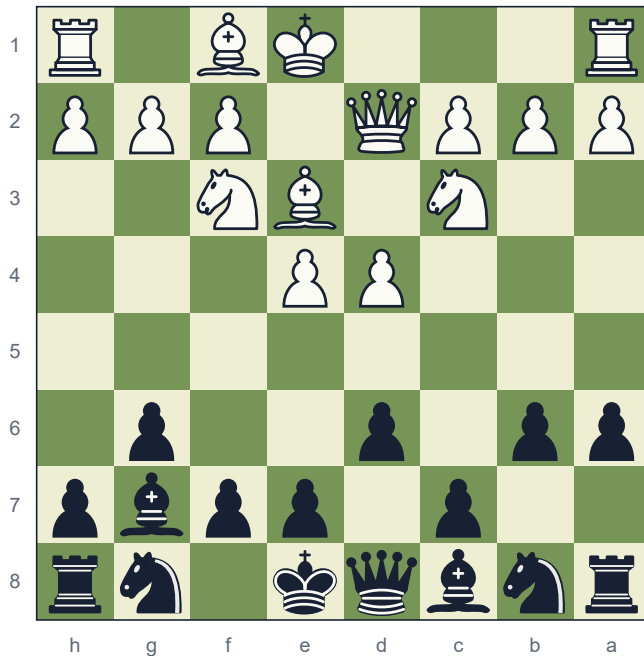
REMEMBER Quiet opponents can win by restricting every break.

HB-03 / White develops Be3 and Qd2

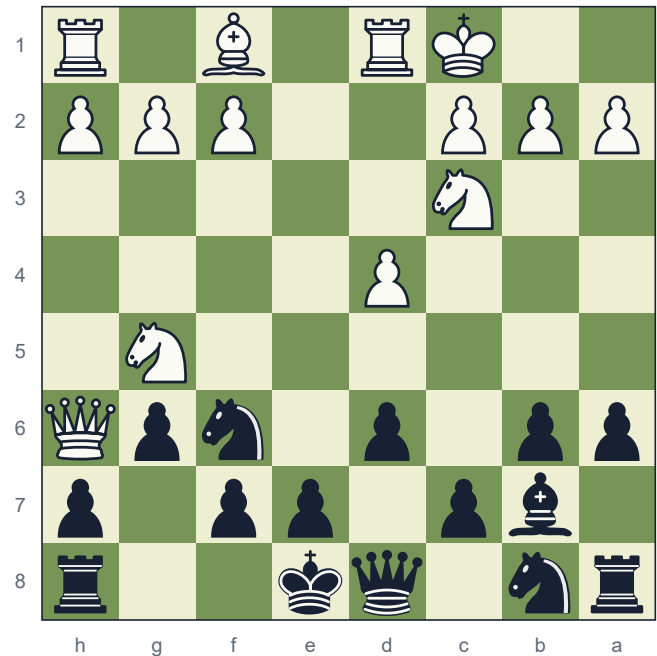
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 a6 5. Qd2 b6 6. Nf3 Bb7 7. O-O-O Nf6 8. Bh6 Bxh6 9. Qxh6 Bxe4 10. Ng5 Bb7

Authored anchor ends after 6... Bb7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White prepares flexible castling and may seek Bh6 to exchange the g7 bishop. Black must notice the attacking setup before automatically playing ...h6.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare ...e6 and ...Nd7 while choosing a safe king destination. If Bh6 is possible, decide whether to exchange, retreat or create central counterplay.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can castle long and push h4. Removing the fianchetto bishop may weaken dark squares around a castled black king.

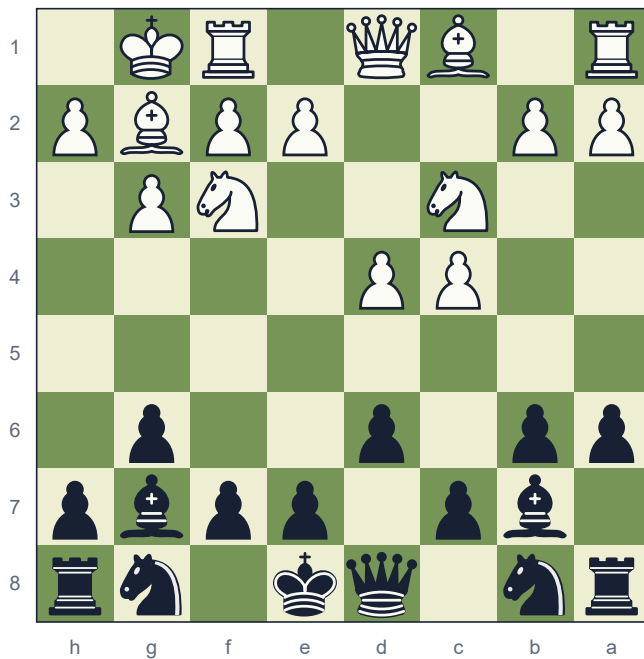
REMEMBER Identify the opponent's king choice before fixing yours.

HB-04 / White fianchettoes the king bishop

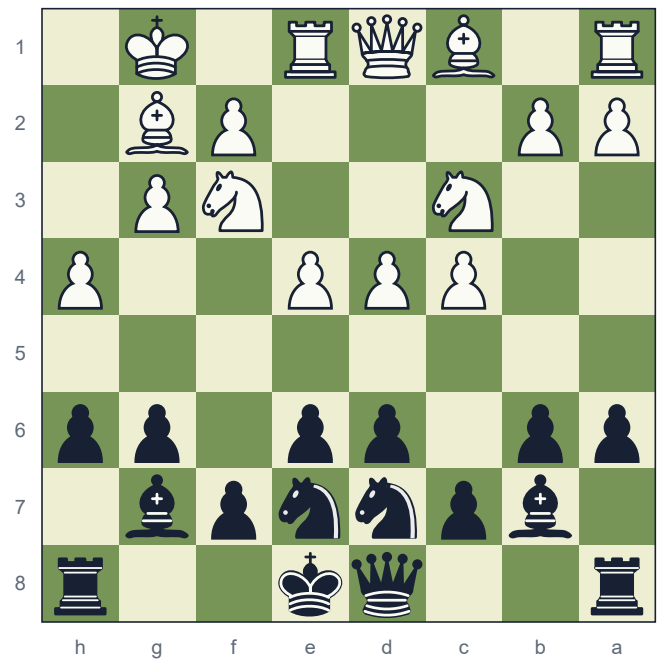
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nf3 d6 4. g3 a6 5. Bg2 b6 6. O-O Bb7 7. Nc3 e6 8. e4 Nd7 9. Re1 h6 10. h4 Ne7

Authored anchor ends after 7... e6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Both sides have long-diagonal bishops, but White has more central space. The g2 bishop creates pressure against b7 when the center opens.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop knights and prepare a break that releases your own bishops. Re-count b7 and e4 pressure after each central pawn exchange.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can advance d5 or e4 with good support. A quiet fianchetto can still produce a strong squeeze.

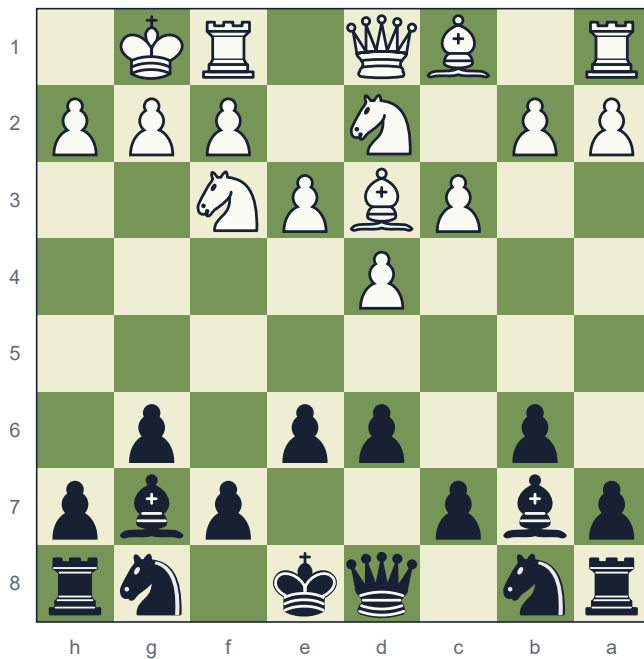
REMEMBER Opening a diagonal can activate both bishops.

HB-05 / White keeps the c-pawn on c2

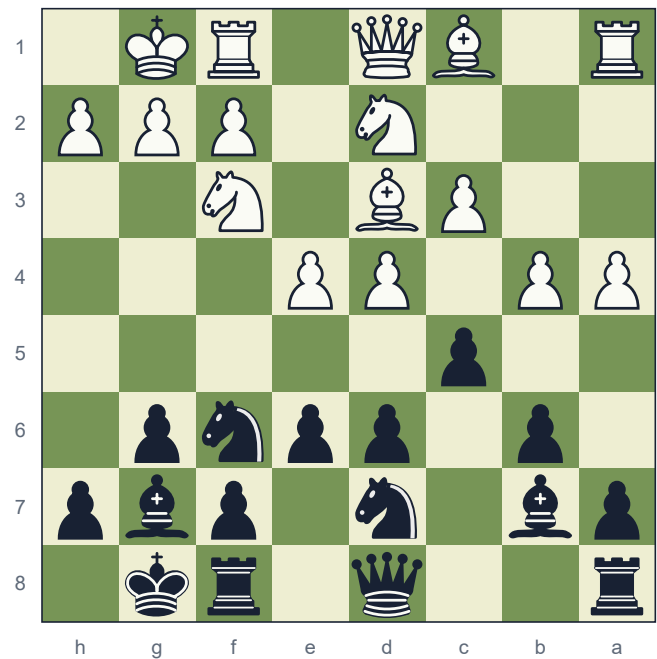
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. e3 d6 4. Bd3 b6 5. O-O Bb7 6. Nbd2 e6 7. c3 Nd7 8. e4 Ngf6 9. a4 O-O 10. b4 c5

Authored anchor ends after 7... Nd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Without c4 White has less queenside space but a compact center. Black can develop flexibly and often challenge d4 with ...c5.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Decide whether the f8 knight belongs on e7 or f6. Prepare castling and use ...c5 when the resulting exchanges do not expose your king.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

e4 can suddenly build a broad center and threaten e5. The modest e3 setup may be a preparation rather than a permanent concession.

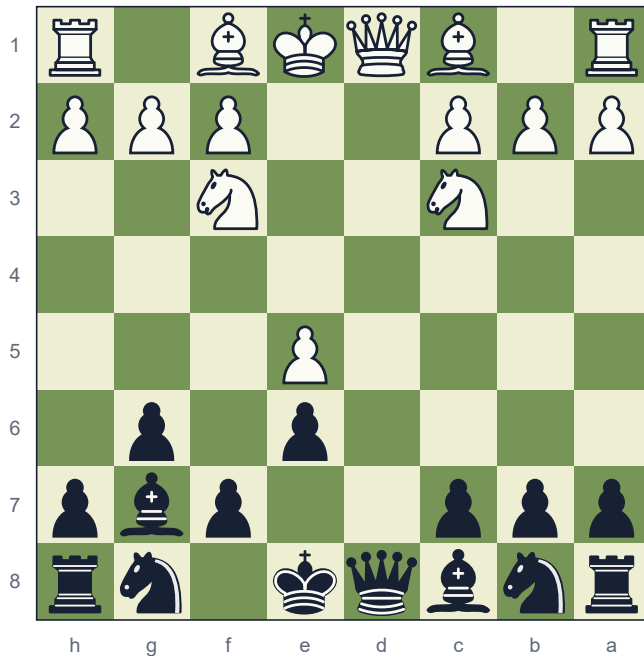
REMEMBER Watch the next central expansion, not only the current one.

HB-06 / An early queen exchange option

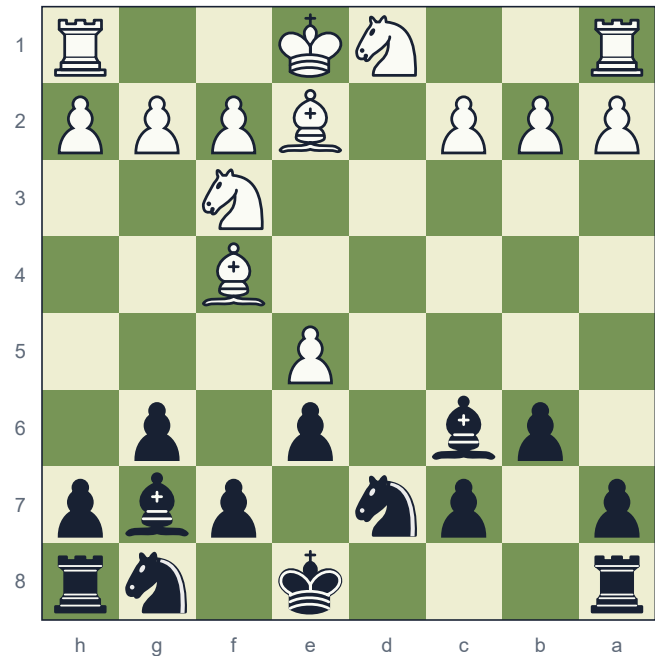
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. e5 dxe5 6. dxe5 Qxd1+ 7. Nxd1 b6 8. Bb5+ Bd7 9. Be2 Bc6 10. Bf4 Nd7

Authored anchor ends after 7. Nxd1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Central exchanges can open the d-file and permit a queen trade. Black is no longer building a full Hippo and should value development and king activity accordingly.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the pieces toward active squares and target the advanced e5 pawn if possible. Do not continue irrelevant wing pawn moves after the position has opened.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White retains space and can develop quickly. Queenless positions still punish undeveloped pieces and weak pawns.

REMEMBER Once the center opens, leave the formation mindset.

Work through HB-01

7... E6

Supports a restrained central formation and opens one bishop diagonal while possibly blocking another. Plan the later pawn break.

8... ND7

Develops a knight toward central supporting squares. Keep a useful onward route so the compact setup does not become overcrowded.

9... H6

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

10... NE7

Develops the king knight while keeping the f-pawn flexible. It may support a central break or move toward g6 or c6 if safe.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

This illustrative route shows the recognizable formation when White develops quietly. The knights avoid blocking the fianchetto bishops, but Black has used many pawn tempi and is still uncastled. Decide on king safety and a central break. Examine ...c5 against d4 and ...d5 against e4; neither move is compulsory or safe in every version.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Large centers and early pawn attacks

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HB-07 - White occupies c4-d4-e4. Black chooses a partial formation and castles instead of insisting on both fianchettoes before addressing the center.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Prepare ...c5 or ...d5 with enough support. A bishop on b7 is useful only if its diagonal and the required tempi justify it.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White can gain more space with d5 or build a kingside attack with f4. Do not add ...a6 and ...h6 automatically under a development deficit.

RECOGNITION TEST

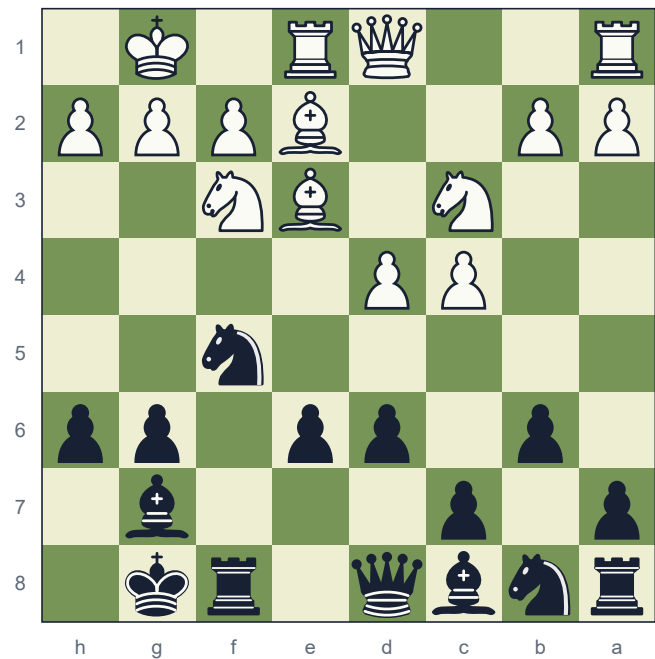
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HB-07 / The three-pawn center

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. c4 d6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Be2 O-O 7. O-O h6 8. Re1 b6 9. Be3 f5 10. exf5 Nxf5

Authored anchor ends after 7. O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White occupies c4-d4-e4. Black chooses a partial formation and castles instead of insisting on both fianchettoes before addressing the center.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Prepare ...c5 or ...d5 with enough support. A bishop on b7 is useful only if its diagonal and the required tempi justify it.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can gain more space with d5 or build a kingside attack with f4. Do not add ...a6 and ...h6 automatically under a development deficit.

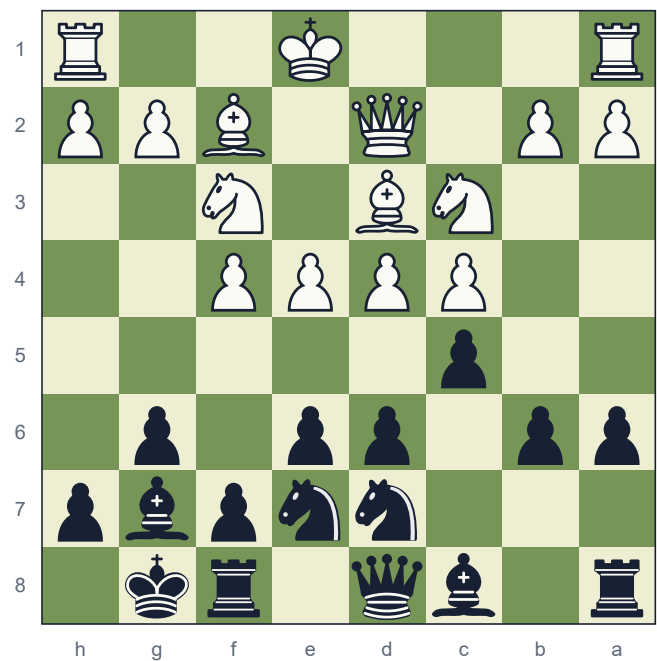
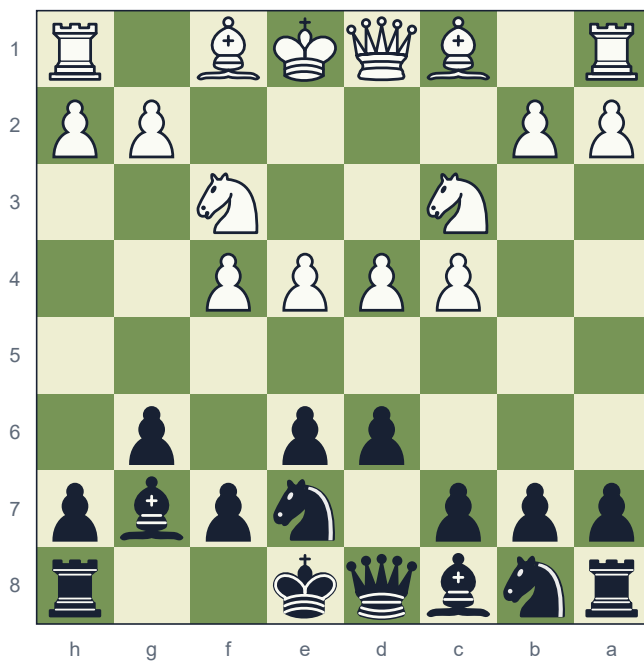
REMEMBER More opposing space demands earlier central action.

HB-08 / The four-pawn center

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. c4 d6 4. Nc3 e6 5. f4 Ne7 6. Nf3 O-O 7. Be3 Nd7 8. Qd2 a6 9. Bf2 b6 10. Bd3 c5

Authored anchor ends after 6... O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White adds f4 and may push e5 or f5. Black prioritizes development and king safety; a full Hippo is not the automatic answer.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Challenge the center with ...c5 when ready, then calculate d5 and exchanges. Keep pieces aimed at the pawn chain rather than retreating without a plan.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White's attack may become dangerous if allowed to consolidate every pawn. You need a break, not merely a compact-looking position.

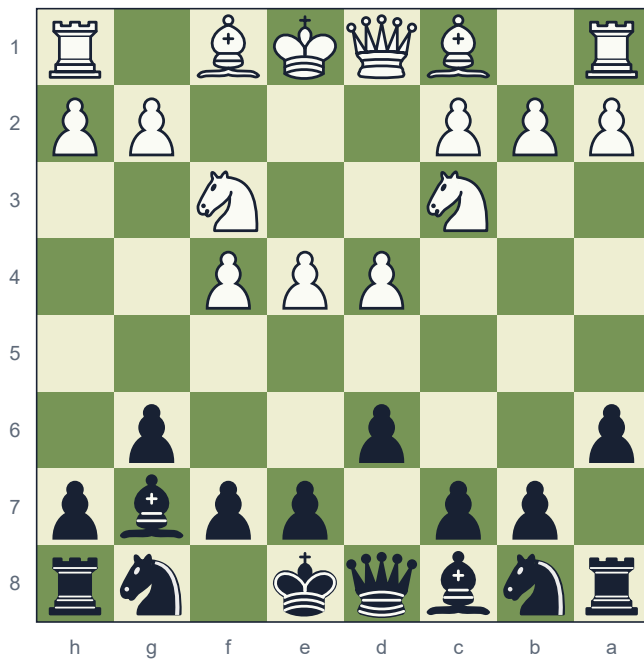
REMEMBER Against four pawns, finish development and challenge them.

HB-09 / The Austrian-style f4 center

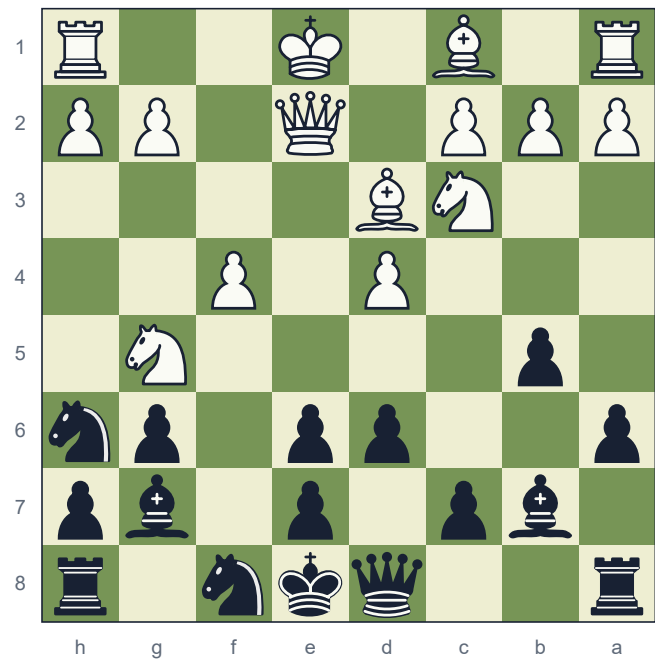
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 a6 5. Nf3 b5 6. Bd3 Bb7 7. Qe2 Nd7 8. e5 Nh6 9. e6 fxe6 10. Ng5 Nf8

Authored anchor ends after 5... b5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black uses a partial formation with immediate queenside activity. ...b5 aims for ...Bb7 and may question Nc3 with ...b4; it is a concrete response to White's central ambition.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the bishop and calculate e5 before each slow move. If the center opens, choose piece development and king safety over completing the usual pawn bank.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

e5 can arrive with tempo against Black's pieces. A queenside expansion does not excuse ignoring the central breakthrough.

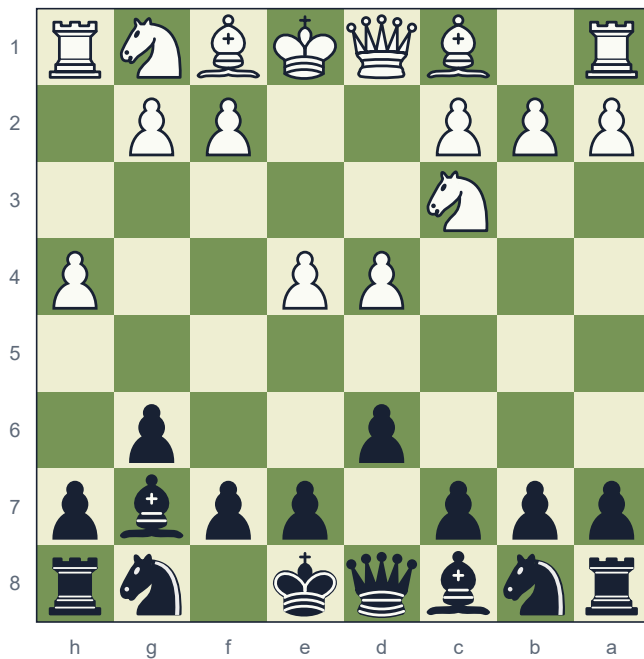
REMEMBER Counterplay must arrive before the center breaks open.

HB-10 / An immediate h-pawn attack

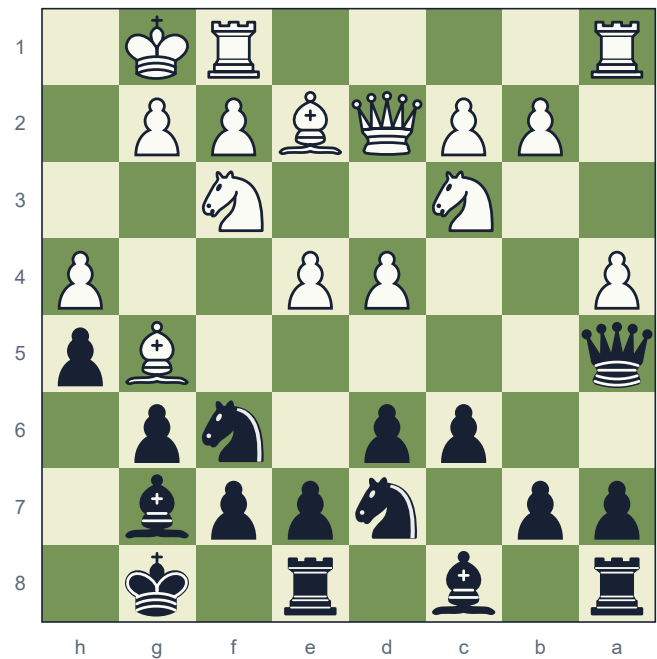
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. h4 h5 5. Bg5 Nf6 6. Qd2 c6 7. a4 Nbd7 8. Be2 Qa5 9. Nf3 O-O 10. O-O Re8

Authored anchor ends after 4... h5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

...h5 stops the immediate h4-h5 lever. Black accepts a fixed kingside structure rather than allowing White to open the h-file by force.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop while watching g4 and the central breaks. Keep the king flexible until you know whether the h-file will open.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

g4 can attack the new h5 hook. A blocked h-pawn does not mean the king side is permanently safe.

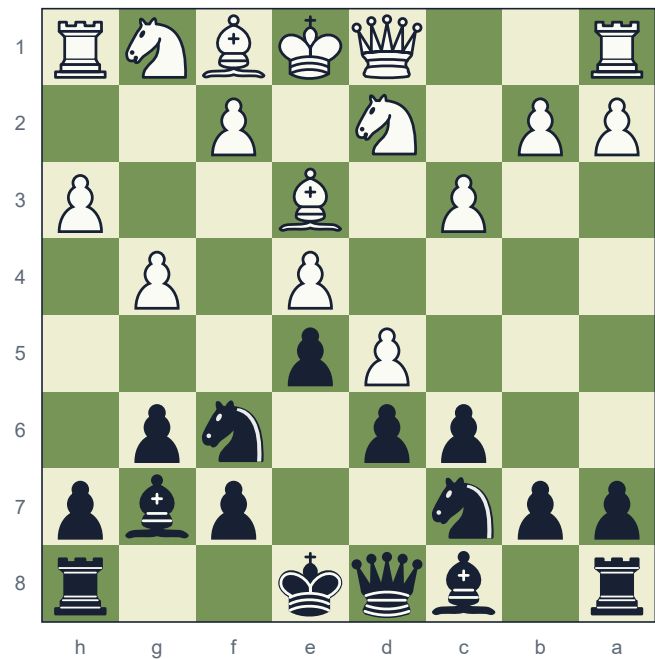
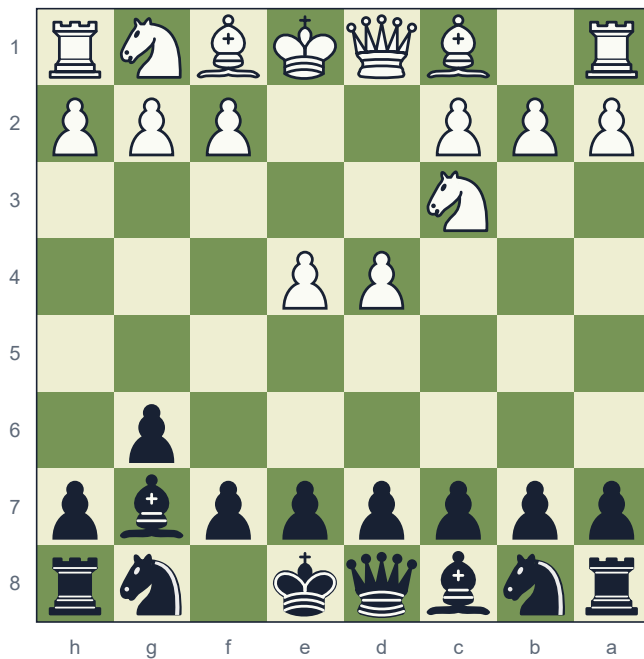
REMEMBER Stopping one lever creates a new contact to monitor.

HB-11 / White plays g4 early

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. g4 Nc6 5. d5 Nd4 6. h3 e5 7. Nb1 c6 8. c3 Nb5 9. Be3 Nf6 10. Nd2 Nc7

Authored anchor ends after 4. g4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White spends time on a wing attack before completing development. Black must calculate central action instead of reacting only on the attacked wing.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Examine ...c5 or ...h5, checking captures and king safety. Develop with threats when possible; the center is the natural place to test a premature wing expansion.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A careless ...h6 can provide the exact hook White wants. Do not complete a decorative pawn wall while the g-pawn advances.

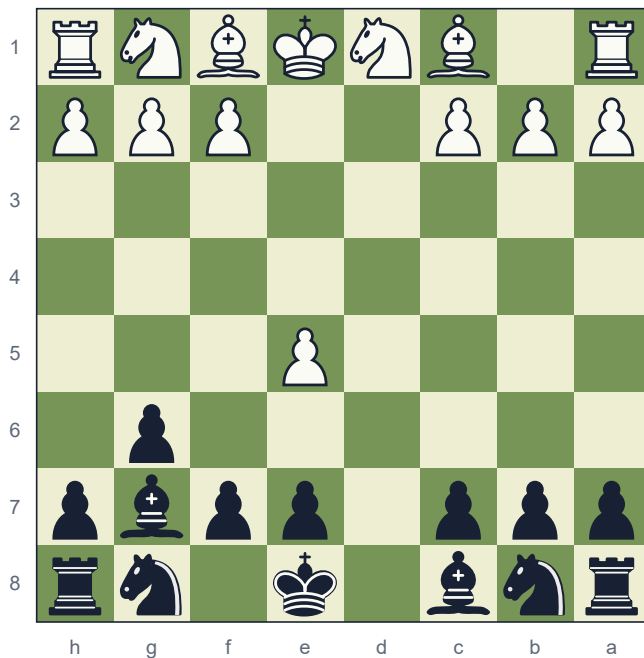
REMEMBER Counter a wing attack through the center when it is safe.

HB-12 / White advances e5 early

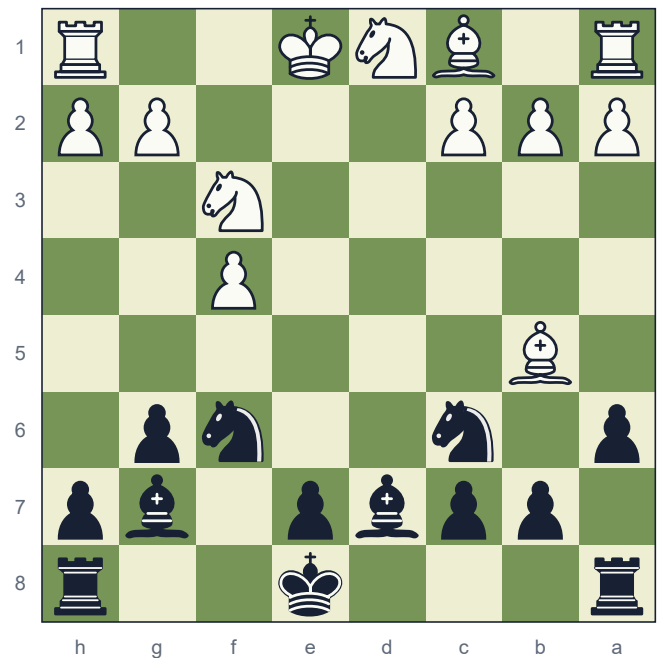
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e5 dxe5 5. dxe5 Qxd1+ 6. Nxd1 Nc6 7. f4 f6 8. Bb5 Bd7 9. exf6 Nxf6 10. Nf3 a6

Authored anchor ends after 6... Nc6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black opens the center and trades queens, then develops with pressure on e5. The immediate central decision takes precedence over any plan to double fianchetto.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop actively and coordinate pieces against e5. Compare a useful capture with a developing move instead of trying to recreate the original pawn structure.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can defend e5 and use the space advantage. A queen trade is a transition to a playable struggle, not proof that Black has won a pawn.

REMEMBER Respond to a central break immediately.

Work through HB-07

7... H6

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

8... B6

Prepares a fianchetto and changes the long diagonal. Check the bishop and corner rook before assuming the next developing move is safe.

9... F5

Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

10... NXF5

The knight captures a pawn on f5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

White occupies c4-d4-e4. Black chooses a partial formation and castles instead of insisting on both fianchettos before addressing the center. Prepare ...c5 or ...d5 with enough support. A bishop on b7 is useful only if its diagonal and the required tempi justify it.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Other first moves and positional systems

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HB-13 - White's bishop develops outside the pawn chain and may support e5. Black uses the double fianchetto while keeping the central break flexible.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop the king knight and decide between ...c5 and ...e5. Count the support of e5 before allowing a white knight or pawn there.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White can use Nbd2, c3 and e4 to expand. The London label does not guarantee that White will remain passive.

RECOGNITION TEST

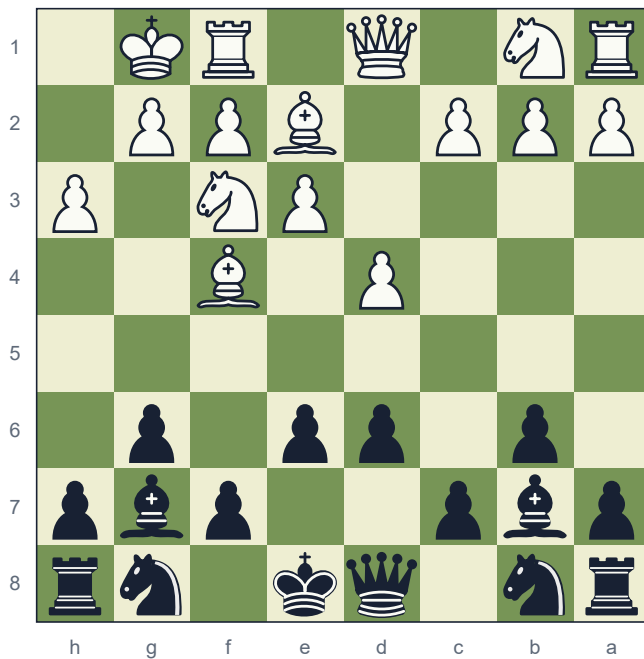
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HB-13 / Against the London bishop

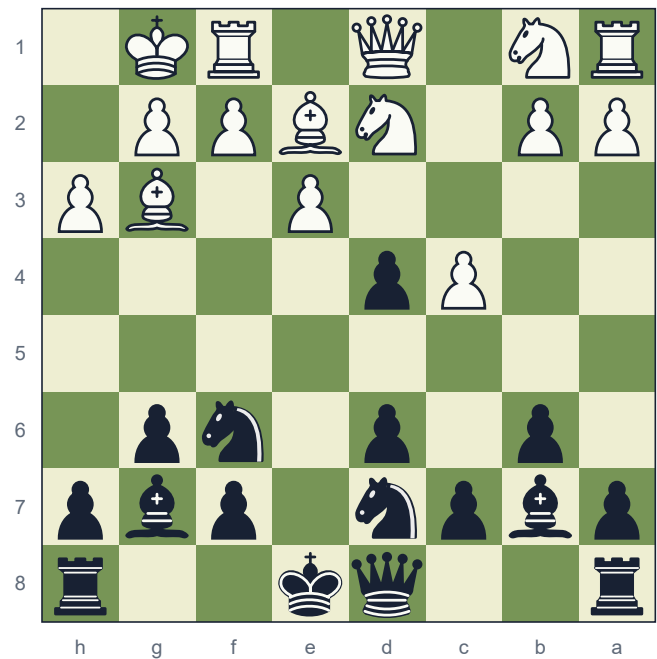
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. Bf4 d6 4. e3 b6 5. h3 Bb7 6. Be2 e6 7. O-O Nd7 8. c4 Ngf6 9. Nfd2 e5 10. Bg3 exd4

Authored anchor ends after 7... Nd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White's bishop develops outside the pawn chain and may support e5. Black uses the double fianchetto while keeping the central break flexible.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the king knight and decide between ...c5 and ...e5. Count the support of e5 before allowing a white knight or pawn there.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can use Nbd2, c3 and e4 to expand. The London label does not guarantee that White will remain passive.

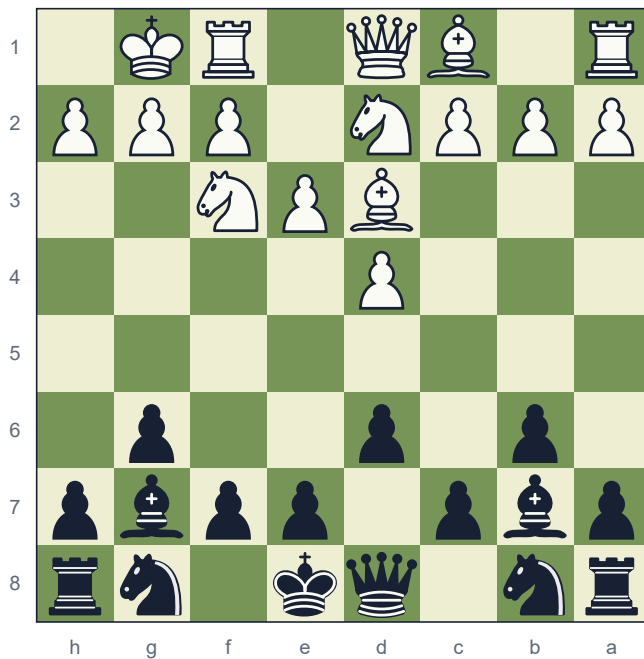
REMEMBER The bishop on f4 changes the e5 square.

HB-14 / Against the Colle structure

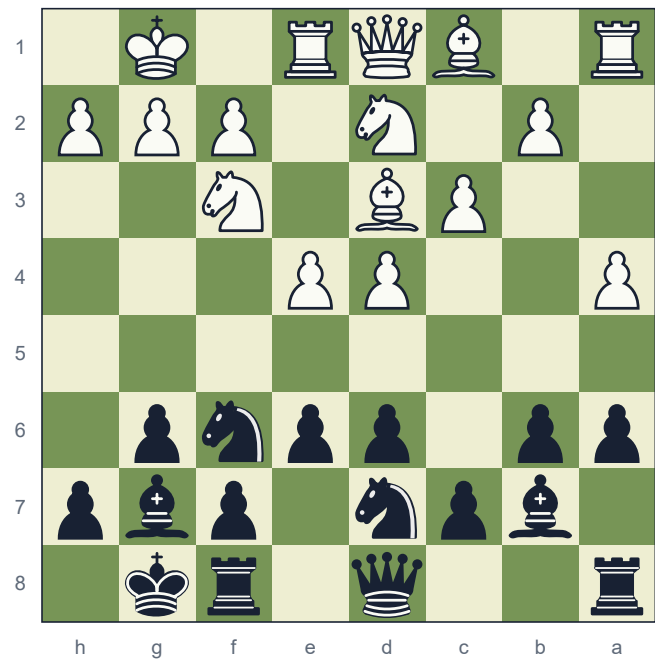
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. e3 d6 4. Bd3 b6 5. O-O Bb7 6. Nbd2 e6 7. e4 Nf6 8. a4 a6 9. Re1 O-O 10. c3 Nbd7

Authored anchor ends after 7. e4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White has achieved e4 and threatens to gain more space. Black must reassess the center at once instead of treating the earlier e3 structure as unchanged.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Consider ...Ne7, ...Nd7 and a timely ...c5, checking e5. If a pawn exchange frees a bishop, compare that activity with the loss of central restraint.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

e5 can attack a developed knight or open attacking diagonals. White's bishop on d3 already aims toward the king side.

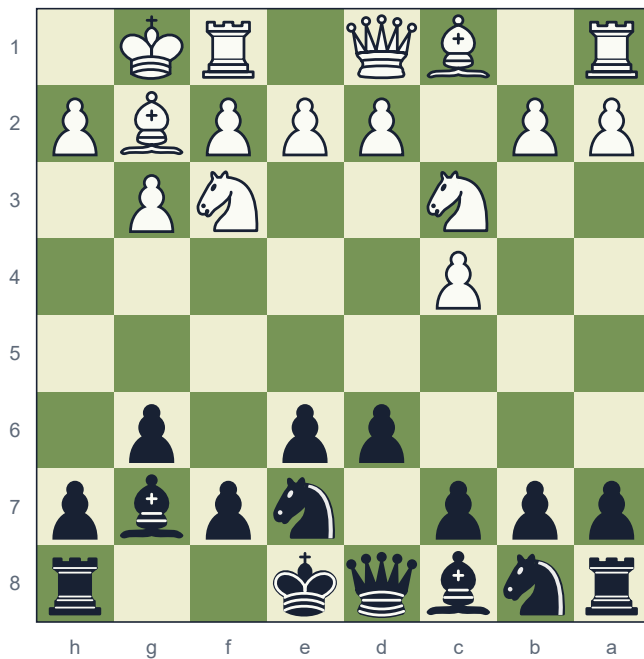
REMEMBER A prepared e4 changes the pace of the game.

HB-15 / Against the English Opening

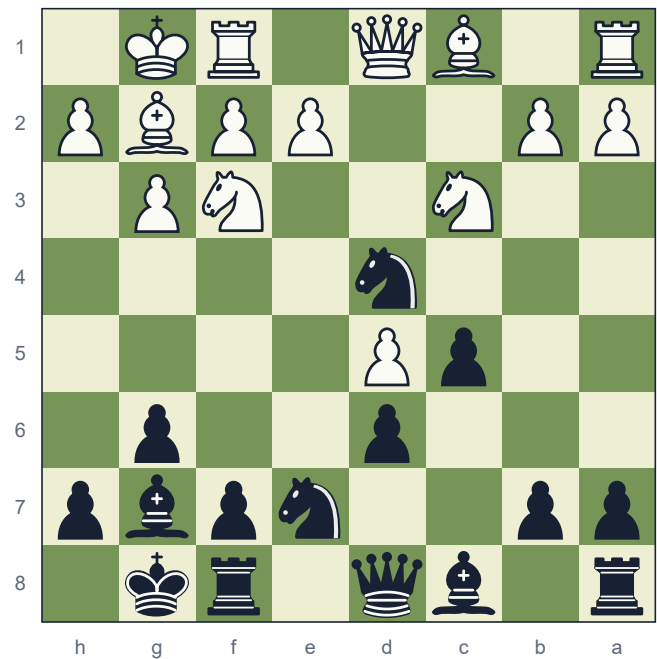
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. c4 g6 2. Nc3 Bg7 3. g3 d6 4. Bg2 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. d3 c5 8. d4 Nbc6 9. d5 exd5 10. cxd5 Nd4

Authored anchor ends after 7. d3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White keeps d4 and e4 flexible. Black can choose a partial Hippo without spending time on both wing pawn pairs.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Decide whether ...c5 produces a useful symmetric structure or ...b6 adds meaningful diagonal pressure. Keep d5 under observation.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can choose d4 in one move and open the center quickly. A slow complete formation may allow a favorable central transformation for White.

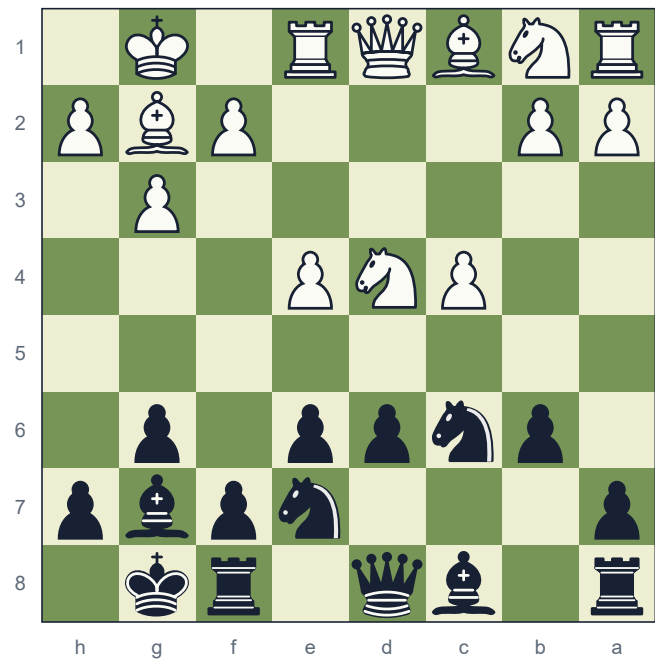
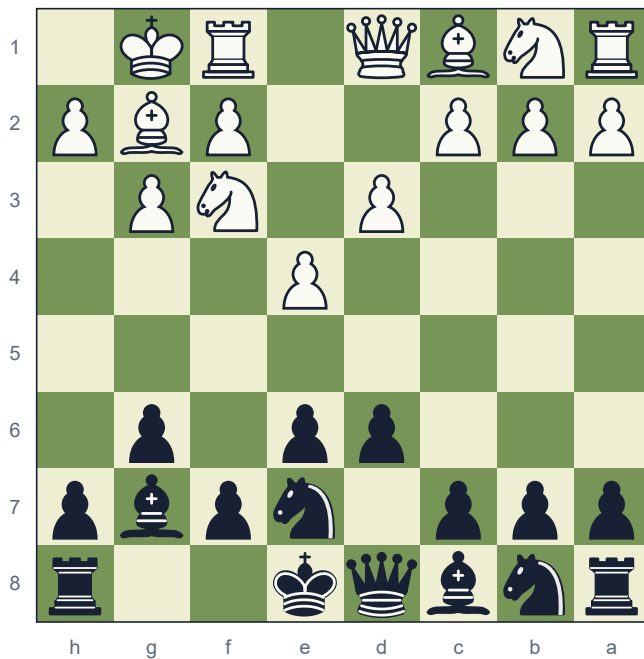
REMEMBER Flexible opposing pawns require flexible development.

HB-16 / Against the Reti

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 g6 2. g3 Bg7 3. Bg2 d6 4. O-O e6 5. d3 Ne7 6. e4 b6 7. d4 O-O 8. Re1 c5 9. c4 cxd4 10. Nxd4 Nbc6

Authored anchor ends after 6... b6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White adopts a King's Indian Attack shape. Black can double fianchetto but should watch whether e5 would gain space with a useful tempo.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...Bb7 and ...Nd7, then choose a central break. If White remains restrained, improve pieces before deciding the king side.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White may switch to c4 or e5 depending on Black's center. The system is not immune to a change of plan.

REMEMBER Expect the opponent to change structures.

HB-17 / Against the Bird

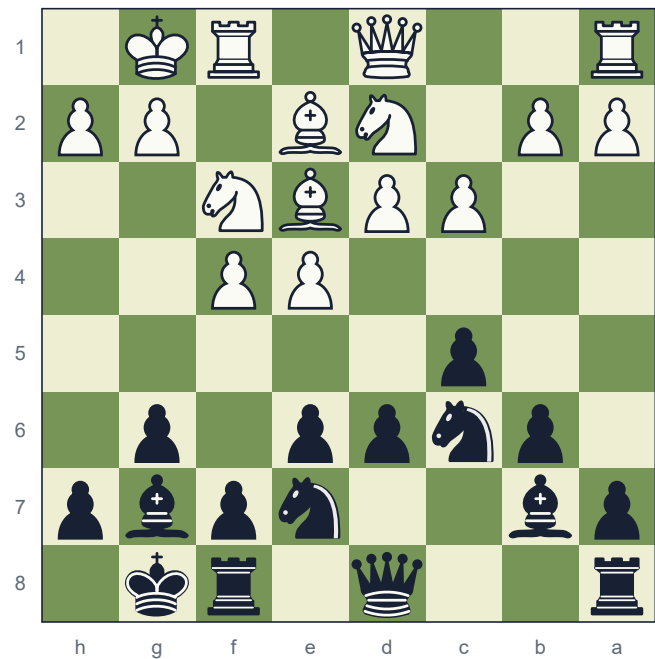
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. f4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. e3 d6 4. Be2 e6 5. O-O Ne7 6. d3 b6 7. c3 Bb7 8. e4 O-O 9. Be3 c5 10. Nbd2 Nbc6

Authored anchor ends after 6... b6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White's f-pawn gives kingside space but also changes the e3 and e4 squares. Black's g7 bishop can become useful against the long diagonal.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...Bb7 and ...Nd7 while preparing ...c5 or ...e5. Calculate the capture on e5 if both sides contest it.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can push e4 and f5. Do not wait until every break has become difficult.

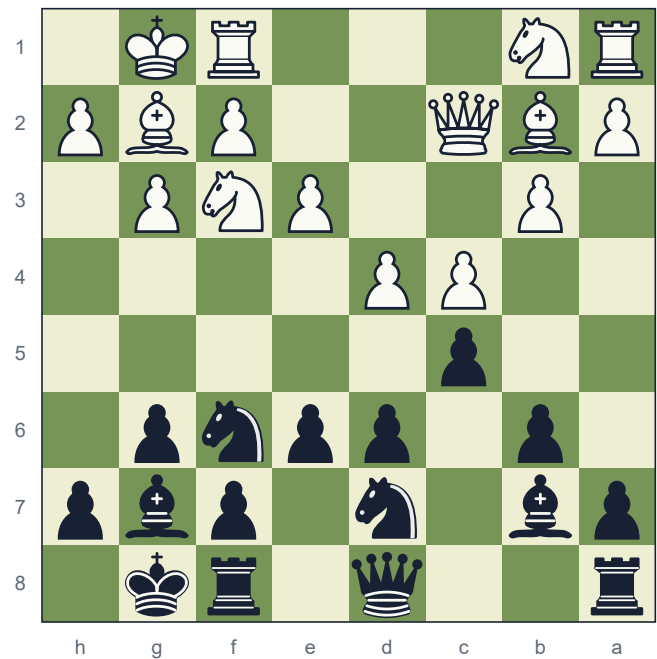
REMEMBER Identify which central square the f-pawn supports.

HB-18 / Against 1.b3

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. b3 g6 2. Bb2 Nf6 3. e3 Bg7 4. Nf3 d6 5. d4 e6 6. g3 b6 7. Bg2 Bb7 8. O-O O-O 9. c4 Nbd7 10. Qc2 c5

Authored anchor ends after 5... e6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

The bishop on b2 already attacks g7 along an open diagonal. Black first develops Nf6 to block that line before placing an undefended bishop on g7.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the queen side and choose a central break. This move order uses Nf6 instead of the standard Ne7 because a concrete threat determines the piece placement.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Playing ...Bg7 immediately after Bb2 would simply leave that bishop en prise. A normal-looking fianchetto is not safe in every move order.

REMEMBER Check the long diagonal before completing a fianchetto.

Work through HB-13

7... ND7

Develops a knight toward central supporting squares. Keep a useful onward route so the compact setup does not become overcrowded.

8... NGF6

Places the knight on f6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

9... E5

Places the pawn on e5, attacking bishop on f4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

10... EXD4

The pawn captures a pawn on d4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

White's bishop develops outside the pawn chain and may support e5. Black uses the double fianchetto while keeping the central break flexible. Develop the king knight and decide between ...c5 and ...e5. Count the support of e5 before allowing a white knight or pawn there.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Pawn-break choices and partial formations

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HB-19 - Black develops the queen knight before forcing a central break. In this exact position an immediate ...c5 allows strong white play; a thematic move still needs preparation.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Compare ...c5 and ...d5 on the next move after checking White's reply. If ...c5 becomes safe, calculate dxc5 and d5 separately and identify the opened file.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White can improve with Qd2 or advance in the center. Do not assume that a break becomes good simply because it belongs to the opening's vocabulary.

RECOGNITION TEST

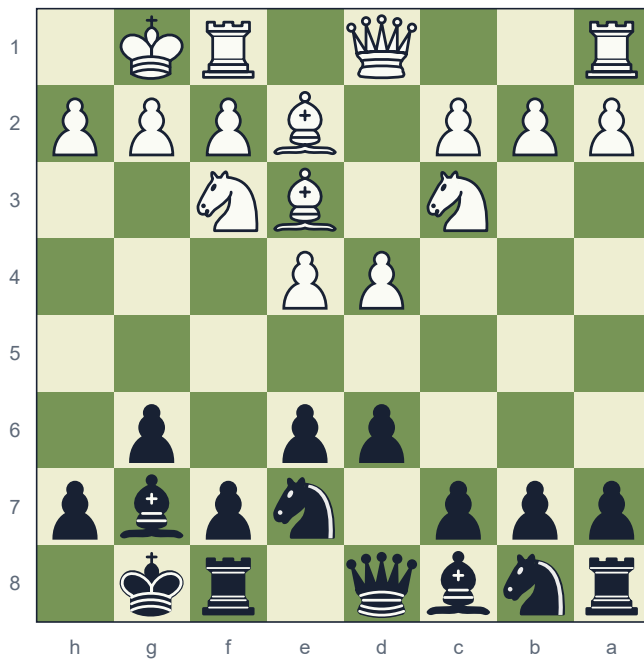
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HB-19 / Prepare ...c5 with development

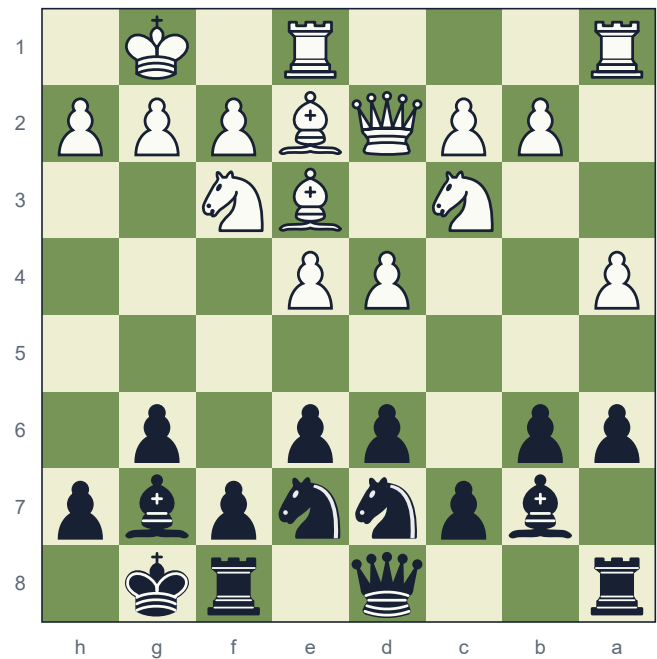
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Be2 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Be3 Nd7 8. Qd2 a6 9. a4 b6 10. Rfe1 Bb7

Authored anchor ends after 7... Nd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black develops the queen knight before forcing a central break. In this exact position an immediate ...c5 allows strong white play; a thematic move still needs preparation.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare ...c5 and ...d5 on the next move after checking White's reply. If ...c5 becomes safe, calculate dxc5 and d5 separately and identify the opened file.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can improve with Qd2 or advance in the center. Do not assume that a break becomes good simply because it belongs to the opening's vocabulary.

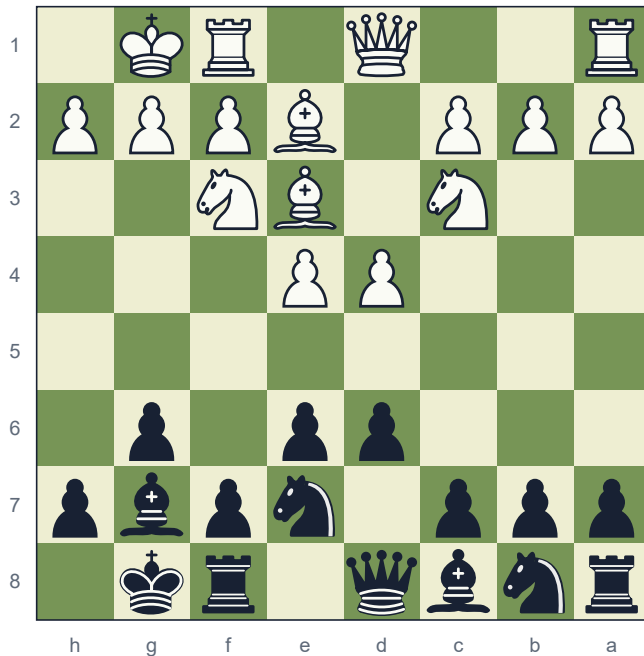
REMEMBER Prepare the break and calculate its consequences.

HB-20 / Use ...d5 to challenge e4

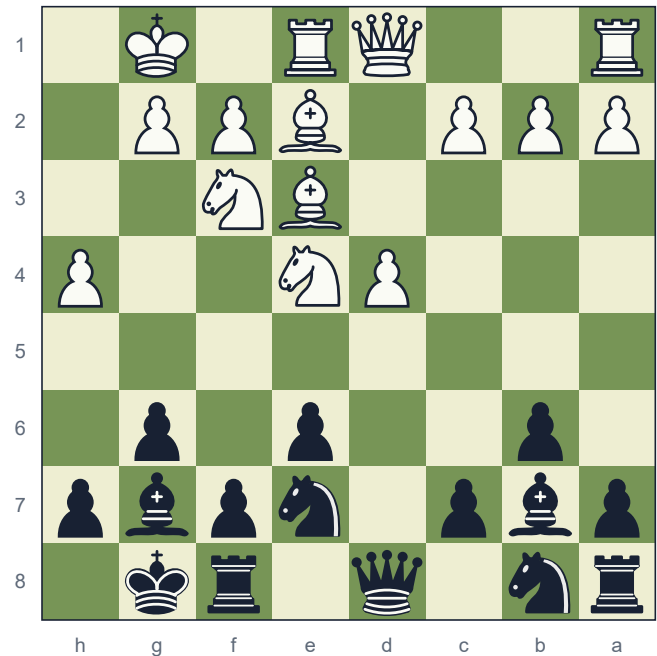
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Be2 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Be3 d5 8. Re1 dxe4 9. Nxe4 b6 10. h4 Bb7

Authored anchor ends after 7... d5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

...d5 directly challenges e4 but creates a new pawn contact and can be captured. Black chooses activity instead of preserving the original d6-e6 shell.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare exd5 and e5, including the effect on the bishops. Reposition pieces toward the opened files instead of clinging to their original squares.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A premature ...d5 can leave a weak isolated pawn or open lines before development is ready. Calculate all forcing replies.

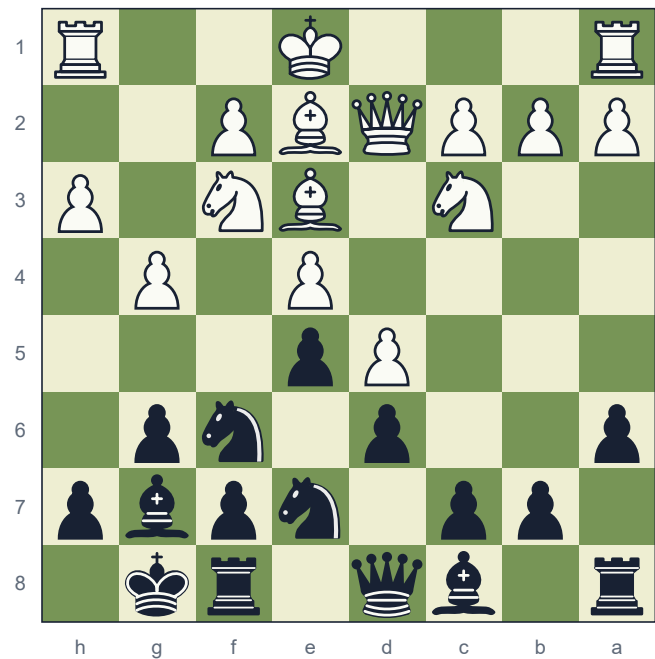
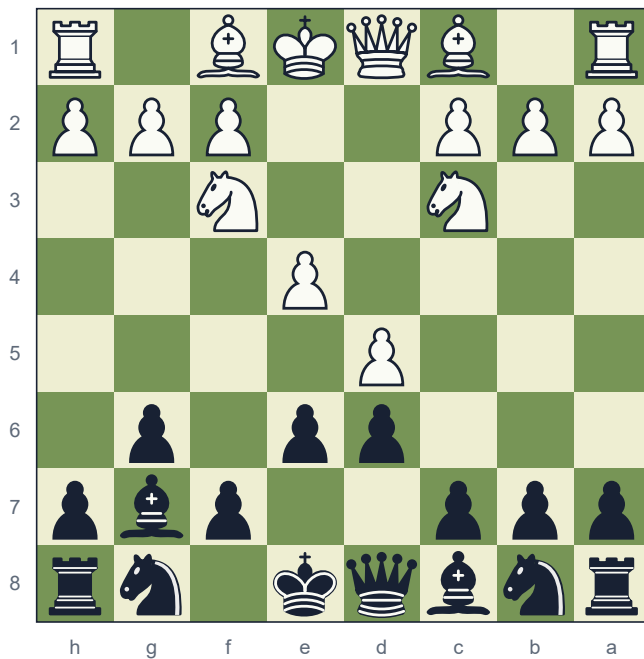
REMEMBER A central break is a concrete transformation, not a slogan.

HB-21 / White closes with d5

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. d5 e5 6. Be2 Ne7 7. Be3 Nd7 8. g4 Nf6 9. h3 O-O 10. Qd2 a6

Authored anchor ends after 5... e5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

Black meets d5 with ...e5 and closes the center. This gives a clear pawn-chain structure but also restricts the g7 bishop.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Consider a later ...f5 after preparation or queenside play with ...c6. Choose the wing based on the pawn chain and king safety.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can expand with c4 and b4 or attack on the king side. A blocked center gives maneuvering time, not unlimited time.

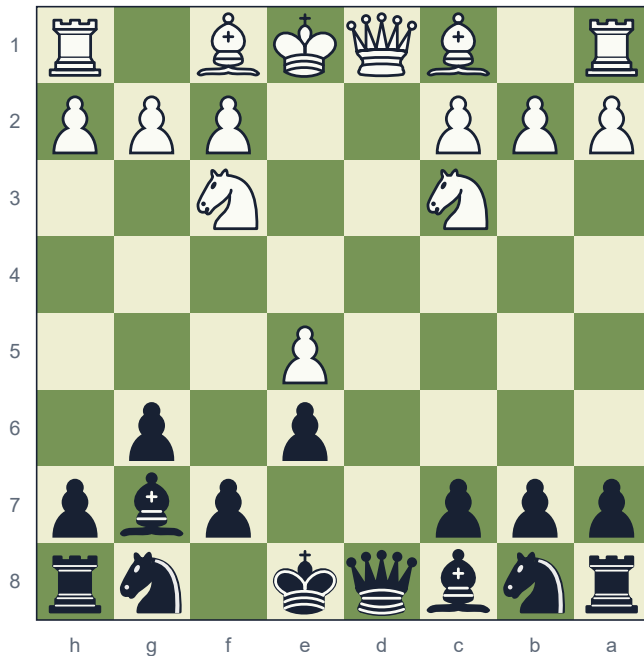
REMEMBER A closed bishop needs a future pawn break.

HB-22 / Meet the e5 advance by exchanging

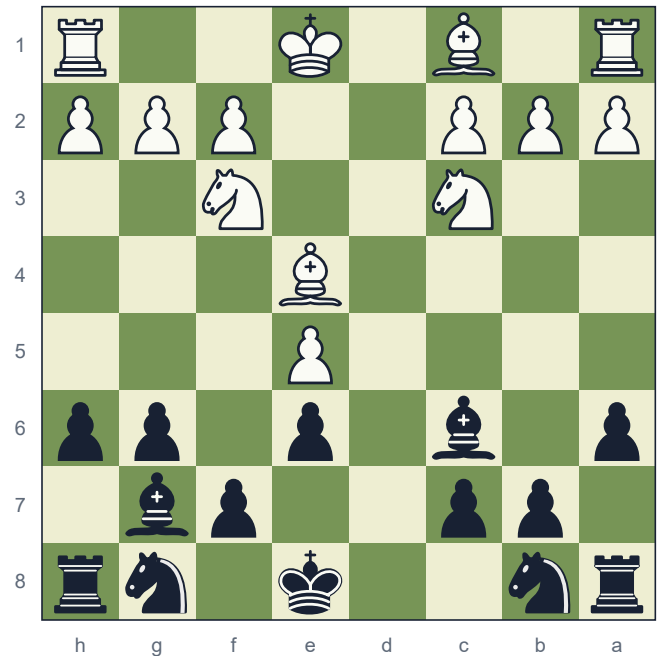
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. e5 dxe5 6. dxe5 Qxd1+ 7. Nxd1 Bd7 8. Nc3 a6 9. Bd3 Bc6 10. Be4 h6

Authored anchor ends after 7. Nxd1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black exchanges the advanced pawn and uses the open d-file to trade queens. In this exact move order, blocking with ...d5 gives White a stronger bind and attacking chances.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop actively and challenge e5 with pieces. King activity and pawn targets now matter more than recreating the full Hippo formation.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White retains space and can consolidate the advanced pawn. A queen trade changes the type of struggle rather than ending it.

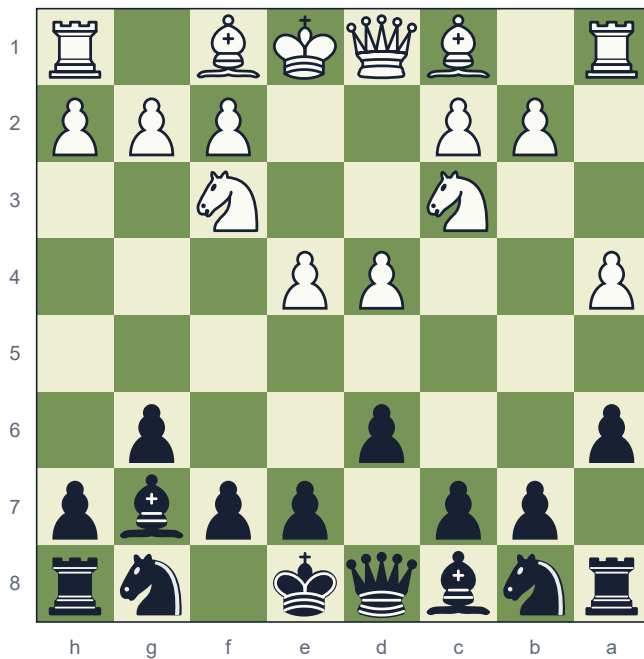
REMEMBER Compare blocking with exchanging before fixing the center.

HB-23 / A queenside space grab with a4

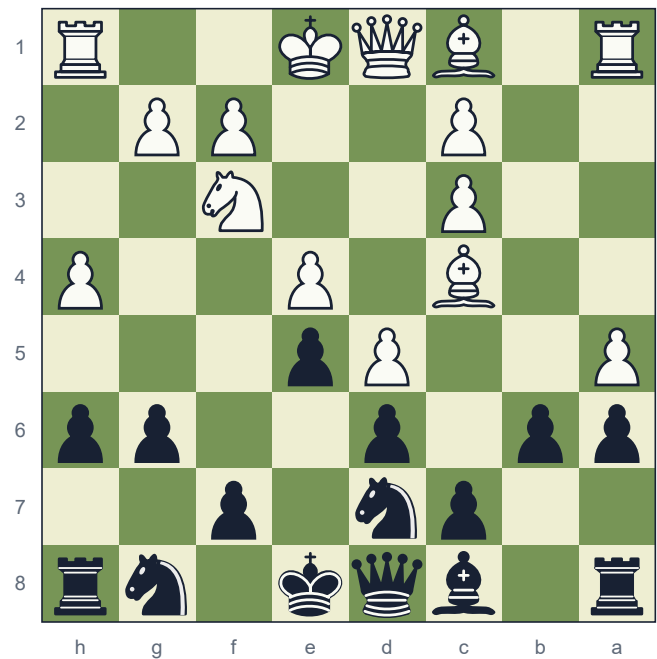
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 a6 5. a4 b6 6. Bc4 e6 7. h4 h6 8. d5 Bxc3+ 9. bxc3 e5 10. a5 Nd7

Authored anchor ends after 5... b6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White restrains ...b5. Black can still develop the bishop through b7, but should not force the pawn advance through a well-controlled square.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop centrally and choose ...c5 or ...d5 when safe. Reconsider whether ...a6 is useful in the resulting structure.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White may use a5 to fix queenside weaknesses. A pawn move intended as flexibility can become a target.

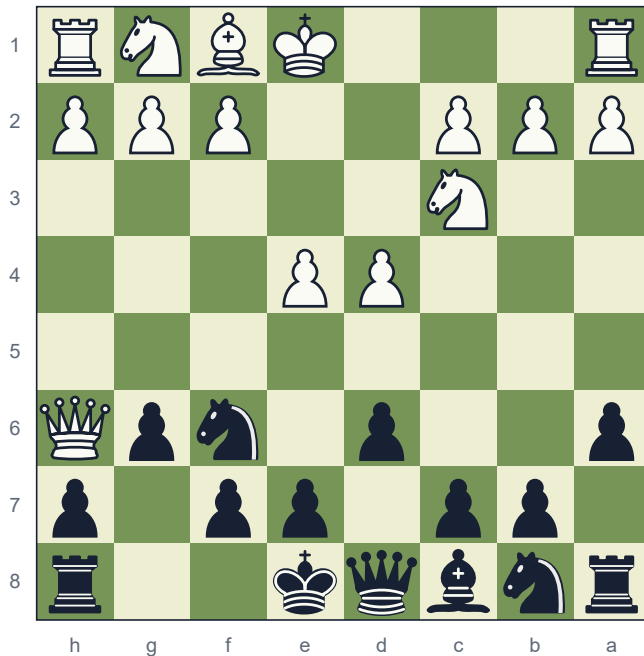
REMEMBER If a break is restrained, choose another useful plan.

HB-24 / White tries Bh6

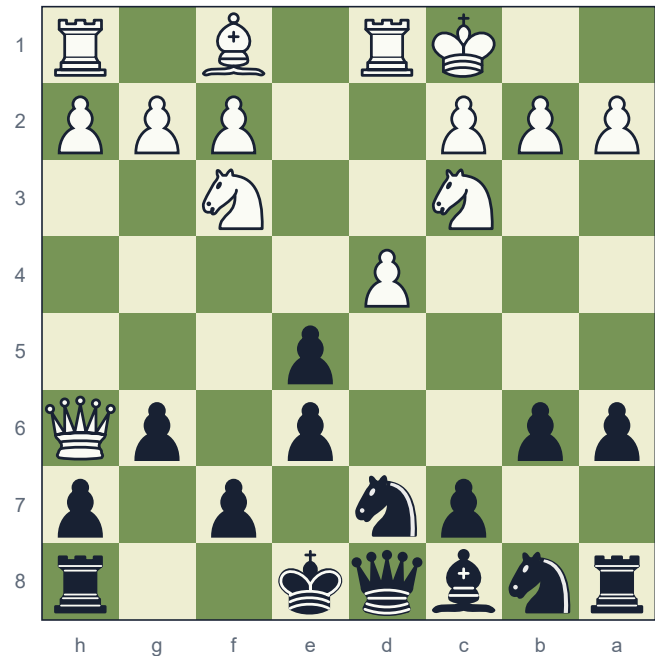
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 a6 5. Qd2 Nf6 6. Bh6 Bxh6 7. Qxh6 b6 8. e5 Nfd7 9. Nf3 e6 10. O-O-O dxe5

Authored anchor ends after 7... b6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black develops Nf6 before this bishop-exchange sequence. White removes the fianchetto bishop and places the queen near the king side, creating a real dark-square concern.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop with attention to king safety and central counterplay. Choose the king's destination from the concrete threats instead of castling automatically toward the queen.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

If the black knight were still on g8, Qxh6 would lose the queen to ...Nxh6. The developed knight is an essential detail in this line.

REMEMBER Check the knight's square before a queen recapture.

Work through HB-19

7... ND7

Develops a knight toward central supporting squares. Keep a useful onward route so the compact setup does not become overcrowded.

8... A6

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

9... B6

Prepares a fianchetto and changes the long diagonal. Check the bishop and corner rook before assuming the next developing move is safe.

10... BB7

Completes the queenside fianchetto and points toward e4. Count the diagonal's blockers before claiming immediate pressure.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Black develops the queen knight before forcing a central break. In this exact position an immediate ...c5 allows strong white play; a thematic move still needs preparation. Compare ...c5 and ...d5 on the next move after checking White's reply. If ...c5 becomes safe, calculate dxc5 and d5 separately and identify the opened file.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

The formation is a menu



HB-01 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

The familiar squares are useful reference points, not compulsory destinations. Black sometimes needs Nf6, ...h5, ...c5 or castling before a second fianchetto.

HOW TO DECIDE

Before each setup move, inspect White's next central advance and forcing threats. Choose the move that meets the position's needs, even if the final board no longer resembles a complete Hippo.

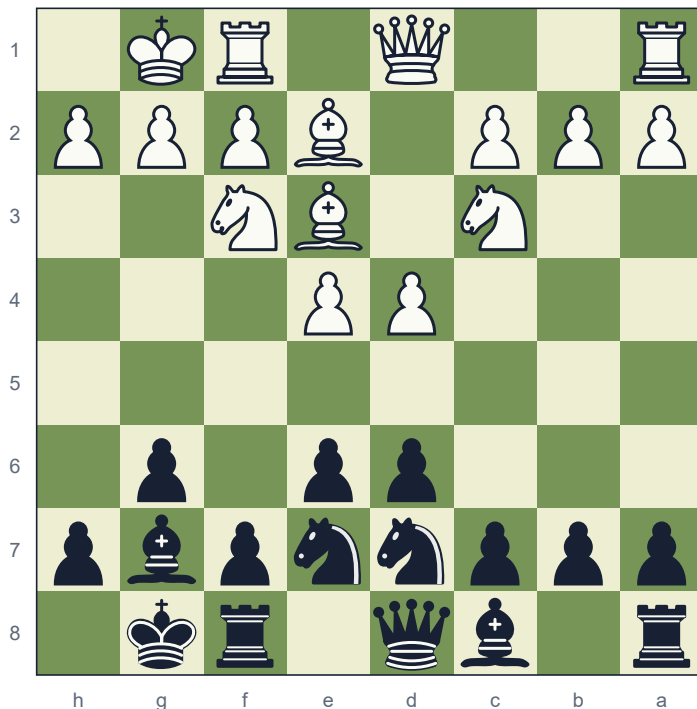
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White can seize space with c4 and f4 or attack with h4. A rigid ten-move script can turn a flexible system into a passive target.

BOARD DRILL

Take three branches and name the first move that departs from the full formation. Explain the concrete reason.

Which central break?



HB-19 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

...c5 challenges d4 from the side; ...d5 challenges e4 directly; ...e5 can close or contest the center; ...f5 is a more committal kingside lever. They are not interchangeable.

HOW TO DECIDE

For each candidate, calculate capture, advance and tension. Ask which bishop opens, which square weakens and whether the king is safe. Prepare the break with pieces when necessary.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White may answer ...c5 with d5 or ...d5 with e5, keeping a space advantage. Your break needs a plan for closure as well as exchanges.

BOARD DRILL

At a quiet endpoint, compare ...c5 and ...d5 in words and short legal variations.

Life with less space



HB-02 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

A compact position leaves fewer squares for pieces. Useful exchanges and timely breaks can relieve pressure; random waiting usually increases it.

HOW TO DECIDE

Identify the least active piece and a realistic route. Do not move it to a square another piece needs unless the exchange or maneuver has a clear benefit.

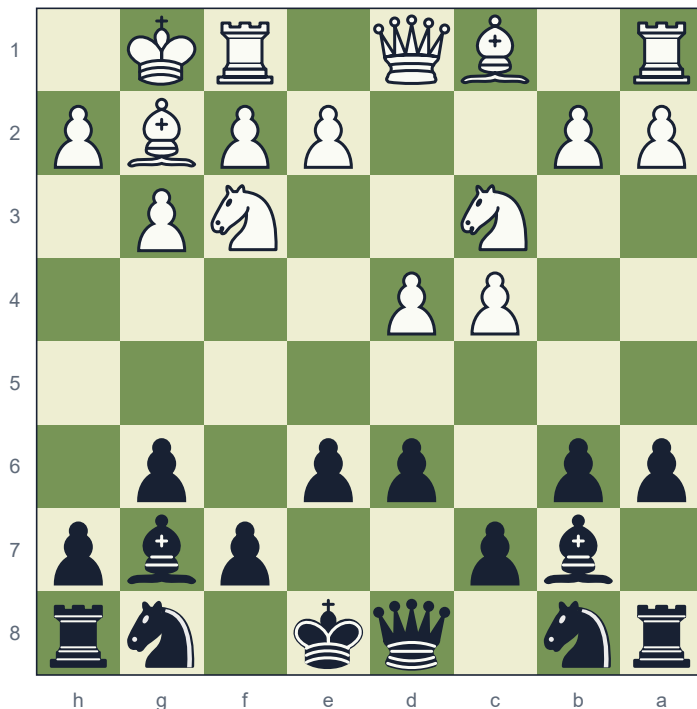
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White can improve every piece before opening the center. The absence of an immediate tactic does not mean Black has unlimited time.

BOARD DRILL

Play ten moves from a restrained endpoint and record whether each move improves a piece, prepares a break or answers a threat.

The two bishops need different openings



HB-04 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

Bb7 points toward e4 and the king side; Bg7 points toward d4 and the queen side. Own pawns may block both diagonals until the center changes.

HOW TO DECIDE

Trace each diagonal to its first blocker. Choose a pawn break that releases the bishop with meaningful targets. Avoid exchanging the active bishop while preserving only the blocked one.

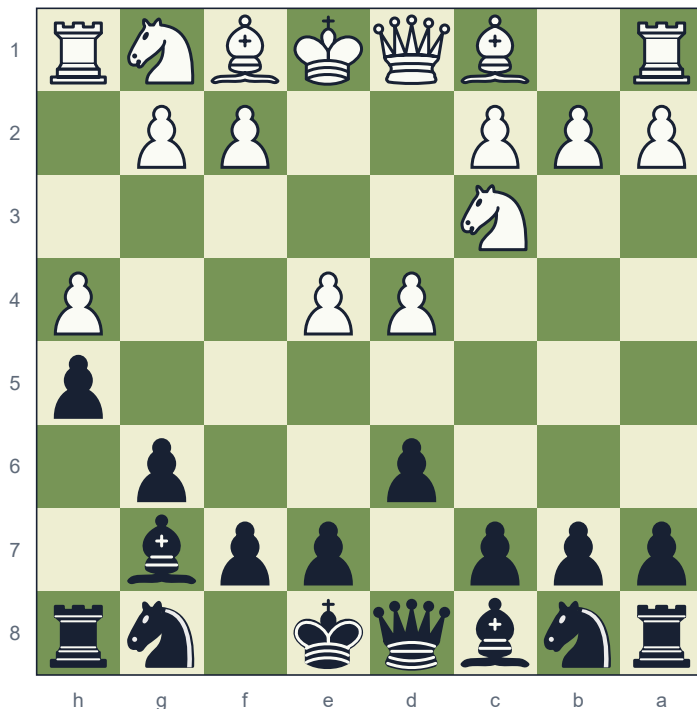
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Opening the center may activate White's fianchetto bishop too. The long diagonal to b7 can become a weakness.

BOARD DRILL

Mark the first blocker for each bishop and calculate one legal way to change it.

Against h4 and g4



HB-10 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

A wing attack is a concrete timing problem. ...h5 can stop one lever, while central action may punish the time White spent on pawns. Both choices can also create weaknesses.

HOW TO DECIDE

Calculate pawn captures and rook files before deciding. Keep the king flexible if castling would walk into an open file. Do not automatically play ...h6 as a visual part of the formation.

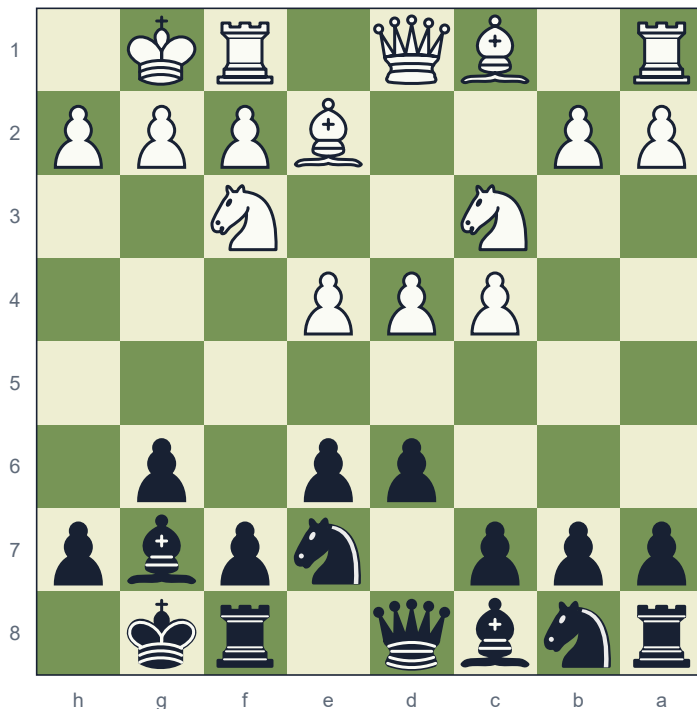
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White can use g4 to attack h5 or Bh6 to exchange Bg7. A blocked h-file may still be opened by another pawn contact.

BOARD DRILL

Compare the immediate h4 branch with the g4 branch and state why the defensive move order differs.

Large centers require earlier action



HB-07 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

Against c4-d4-e4 or an added f4, a full Hippo often gives White too much time and space. A partial formation with prompt development is the practical priority.

HOW TO DECIDE

Finish the king side and prepare a supported ...c5 or ...d5. Calculate e5 before every quiet move. Judge the resulting position honestly even when White retains an edge.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White can consolidate and then attack on either wing. Do not rely on the opponent overextending without actively testing the center.

BOARD DRILL

Play the four-pawn endpoint from both sides. Black's task is to create a safe break; White's is to prevent it.

King safety is a decision



HB-03 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

A closed center can make delayed castling workable, but a central break can expose the king suddenly. A queen on h6 or an open h-file can make short castling especially dangerous.

HOW TO DECIDE

Inspect open lines, central pawn contacts and the opponent's castling choice. Compare castling with a central exchange or a developing defensive move.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White may keep the king flexible while preparing Bh6 and h4. A king destination chosen on habit can become the attack's target.

BOARD DRILL

In three diagrams, decide whether castling is legal, then separately whether it looks strategically safe.

Do not fear a partial Hippo



HB-18 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

After 1.b3 g6 2.Bb2, the bishop already attacks g7. Developing Nf6 first blocks that diagonal. The correct position has a knight on f6 rather than e7.

HOW TO DECIDE

Check every long diagonal before placing an undefended bishop. Use normal development and central control when the opponent's move order prevents the preferred arrangement.

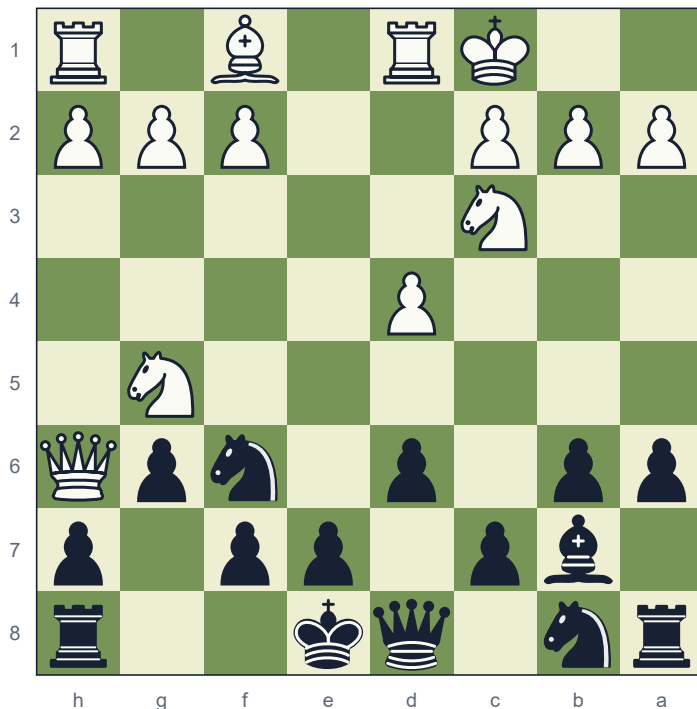
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Bishop captures and queen checks can punish an apparently standard fianchetto. An opening name cannot justify leaving a piece en prise.

BOARD DRILL

Reconstruct this branch and prove why immediate ...Bg7 loses a bishop. Then explain how ...Nf6 changes the board.

Loose pieces and forks



HB-03 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Before calculating an attack, list undefended pieces. A knight fork attacks two targets that cannot both move away. A queen check may combine king pressure with a second target. If you remove a defender, inspect every piece it protected.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Find two pieces that would be vulnerable if their defender moved. Calculate one legal forcing move that tests the relation. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

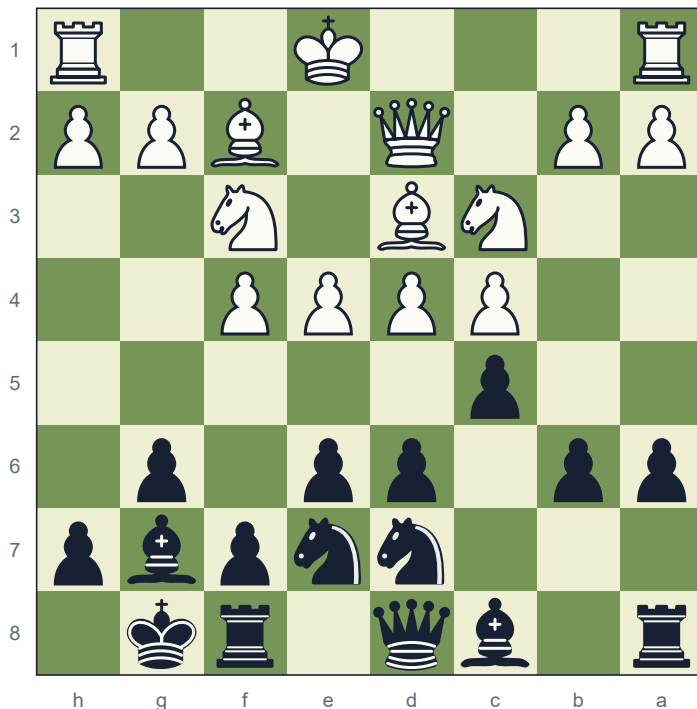
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

White can castle long and push h4. Removing the fianchetto bishop may weaken dark squares around a castled black king.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Pins and discovered attacks



HB-08 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

An absolute pin prevents a piece from moving if doing so exposes its king. A relative pin involves a valuable piece behind it, usually the queen. A discovered attack appears when a blocking piece moves away. Always trace the entire line, including the piece behind the blocker.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Identify a line piece, its blocker and the target behind it. If no pin exists, explain which required element is missing. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

White's attack may become dangerous if allowed to consolidate every pawn. You need a break, not merely a compact-looking position.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Intermediate moves and defensive resources



HB-13 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

A recapture is not compulsory unless it is the only legal response to check. Before recapturing, inspect checks, stronger captures and direct threats. When attacking, give the defender the same opportunity; do not assume automatic recaptures.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

At a capture in your line, pause before the reply. List all legal checks, then compare them with the expected recapture. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

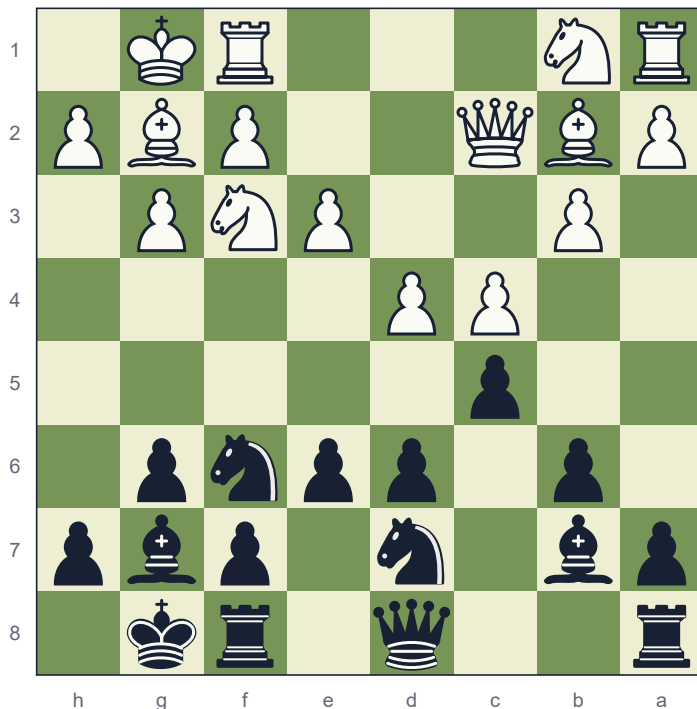
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

White can use Nbd2, c3 and e4 to expand. The London label does not guarantee that White will remain passive.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

A sacrifice needs a stopping point



HB-18 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Calculate a sacrifice until the defender has a stable reply you can evaluate. Count material after the whole sequence, not after the first capture. If the line ends only with a vague promise of attack, compare a non-sacrificial candidate.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Choose a tempting sacrifice from a laboratory or your own game. Write the best defensive reply and the position where you stop calculating. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

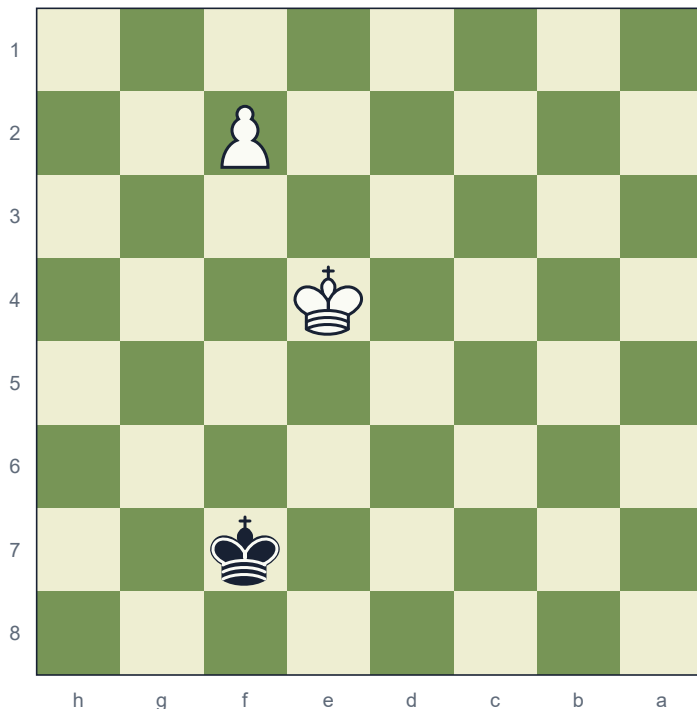
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Playing ...Bg7 immediately after Bb2 would simply leave that bishop en prise. A normal-looking fianchetto is not safe in every move order.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Activate the king when queens are gone



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

White to move: Kf5 is a legal active king move. Kf4 is also legal but less direct; compare plans rather than inventing a forcing win. The general lesson is to bring the king toward the pawn and useful squares while keeping the opposing king out.

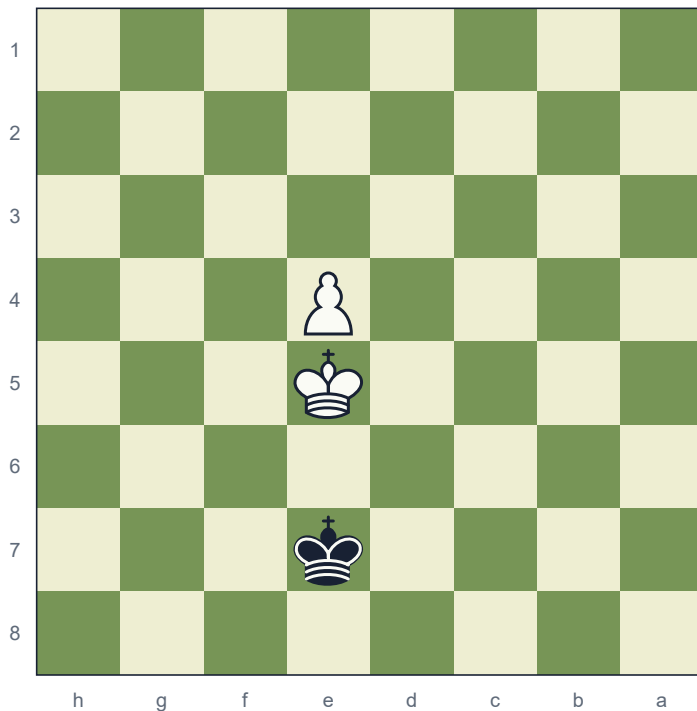
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In an opening-to-endgame transition, first inspect checks and pawn threats, then activate the king. Do not continue making shelter moves whose main purpose was defense against a queen. A rook ending may still require care about checks from behind.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Opposition and the importance of the move



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The kings face each other on e5 and e7 with one square between. White to move must give way or move the pawn; the geometry changes if Black is to move. Opposition is a tool for gaining entry squares, not a rule that always wins.

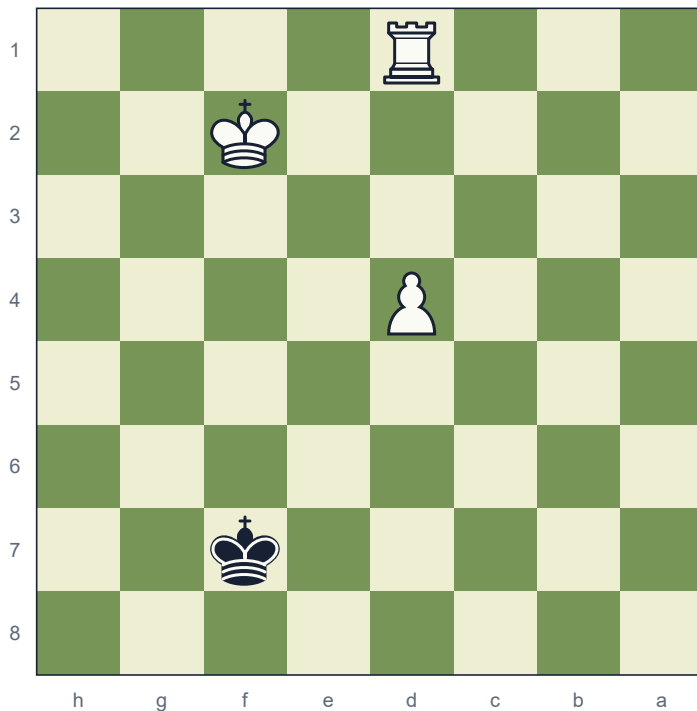
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Replay both side-to-move versions. Track the pawn's key squares and whether the attacking king can reach them. If you exchange into a pawn ending, calculate the actual king route and tempo rather than relying on the extra pawn alone.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Rooks belong where they work



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The rook on d1 stands behind its own passed d-pawn. As the pawn advances, the rook can continue supporting it from behind. This is a teaching position, not a claim of a difficult theoretical win against a rook.

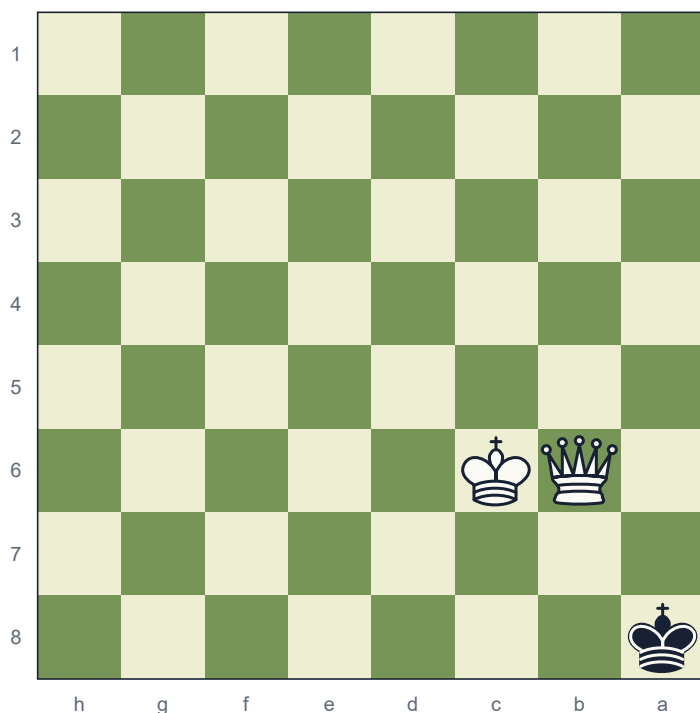
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In real rook endings compare activity, checking distance, king shelter and pawn races. Putting a rook behind a passed pawn is a useful default, but a tactical threat or a decisive lateral check can override it. Do not trade an active rook into a lost pawn ending.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Recognize stalemate before promoting



Teaching position - Black to move

READ THE BOARD

Black to move is not in check and has no legal move: a7 and b8 are controlled by Qb6, while b7 is controlled by the queen and Kc6. This is stalemate, so the position is a draw despite White's extra queen.

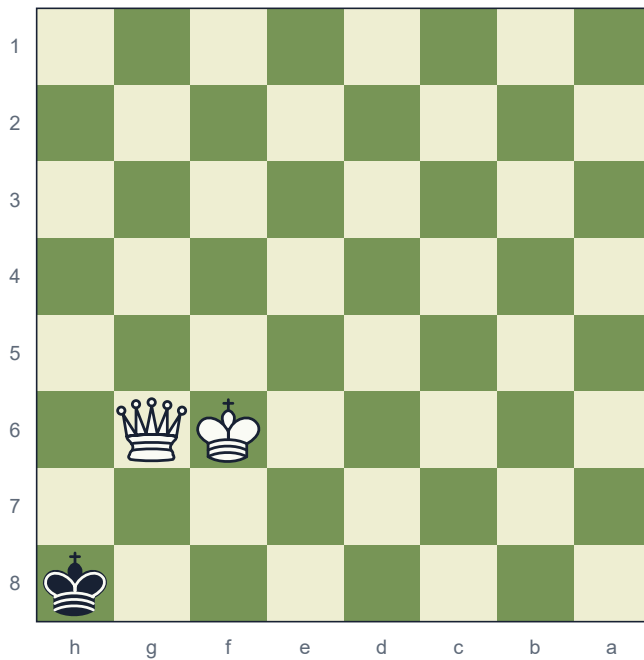
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Before delivering the final move of a won game, check whether the opponent has a legal reply if not in check. In queen-versus-king technique, restrict the king with the queen, approach with your king and preserve a legal waiting square until you can give mate.

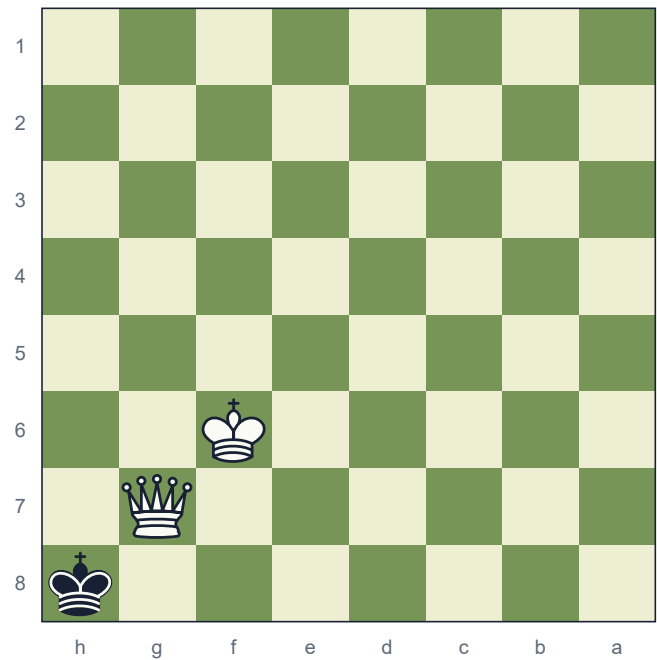
PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Finish a won queen ending



White to move - find mate in one



After Qg7# - Black is checkmated

WHY THIS IS MATE

Qg7 gives check along the g7-h8 diagonal. The white king on f6 protects the queen, so ...Kxg7 is illegal. The queen controls g8 and h7, removing the remaining escape squares. This proof checks attacks and legal replies, not just the appearance of the diagram.

TECHNIQUE BEFORE THE FINAL MOVE

Use the queen to reduce the enemy king's space, bring your king close enough to support the mate, and keep a legal waiting square until you can give checkmate. A queen alone can accidentally stalemate; review the previous lesson before repeating this drill.

Choosing the right exchanges

DO NOT TRADE BY HABIT

When offered a trade, compare the activity of the pieces leaving the board, the resulting pawn weaknesses and the king positions. A player with less space may welcome exchanges, but trading the only active piece can make the position worse.

PAWN ENDING TEST

Before exchanging the last pieces, calculate king activity, passed-pawn races and the side to move. Opposition is one tool; it is not a substitute for counting legal tempi. A pawn ending is often less forgiving than a rook ending.

OPENING-SPECIFIC QUESTION

After 1.b3 g6 2.Bb2, the bishop already attacks g7. Developing Nf6 first blocks that diagonal. The correct position has a knight on f6 rather than e7.

PRACTICAL CONVERSION

When ahead, neutralize counterplay and improve the least active piece before collecting another pawn. When defending, seek active checks, pawn breaks and useful exchanges rather than passive waiting.

A STUDY HABIT

After every practice game, keep one transition position. Record which exchange you chose, which alternative you considered and how the pawn structure changed.

How the six laboratories work

ORIGINAL ILLUSTRATIVE PLAY

These are original engine-assisted study continuations from this course's positions. They are not historical master games and no invented players or tournament results are assigned. The continuations reach roughly move twenty and stop for further practice.

THINK BEFORE REVEALING

At each checkpoint, name the opponent's threat, compare two candidates and calculate a forcing reply. Use a board to replay the sequence. The engine comparison supplies concrete evidence, while the opening explanation supplies a plan.

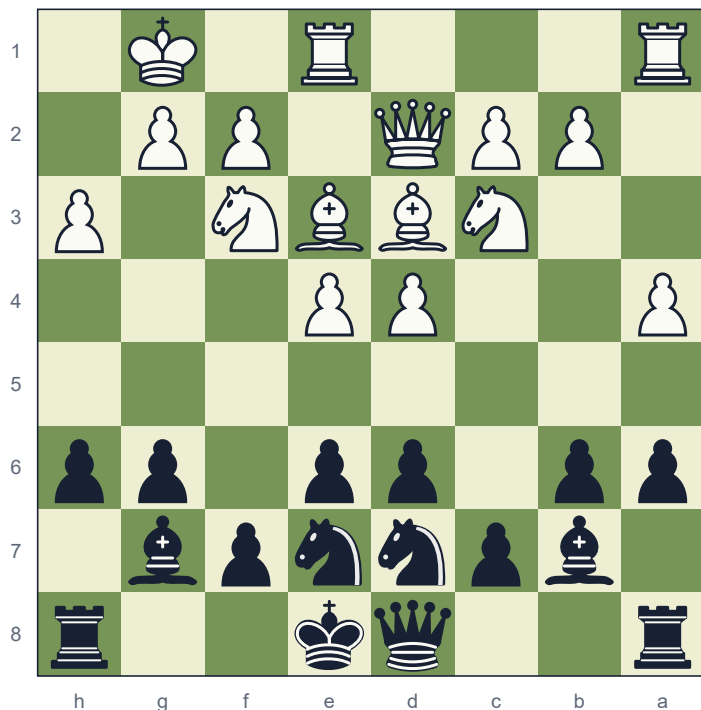
MORE THAN ONE GOOD MOVE

Close engine scores do not establish a unique answer. The finite search can prefer a different move when run longer. Accept another candidate if you can support it with a sound variation and a coherent explanation.

PRACTICE FROM BOTH SIDES

Play each starting position twice, switching colors. Record the first decision you could not explain and compare it with the branch lesson after the game.

HB-LAB-01 / The full formation as a study position



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

This illustrative route shows the recognizable formation when White develops quietly. The knights avoid blocking the fianchetto bishops, but Black has used many pawn tempi and is still uncastled.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, e4. Black king e8; central-file pawns d6, e6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

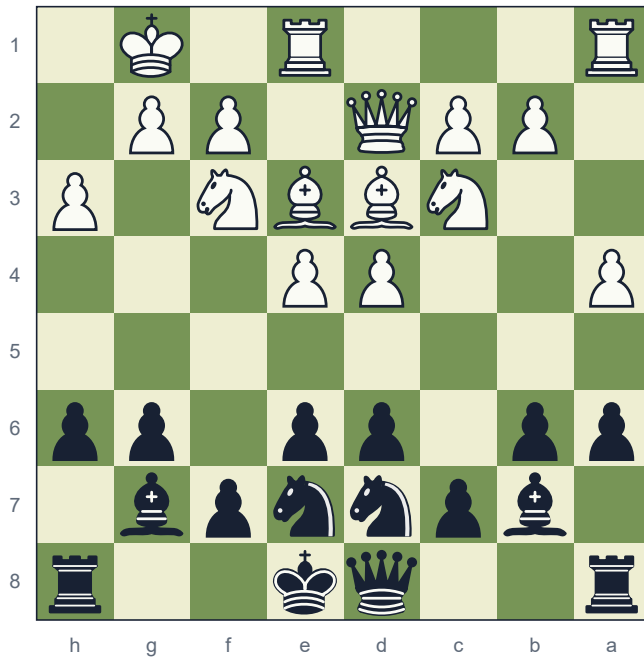
White owns more space and can prepare d5, e5 or a wing attack. Finishing the diagram is not a strategic achievement if Black then has no active move. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

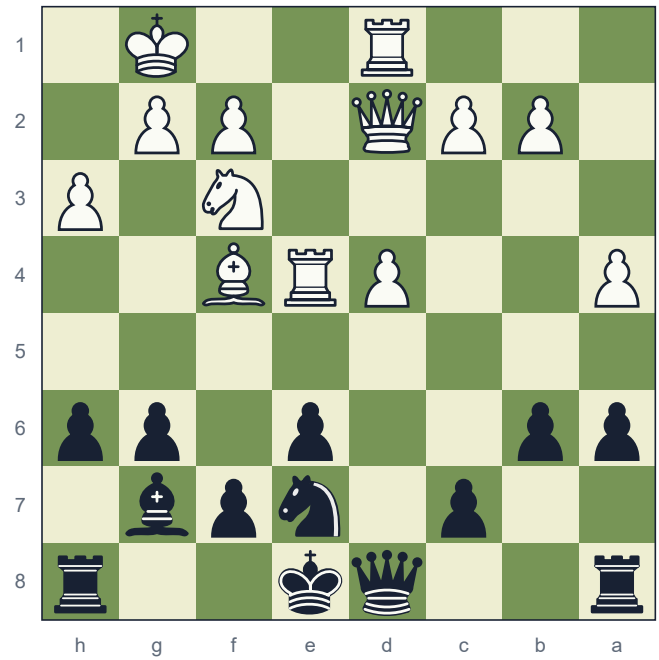
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

HB-LAB-01 / play and explain 1

11... Nf6 12. Rad1 d5 13. Bf4 Nxe4 14. Nxe4 dxe4 15. Bxe4 Bxe4 16. Rxe4



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... NF6

Develops the king knight toward e4 and d5. Its location also blocks some long-diagonal bishop attacks, but makes it a possible target of e5.

13... NXE4

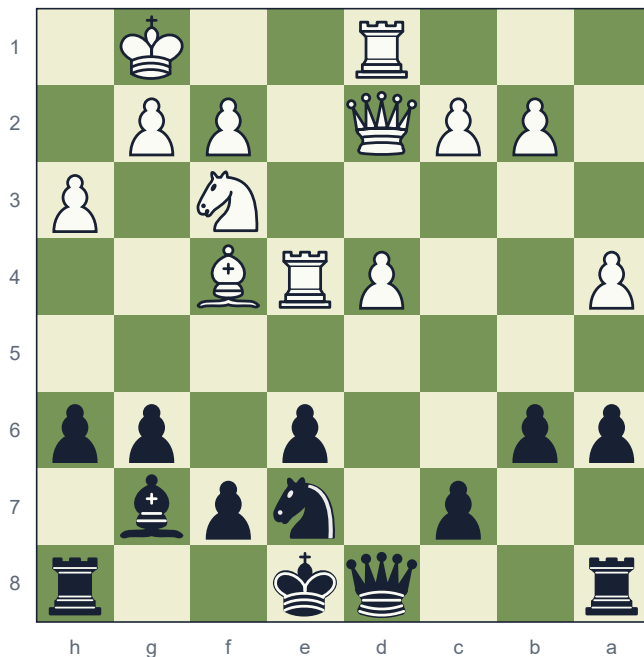
The knight captures a pawn on e4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

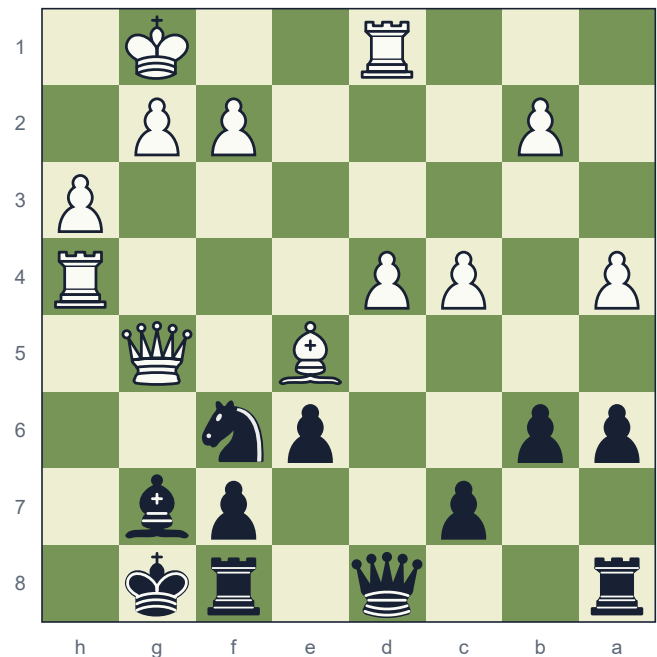
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HB-LAB-01 / play and explain 2

16... Nd5 17. Be5 O-O 18. c4 Nf6 19. Rh4 g5 20. Nxd5 hxd5 21. Qxd5



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... ND5

Places the knight on d5, attacking bishop on f4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

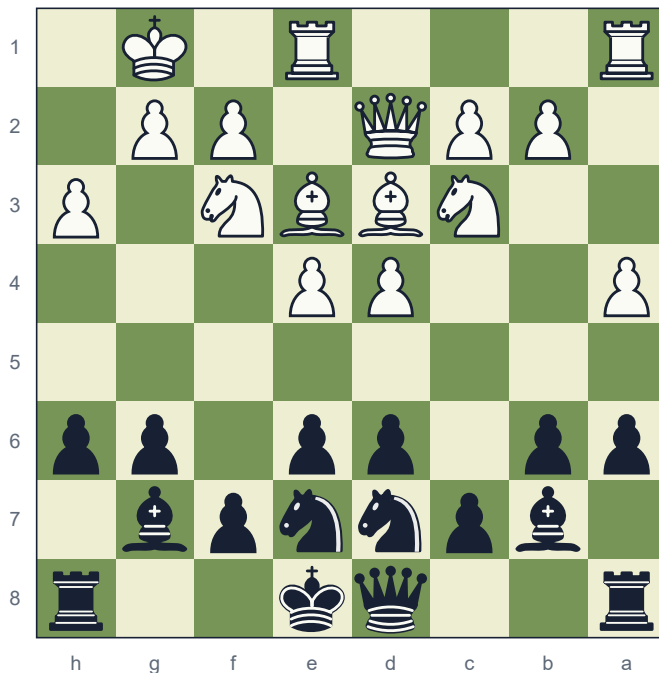
18... NF6

Places the knight on f6, attacking rook on e4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HB-LAB-01 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nf6 and d5. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, e4. Black king e8; central-file pawns d6, e6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NF6

11... Nf6 12. Rad1 Search estimate: -1.12 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE D5

11... d5 12. Bf4 g5 13. Bg3 O-O 14. e5 c5 15. h4 Search estimate: -1.16 from Black's perspective.

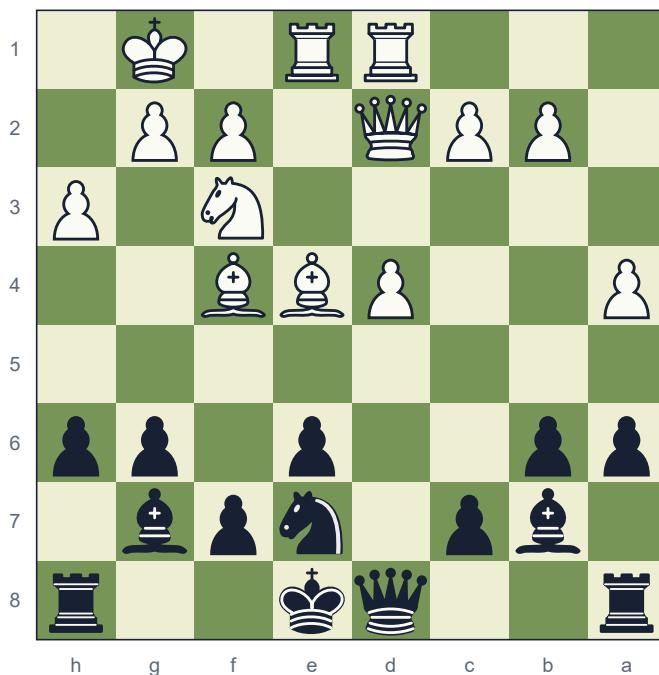
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Develops the king knight toward e4 and d5. Its location also blocks some long-diagonal bishop attacks, but makes it a possible target of e5.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-01 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Bxe4 and Bd5. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns e6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE Bxe4

15... Bxe4 16. Rxe4 Nd5 17. Be5 Nf6 18. Rf4 g5 19. Bxf6 Search estimate: -1.21 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE Bd5

15... Bd5 16. c4 Bxe4 17. Rxe4 c6 18. b3 b5 19. Re2 Search estimate: -1.41 from Black's perspective.

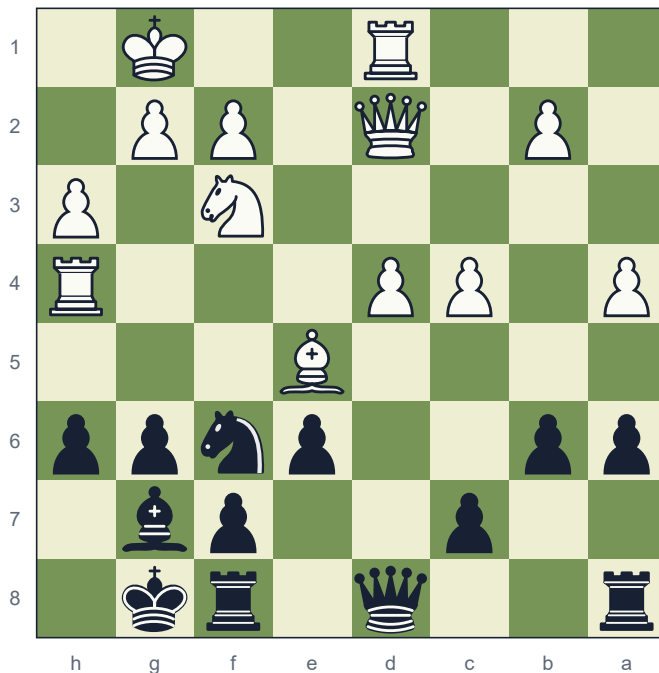
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The bishop captures a bishop on e4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-01 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

g5 and h5. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c4, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns e6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE G5

19... g5 Search estimate: -0.95 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE H5

19... h5 20. Qc3 Nd7 21. Bxg7 Kxg7 22. Re1 Re8 23. Rhe4 Search estimate: -1.16 from Black's perspective.

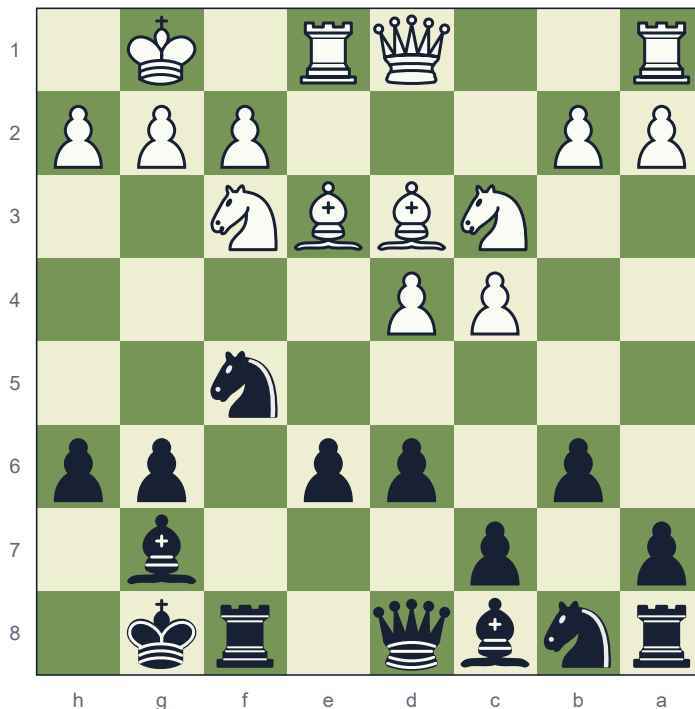
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the pawn on g5, attacking rook on h4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-02 / The three-pawn center



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

White occupies c4-d4-e4. Black chooses a partial formation and castles instead of insisting on both fianchettos before addressing the center.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c4, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns d6, e6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

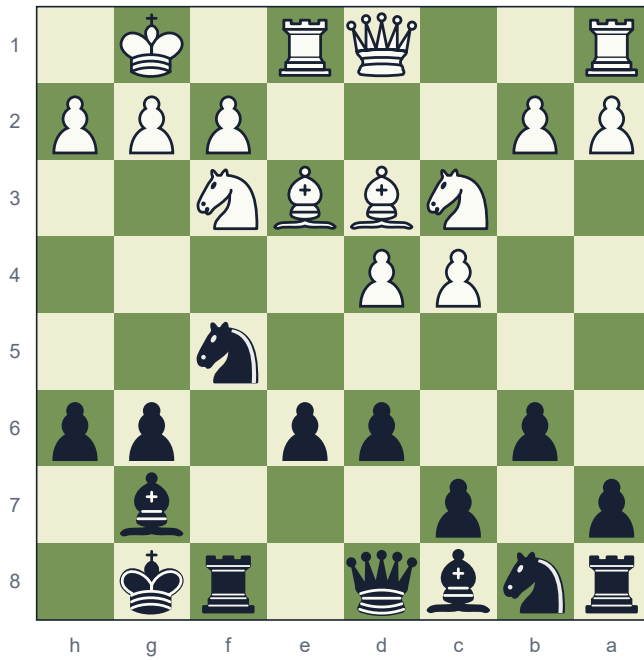
White can gain more space with d5 or build a kingside attack with f4. Do not add ...a6 and ...h6 automatically under a development deficit. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

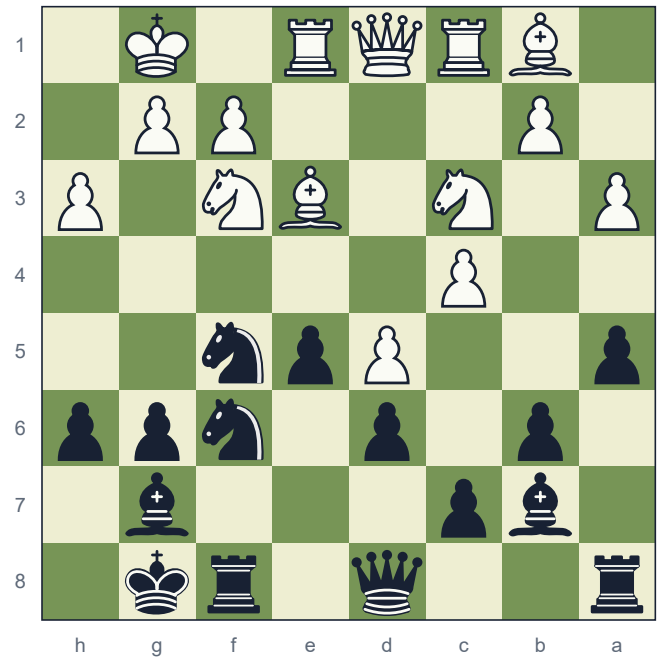
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

HB-LAB-02 / play and explain 1

11... Nd7 12. Rc1 Bb7 13. d5 e5 14. Bb1 a5 15. a3 Nf6 16. h3



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... ND7

Develops a knight toward central supporting squares. Keep a useful onward route so the compact setup does not become overcrowded.

13... E5

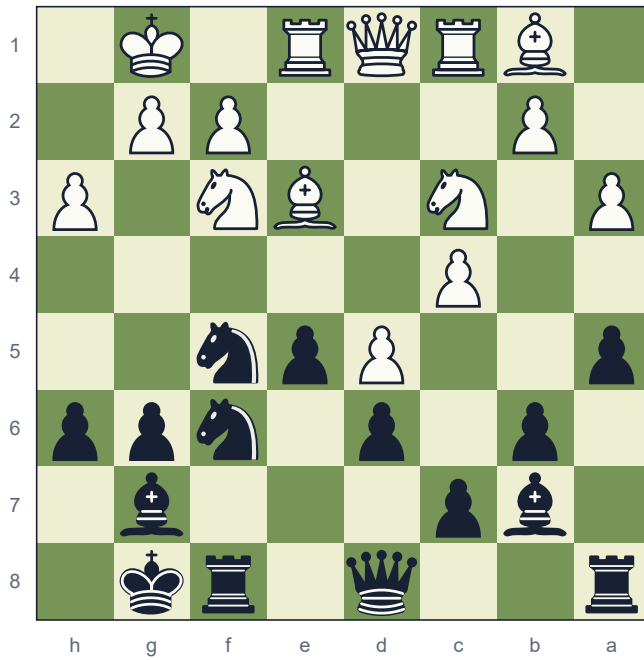
Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

REASSESS

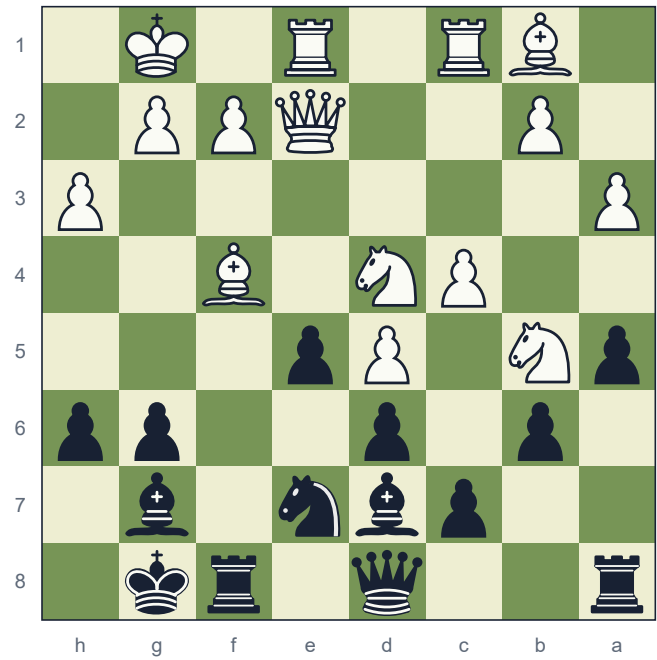
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HB-LAB-02 / play and explain 2

16... Bc8 17. Bd2 Bd7 18. Qe2 Nh5 19. Nb5 Ne7 20. Nfd4 Nf4 21. Bxf4



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... BC8

Places the bishop on c8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

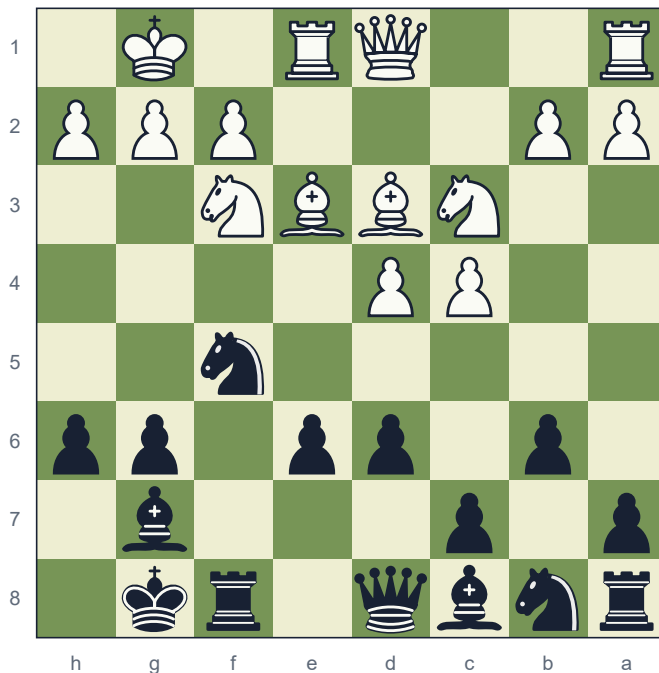
18... NH5

Places the knight on h5. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HB-LAB-02 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nd7 and Nc6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c4, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns d6, e6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE ND7

11... Nd7 12. Be4 Rb8 13. h3 a6 14. Qd2 g5 15. Rac1 Search estimate: -0.76 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE NC6

11... Nc6 12. Be4 Bb7 13. d5 Ne5 14. Nd4 Nxe3 15. Rxe3 Search estimate: -0.80 from Black's perspective.

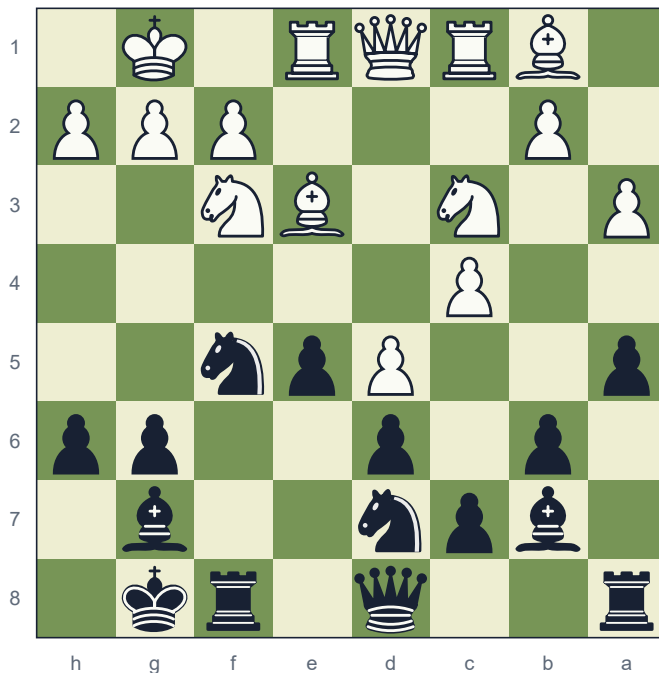
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Develops a knight toward central supporting squares. Keep a useful onward route so the compact setup does not become overcrowded.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-02 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nf6 and Ba6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c4, d5. Black king g8; central-file pawns e5, d6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NF6

15... Nf6 16. h3 Bc8 17. Bd2 Bd7 18. Nb5 Rc8 19. a4 Search estimate: -0.72 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE BA6

15... Ba6 16. b3 Search estimate: -0.77 from Black's perspective.

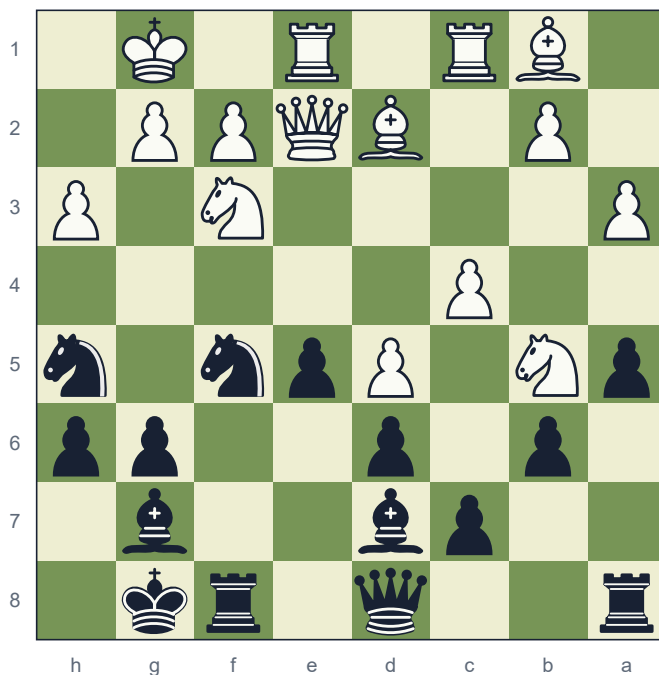
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Develops the king knight toward e4 and d5. Its location also blocks some long-diagonal bishop attacks, but makes it a possible target of e5.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-02 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Ne7 and Nf6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c4, d5. Black king g8; central-file pawns e5, d6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NE7

19... Ne7 20. Rc3 Search estimate: -0.66 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE NF6

19... Nf6 20. g4 Ne7 21. Nh4 g5 22. Ng6 Nxe6 23. Bxe6 Search estimate: -1.09 from Black's perspective.

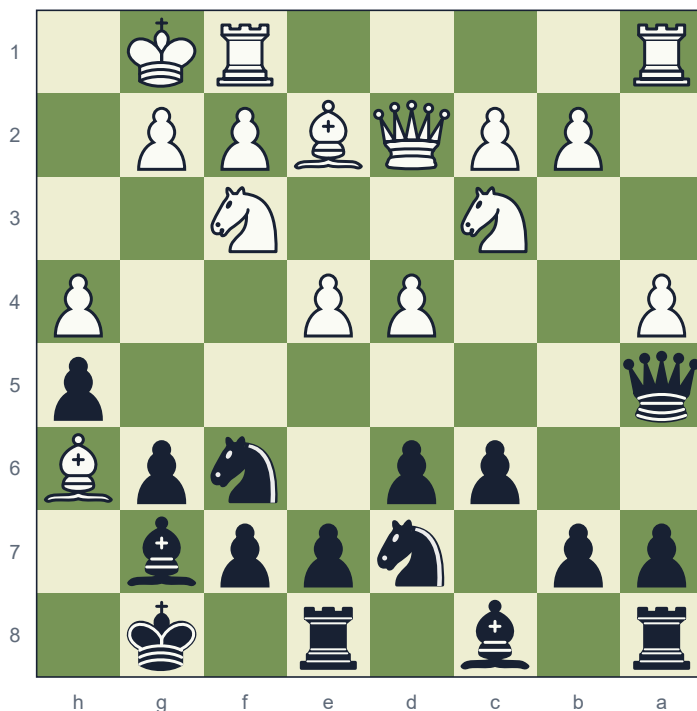
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Develops the king knight while keeping the f-pawn flexible. It may support a central break or move toward g6 or c6 if safe.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-03 / An immediate h-pawn attack



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

...h5 stops the immediate h4-h5 lever. Black accepts a fixed kingside structure rather than allowing White to open the h-file by force.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c6, d6, e7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

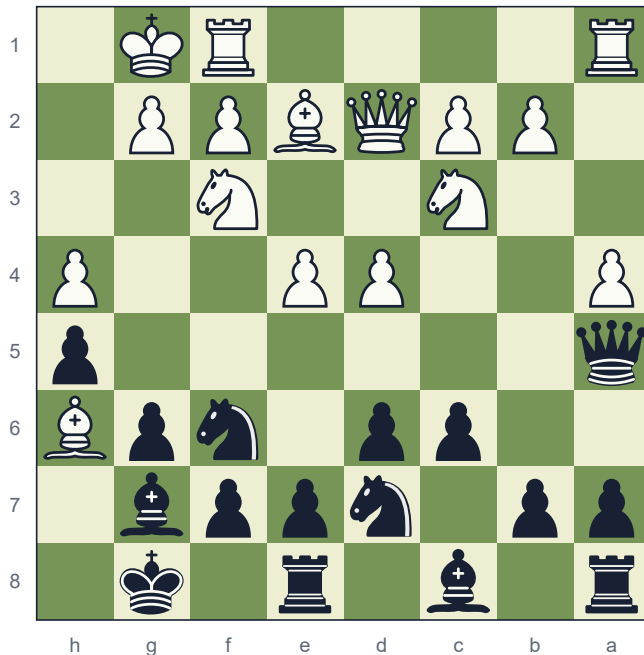
g4 can attack the new h5 hook. A blocked h-pawn does not mean the king side is permanently safe. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

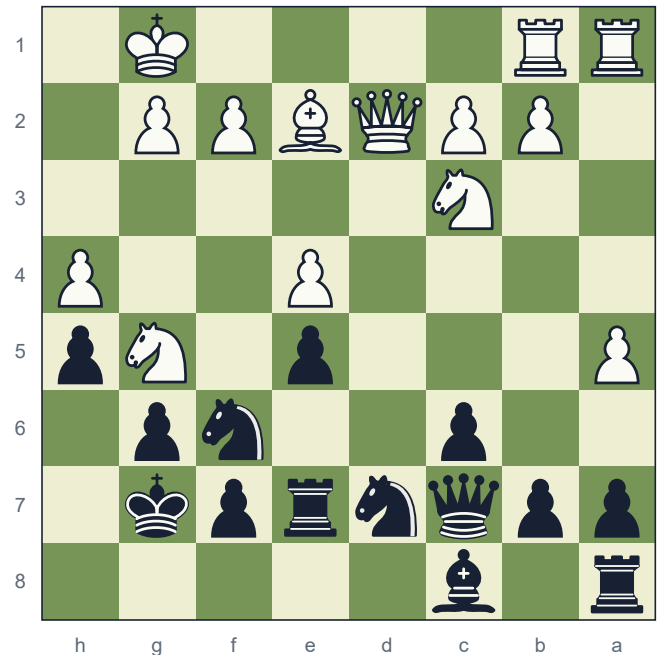
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

HB-LAB-03 / play and explain 1

11... e5 12. Bxg7 Kxg7 13. Ng5 Re7 14. dxe5 dxe5 15. Rfb1 Qc7 16. a5



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... E5

Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

13... RE7

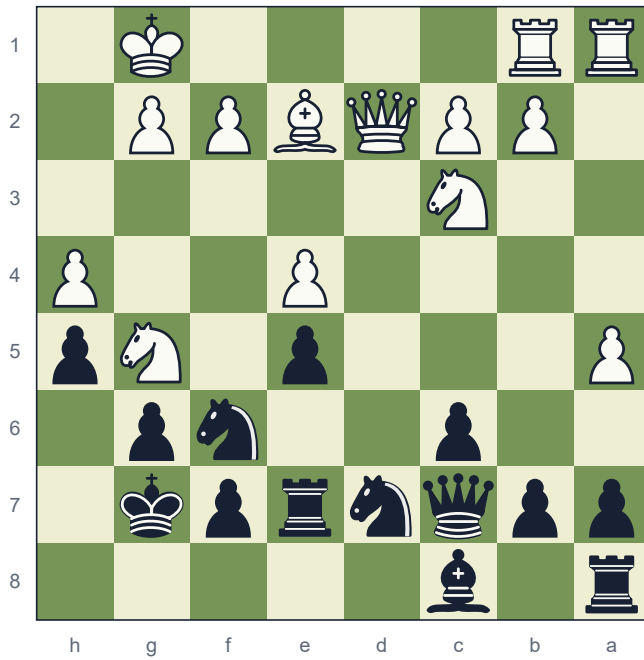
Places the rook on e7. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

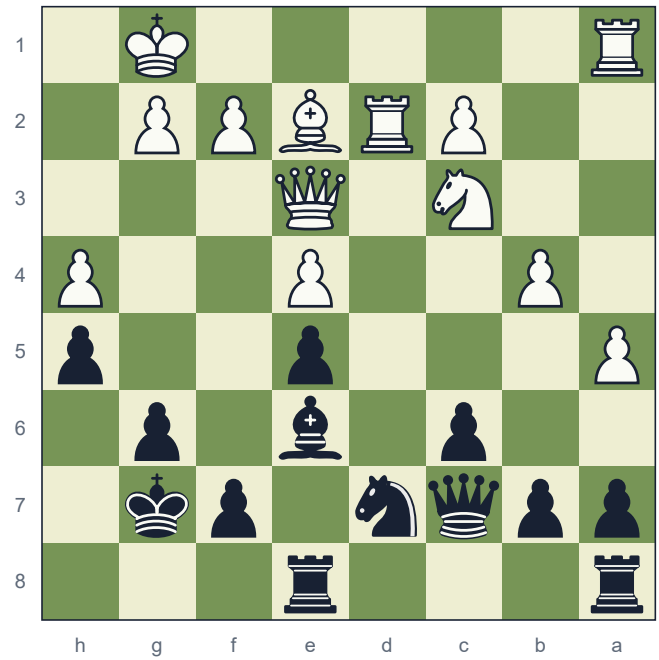
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HB-LAB-03 / play and explain 2

16... Nf8 17. b4 Ne6 18. Nxe6+ Bxe6 19. Qe3 Nd7 20. Rd1 Ree8 21. Rd2



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... NF8

Places the knight on f8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

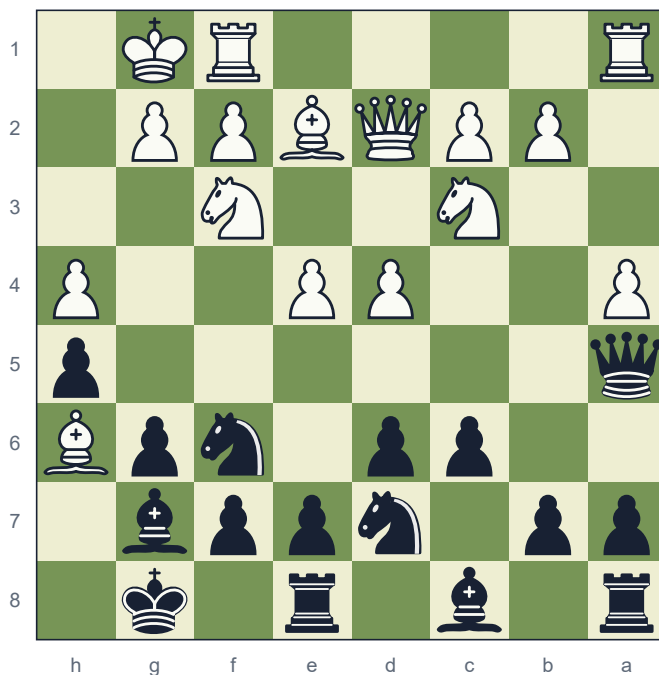
18... BXE6

The bishop captures a knight on e6. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HB-LAB-03 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

e5 and Nf8. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c6, d6, e7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE E5

11... e5 Search estimate: -0.59 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE NF8

11... Nf8 12. Bxg7 Kxg7 13. Ng5 e5 14. f4 exd4 15. Qxd4 Search estimate: -0.64 from Black's perspective.

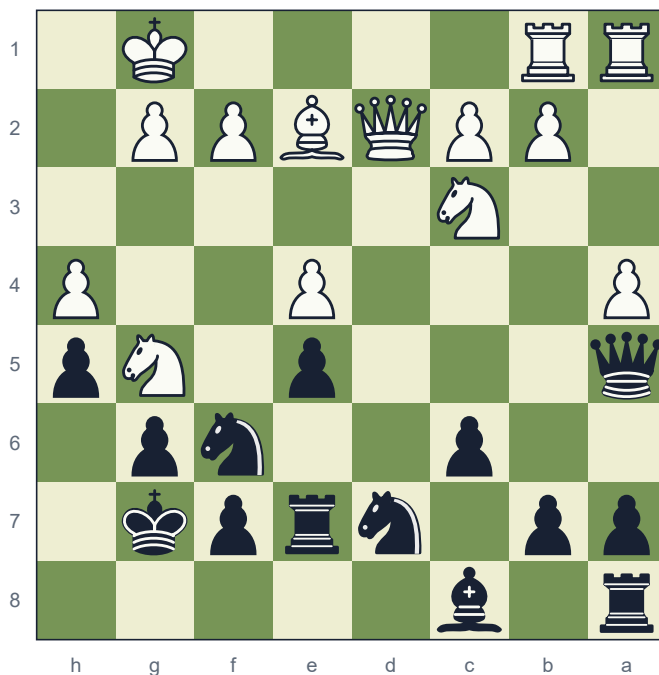
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-03 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Qc7 and Nf8. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e4. Black king g7; central-file pawns e5, c6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE QC7

15... Qc7 Search estimate: -0.25 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE NF8

15... Nf8 16. b4 Search estimate: -0.27 from Black's perspective.

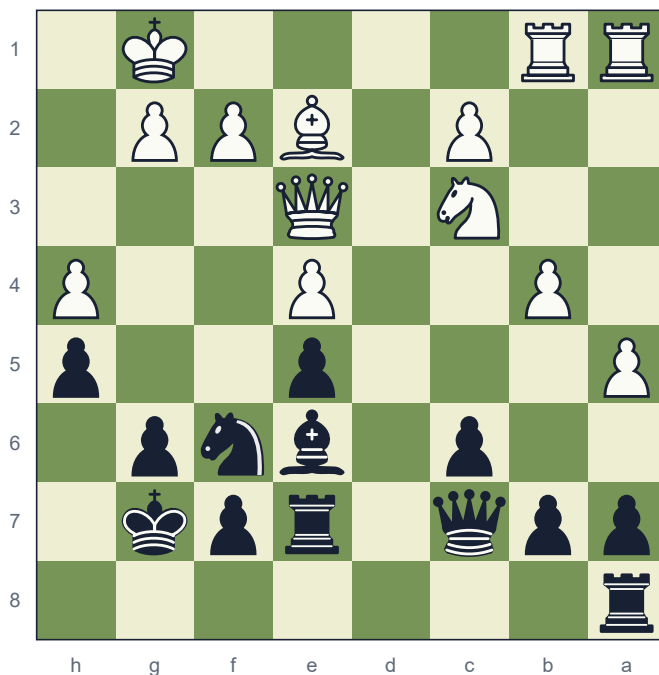
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the queen on c7. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-03 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nd7 and Ree8. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e4. Black king g7; central-file pawns e5, c6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE ND7

19... Nd7 20. Rd1 Ree8 21. Rd2 Nf6 22. Rad1 Qe7 23. Rd6 Search estimate: -0.27 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE REE8

19... Ree8 20. Na4 Search estimate: -0.35 from Black's perspective.

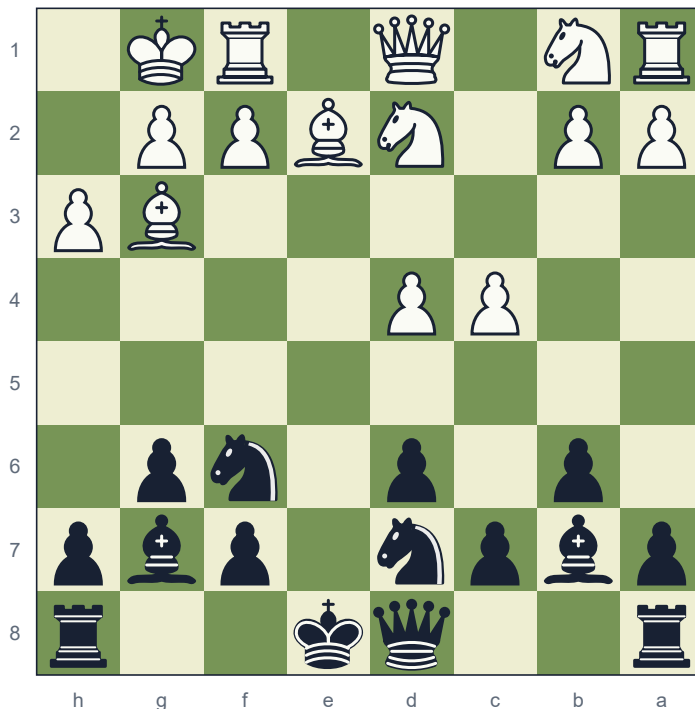
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Develops a knight toward central supporting squares. Keep a useful onward route so the compact setup does not become overcrowded.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-04 / Against the London bishop



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

White's bishop develops outside the pawn chain and may support e5. Black uses the double fianchetto while keeping the central break flexible.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c4, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns d6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

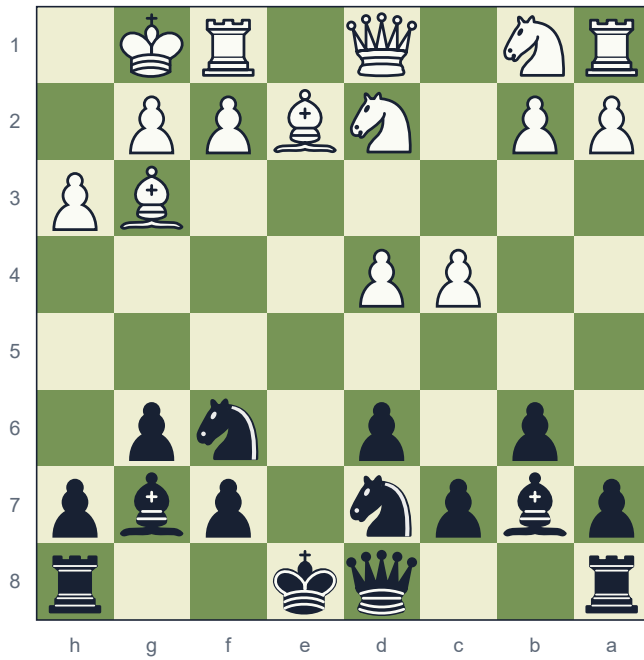
White can use Nbd2, c3 and e4 to expand. The London label does not guarantee that White will remain passive. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

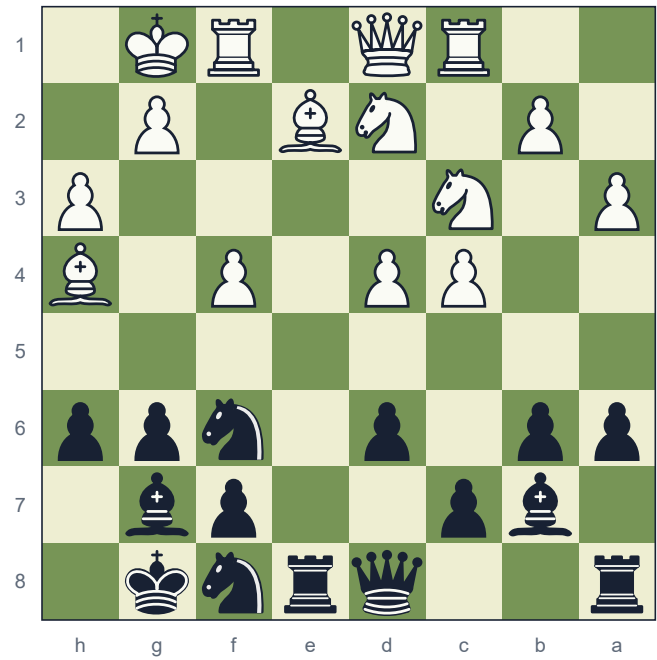
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

HB-LAB-04 / play and explain 1

11... O-O 12. Nc3 Re8 13. Bh4 h6 14. Rc1 a6 15. a3 Nf8 16. f4



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... O-O

Moves the king toward shelter and brings a rook toward the center. Check the resulting open lines before assuming the king is safe.

13... H6

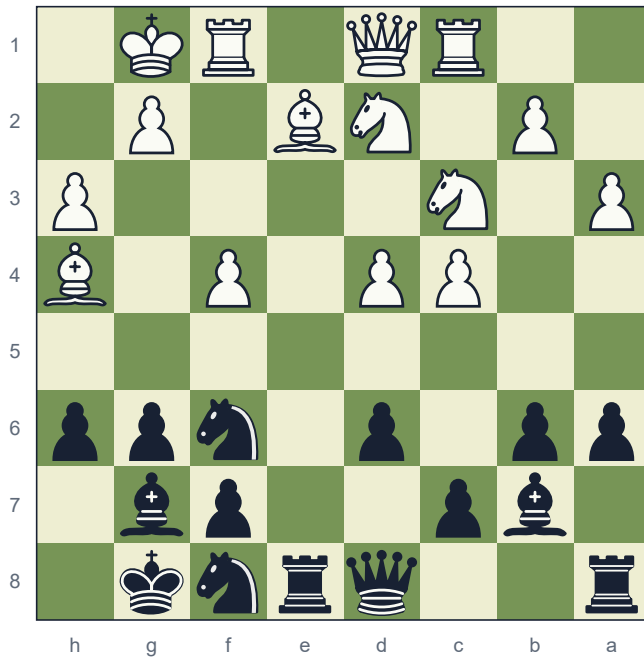
Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

REASSESS

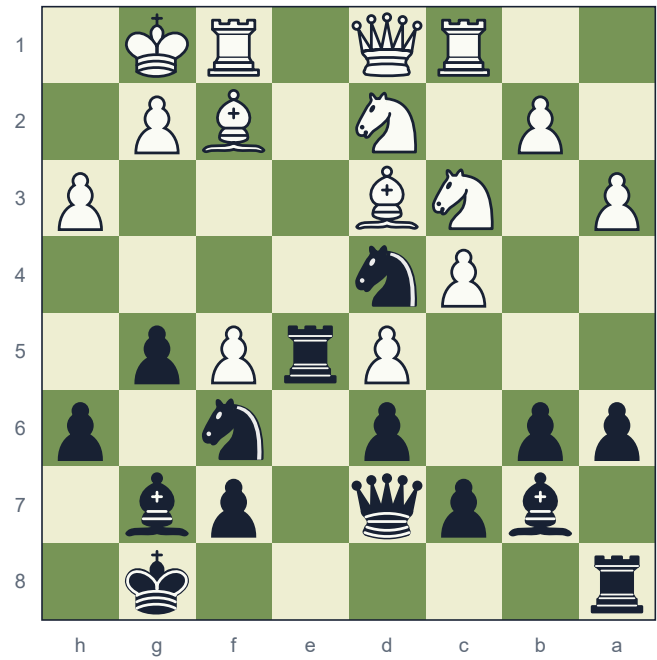
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HB-LAB-04 / play and explain 2

16... Ne6 17. d5 Nd4 18. Bd3 Qd7 19. f5 g5 20. Be1 Re5 21. Bf2



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... NE6

Places the knight on e6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

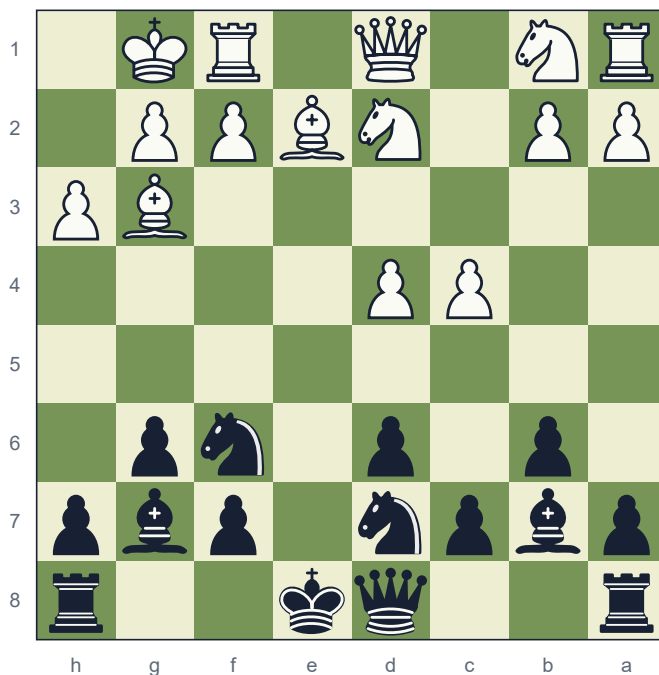
18... QD7

Places the queen on d7. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HB-LAB-04 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

O-O and h6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c4, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns d6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE O-O

11... O-O 12. Nc3 Re8 13. Bh4 h6 14. a4 a6 15. Rc1 Search estimate: -0.47 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE H6

11... h6 12. Nc3 O-O 13. Qc2 Nh7 14. Bf3 Bxf3 15. Nxf3 Search estimate: -0.48 from Black's perspective.

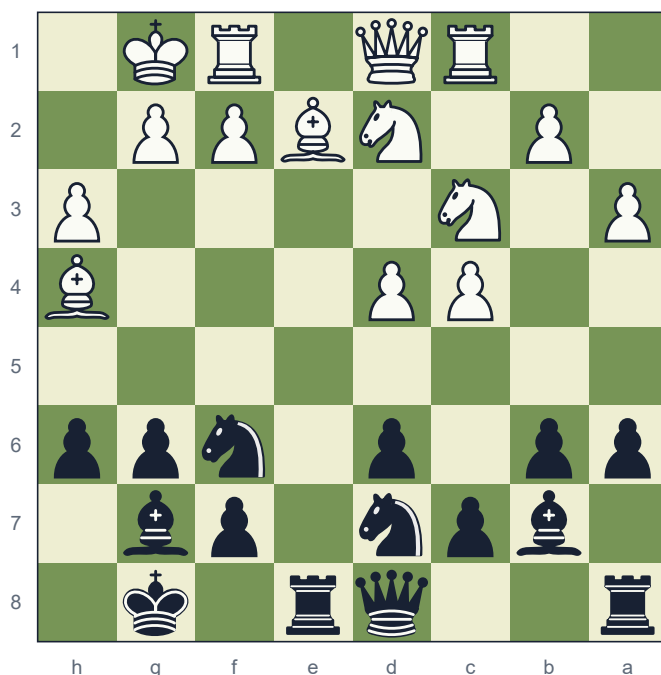
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Moves the king toward shelter and brings a rook toward the center. Check the resulting open lines before assuming the king is safe.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-04 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nf8 and Qc8. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c4, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns d6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NF8

15... Nf8 16. f4 Ne6 17. d5 Nd4 18. Bd3 Bc8 19. Nb3 Search estimate: -0.51 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE QC8

15... Qc8 16. Re1 Search estimate: -0.54 from Black's perspective.

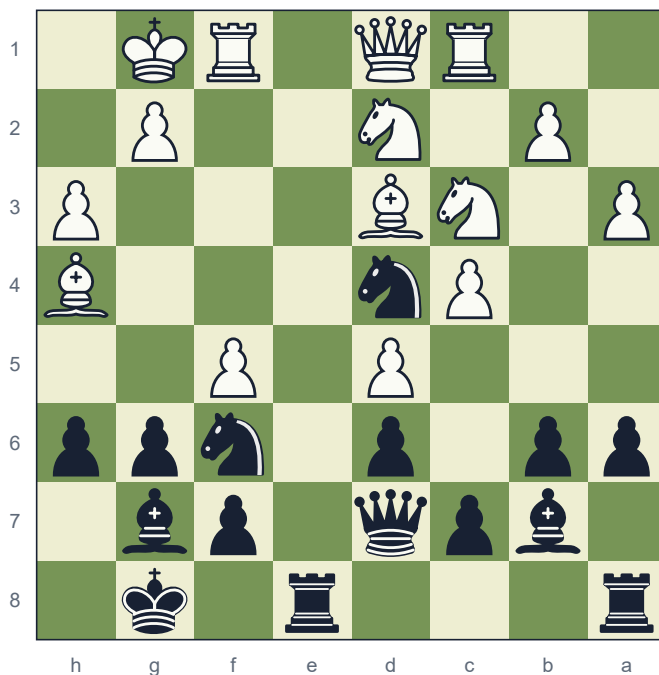
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the knight on f8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-04 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

g5 and Nxf5. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c4, d5, f5. Black king g8; central-file pawns d6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE G5

19... g5 Search estimate: -0.46 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE NXF5

19... Nxf5 20. Bxf5 gxf5 21. Rc2 b5 22. Nf3 bxc4 23. Nd4 Search estimate: -0.70 from Black's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the pawn on g5, attacking bishop on h4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-05 / Prepare ...c5 with development



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

Black develops the queen knight before forcing a central break. In this exact position an immediate ...c5 allows strong white play; a thematic move still needs preparation.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns d6, e6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

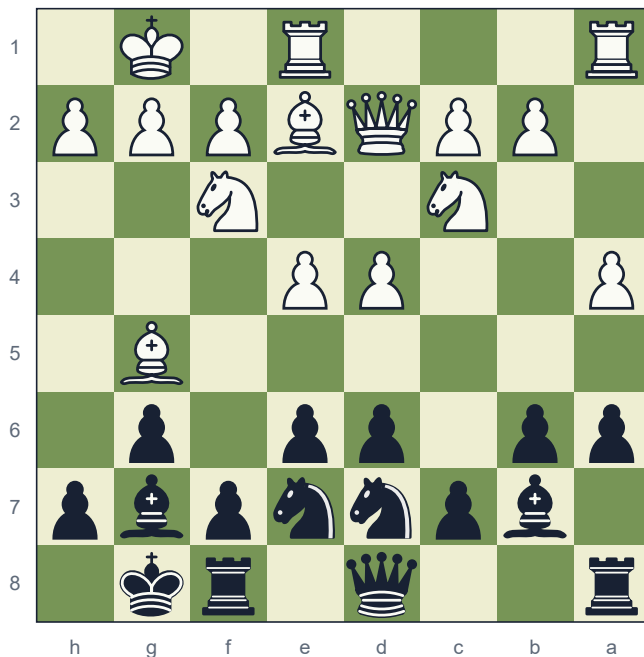
White can improve with Qd2 or advance in the center. Do not assume that a break becomes good simply because it belongs to the opening's vocabulary. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

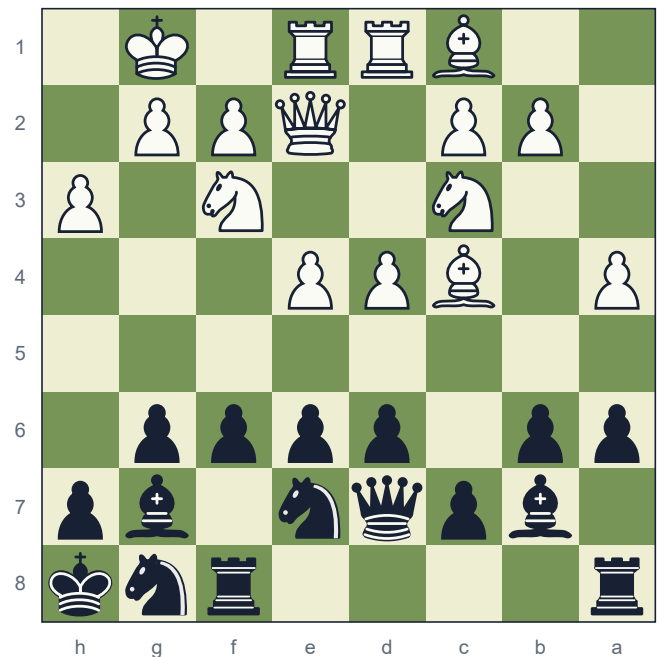
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

HB-LAB-05 / play and explain 1

11... Kh8 12. Bc4 Nf6 13. Rad1 Qd7 14. h3 Nfg8 15. Qe2 f6 16. Bc1



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... KH8

Places the king on h8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

13... QD7

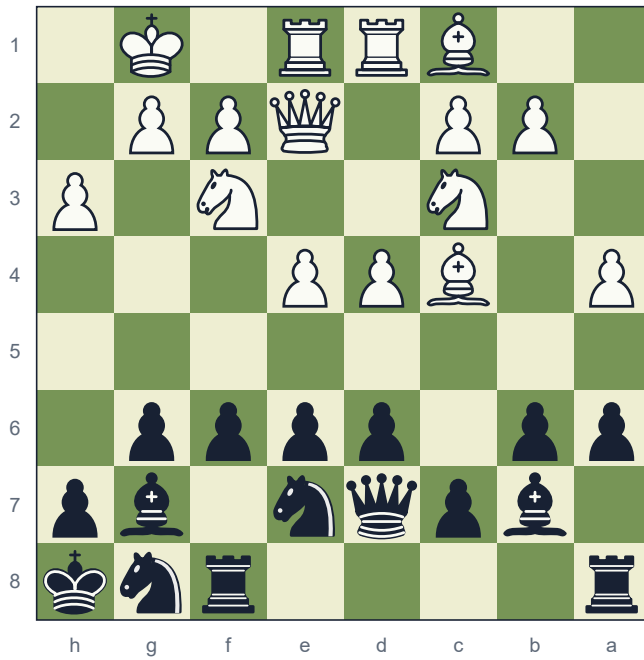
Places the queen on d7. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

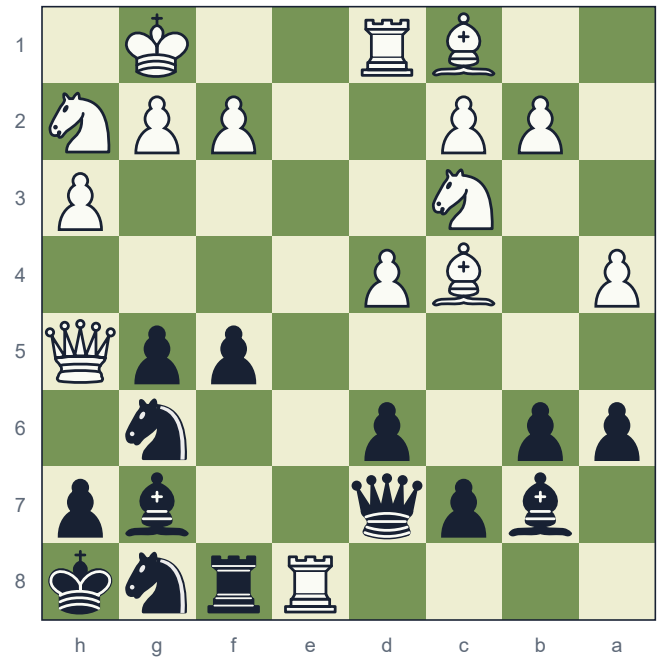
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HB-LAB-05 / play and explain 2

16... g5 17. Nh2 Ng6 18. Qg4 f5 19. exf5 exf5 20. Qh5 Rae8 21. Rxe8



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... G5

Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

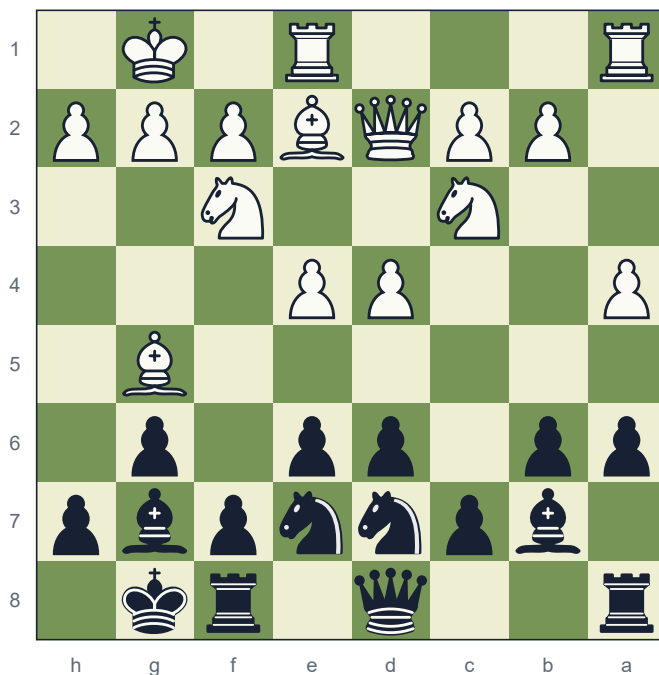
18... F5

Places the pawn on f5, attacking queen on g4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HB-LAB-05 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Kh8 and Re8. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns d6, e6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE KH8

11... Kh8 Search estimate: -0.76 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE RE8

11... Re8 12. h4 Nf6 13. Bd3 h5 14. e5 Nh7 15. Ne4 Search estimate: -0.79 from Black's perspective.

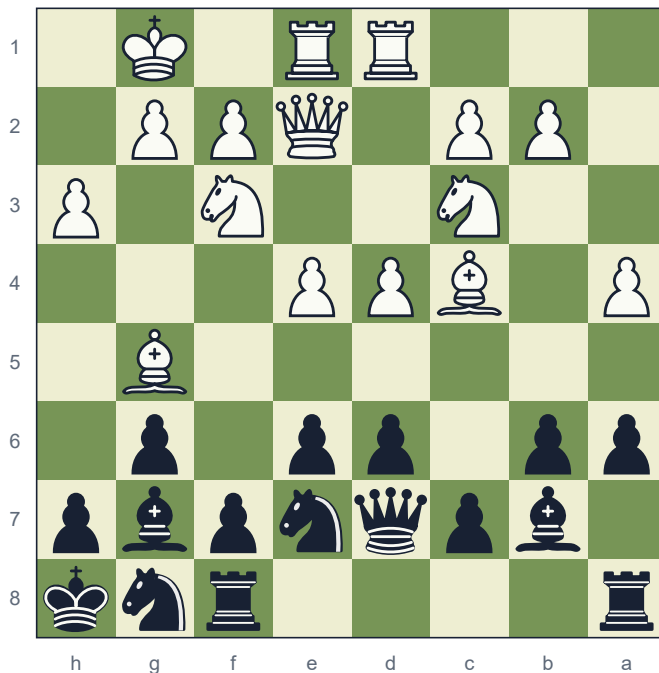
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the king on h8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-05 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

f6 and h6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, e4. Black king h8; central-file pawns d6, e6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE F6

15... f6 16. Bc1 g5 17. Bb3 Ng6 18. Qd3 Qf7 19. Ne2 Search estimate: -0.70 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE H6

15... h6 16. Bf4 Search estimate: -0.81 from Black's perspective.

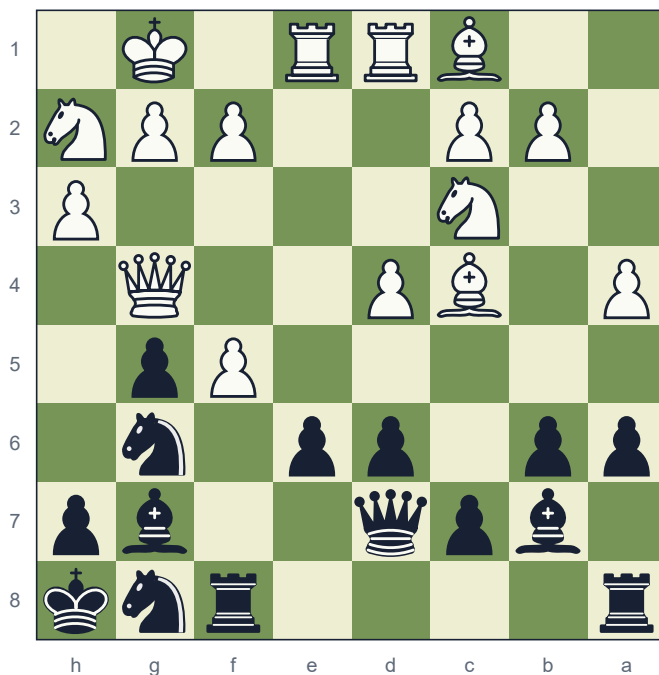
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the pawn on f6, attacking bishop on g5. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-05 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

exf5 and Nh6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, f5. Black king h8; central-file pawns d6, e6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE EXF5

19... exf5 20. Qh5 Search estimate: -0.95 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE NH6

19... Nh6 20. Bxe6 Qd8 21. Qh5 Nxf5 22. Bxg5 Nxd4 23. Bxd8 Search estimate: -2.76 from Black's perspective.

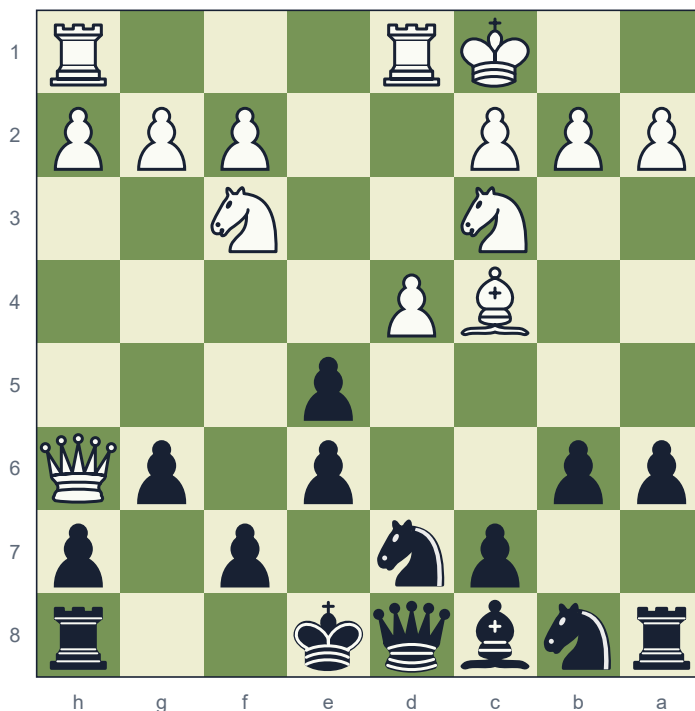
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The pawn captures a pawn on f5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-06 / White tries Bh6



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

Black develops Nf6 before this bishop-exchange sequence. White removes the fianchetto bishop and places the queen near the king side, creating a real dark-square concern.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns e5, e6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

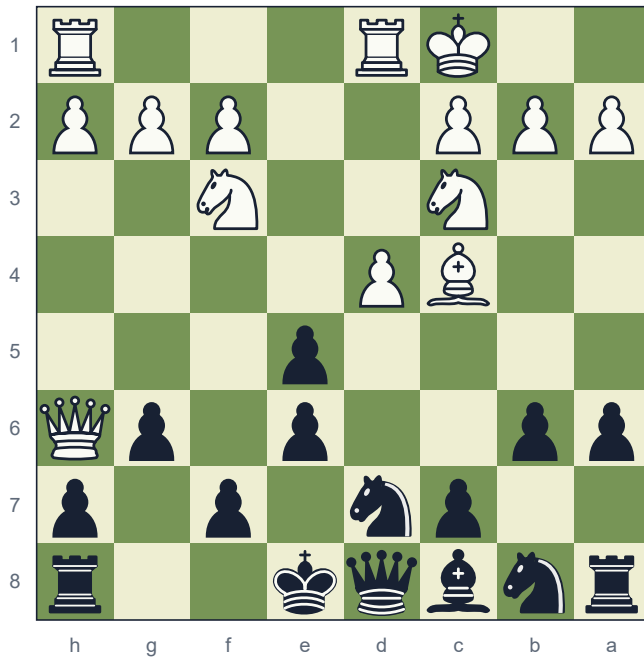
If the black knight were still on g8, Qxh6 would lose the queen to ...Nxh6. The developed knight is an essential detail in this line. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

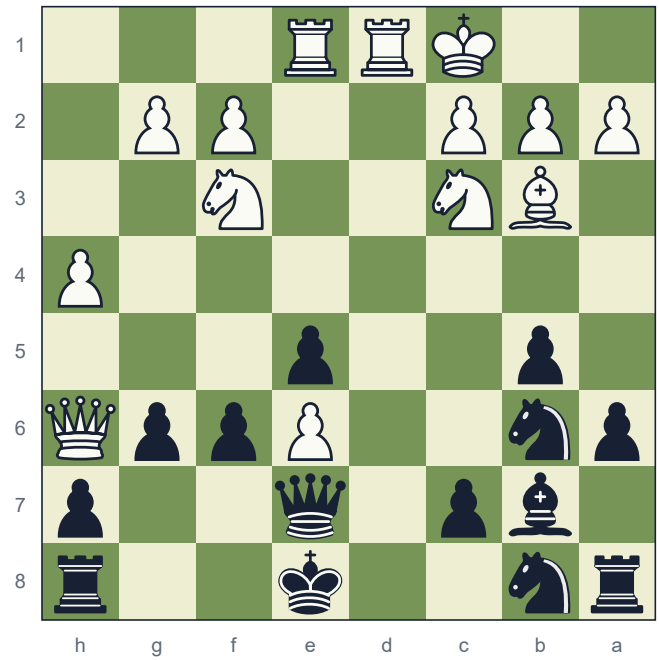
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

HB-LAB-06 / play and explain 1

11... Bb7 12. d5 Qe7 13. Rhe1 b5 14. Bb3 f6 15. dxe6 Nb6 16. h4



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... BB7

Places the bishop on b7, attacking knight on f3. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

13... B5

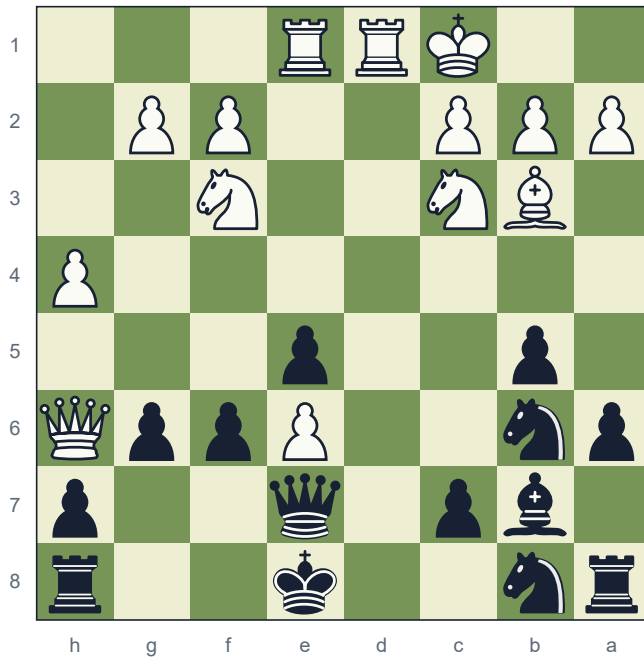
Places the pawn on b5, attacking bishop on c4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

REASSESS

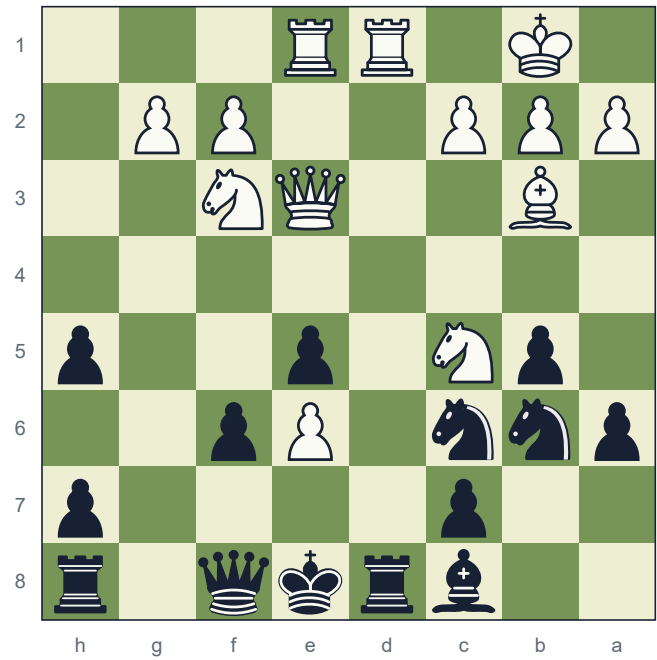
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HB-LAB-06 / play and explain 2

16... Nc6 17. h5 Qf8 18. Qe3 Rd8 19. Ne4 gxh5 20. Nc5 Bc8 21. Kb1



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... NC6

Develops toward d4 and e5. Check whether an opposing d5 advance would gain a tempo.

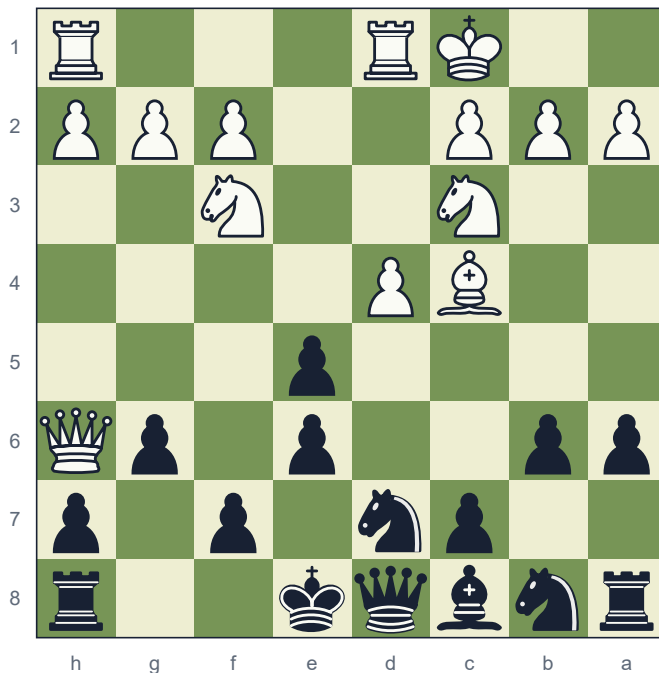
18... RD8

Places the rook on d8, attacking rook on d1. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HB-LAB-06 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Bb7 and b5. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns e5, e6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE BB7

11... Bb7 12. d5 Qe7 13. Rhe1 b5 14. Bb3 f6 15. dxe6 Search estimate: -2.09 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE B5

11... b5 12. Bb3 Qe7 13. d5 Qf8 14. Qh3 Nc5 15. Nxe5 Search estimate: -2.14 from Black's perspective.

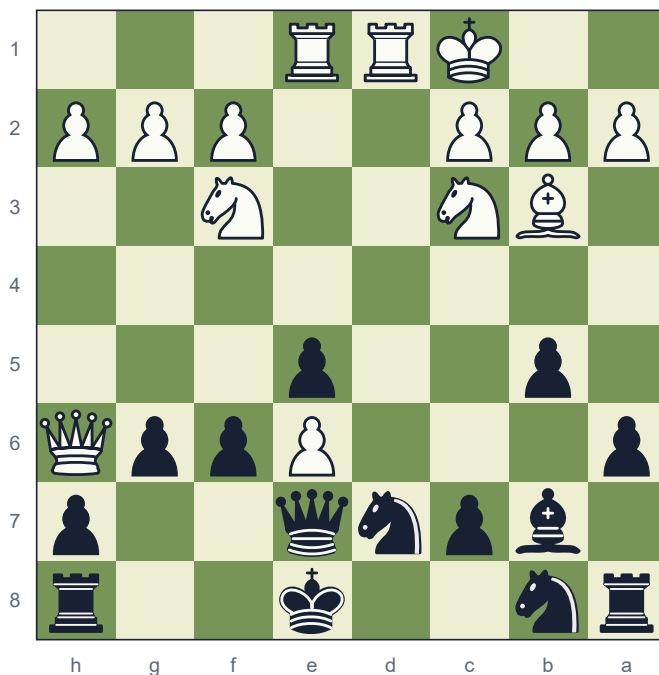
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the bishop on b7, attacking knight on f3. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-06 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nb6 and Nc5. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e6. Black king e8; central-file pawns e5, f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NB6

15... Nb6 16. h4 Nc6 17. h5 Qf8 18. Qe3 Rd8 19. Ne4 Search estimate: -2.49 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE NC5

15... Nc5 16. Nd2 Nxb3+ 17. Nxb3 b4 18. Nd5 Bxd5 19. Rxd5 Search estimate: -2.64 from Black's perspective.

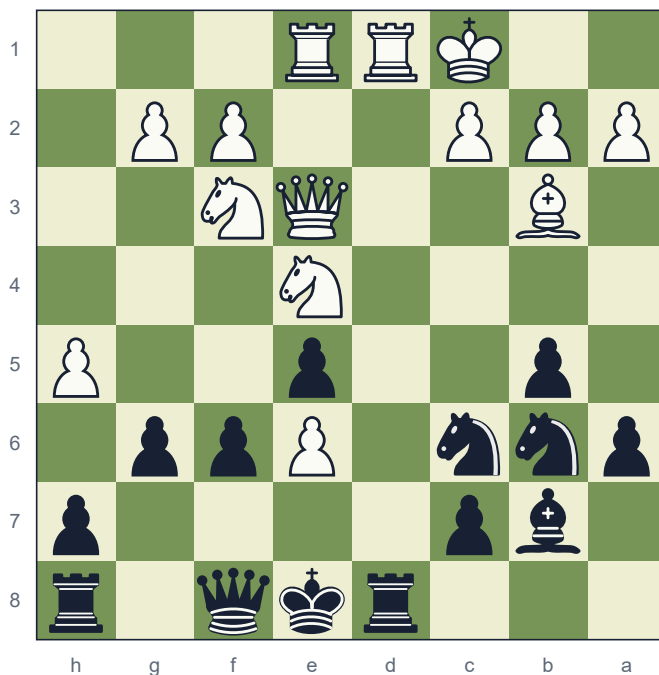
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the knight on b6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HB-LAB-06 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

gxh5 and Qg7. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e6. Black king e8; central-file pawns e5, f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE GXH5

19... gxh5 20. Nc5 Rxd1+ 21. Rxd1 Bc8 22. Kb1 Nc4 23. Bxc4 Search estimate: -2.44 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE QG7

19... Qg7 20. Nc5 Rxd1+ 21. Rxd1 Bc8 22. Kb1 Na5 23. Nh4 Search estimate: -2.73 from Black's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The pawn captures a pawn on h5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

48 exercises / instructions

THREE KINDS OF QUESTION

Questions 1-24 test opening recall, 25-36 test plans and defense, and 37-48 compare concrete candidates from the laboratories. These are not all tactical puzzles and do not all have one uniquely best move.

WORK WITHOUT THE ANSWER

Use a board and write your answer. Spend two to five minutes on a recall question and five to ten on a candidate comparison. Name the opponent's threat before choosing your own move.

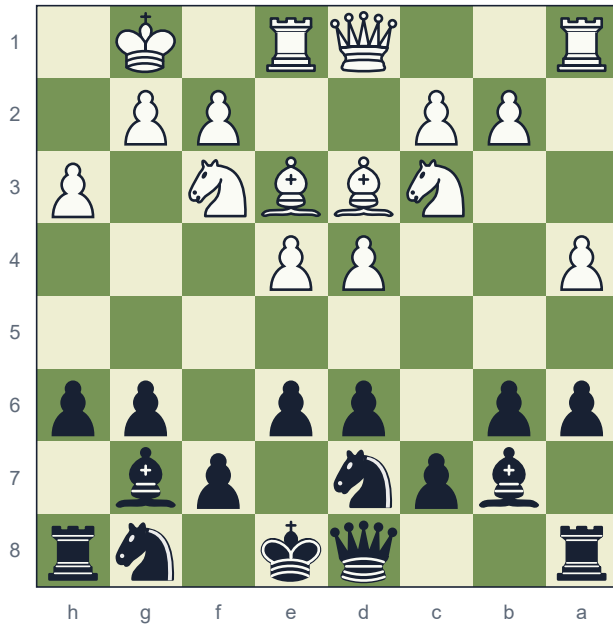
MARKING

Award one point for a legal, relevant choice or plan; one for a clear reason; one for recognizing the opponent's resource; and one for a supporting variation or accurate description of the structure. Maximum: 192. Do not reward memorized notation that you cannot explain.

ANSWERS ARE LATER

The question pages come first, followed by explained answers and sample continuations. In planning questions the sample answer is a guide, not an exhaustive list of reasonable plans.

Exercises 1-2



Black to move

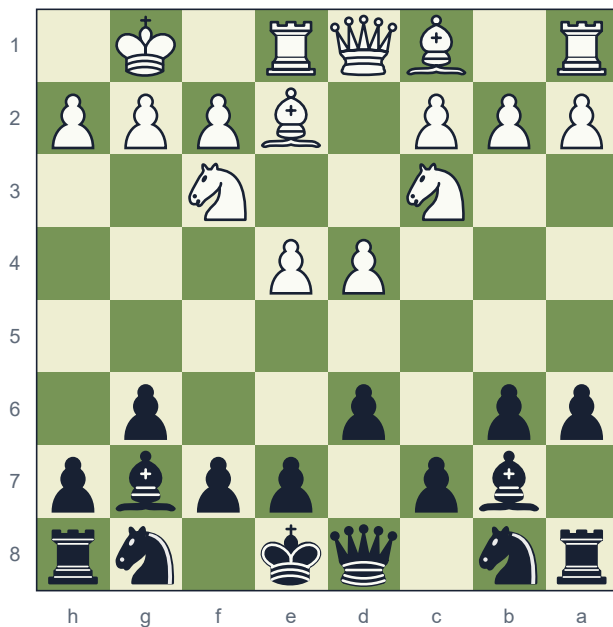
01 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

02 / OPENING RECALL

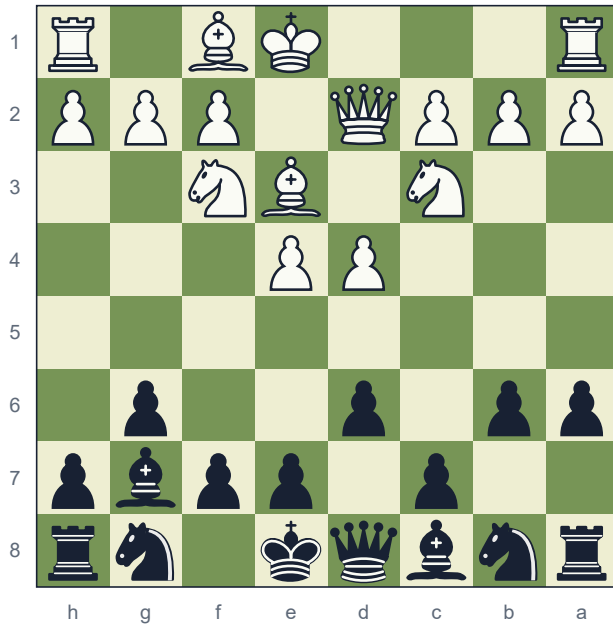
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 3-4



Black to move

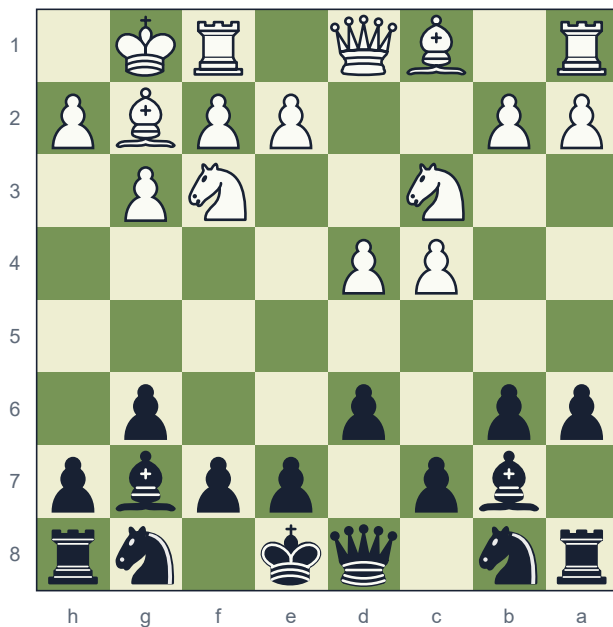
03 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

04 / OPENING RECALL

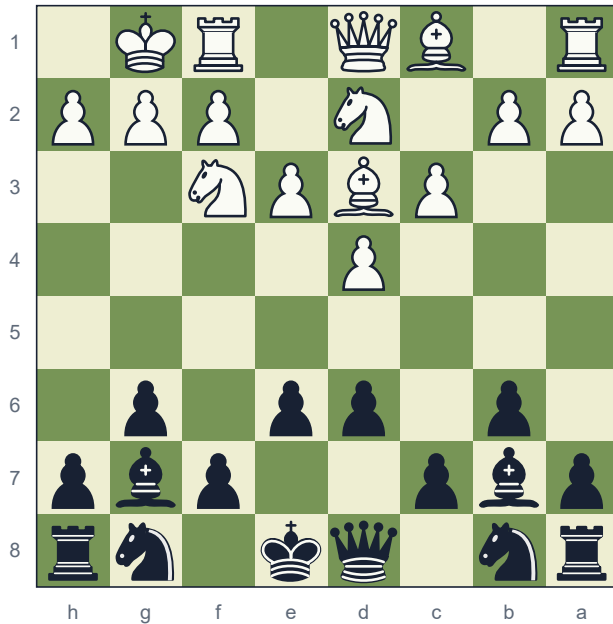
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 5-6



Black to move

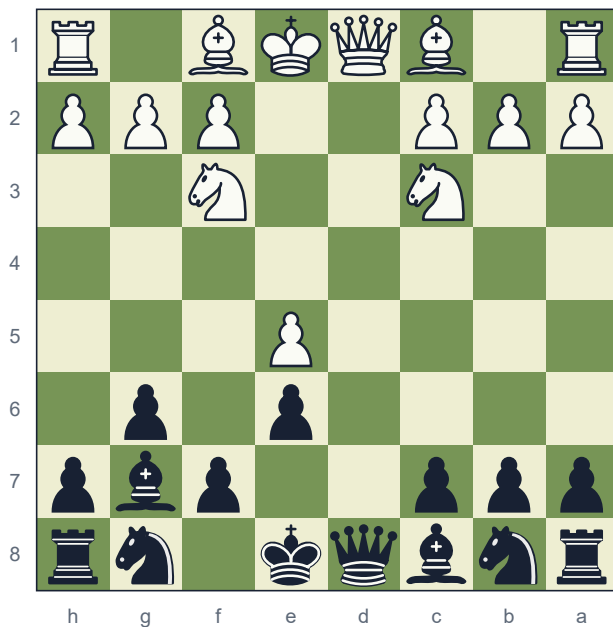
05 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

06 / OPENING RECALL

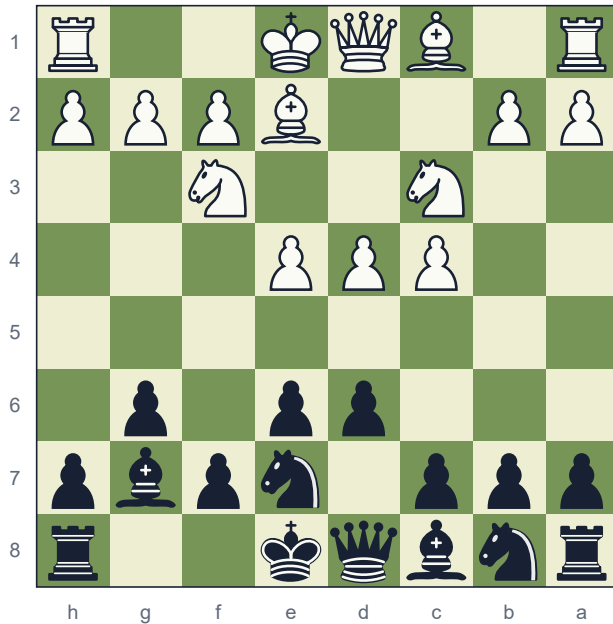
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 7-8



Black to move

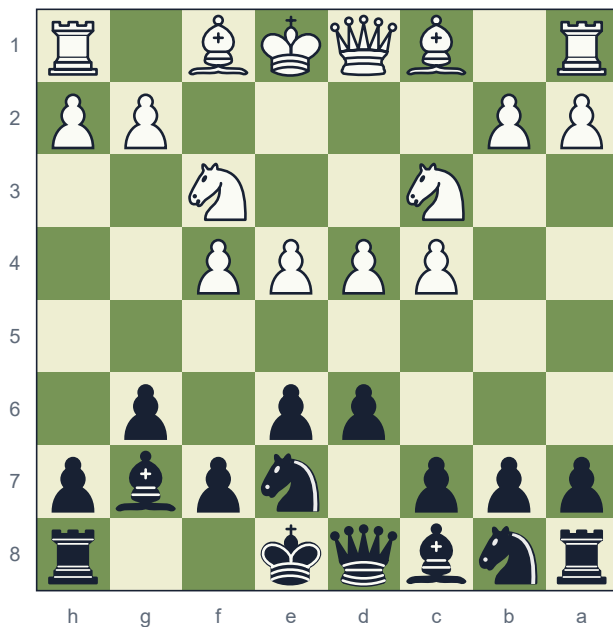
07 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

08 / OPENING RECALL

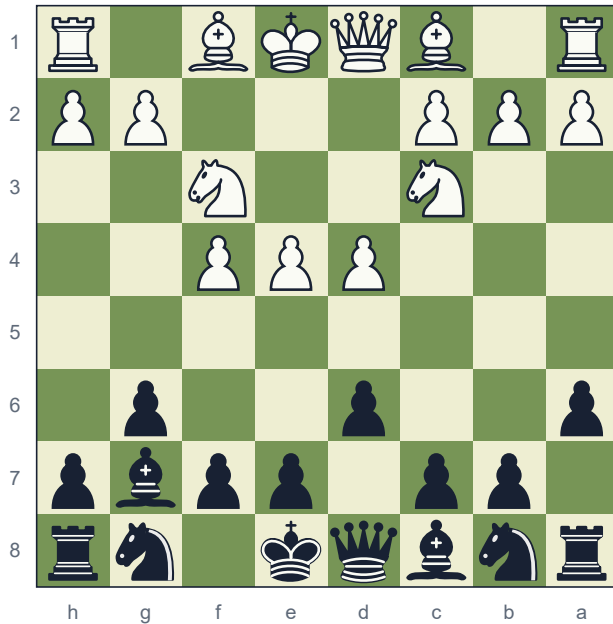
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 9-10



Black to move

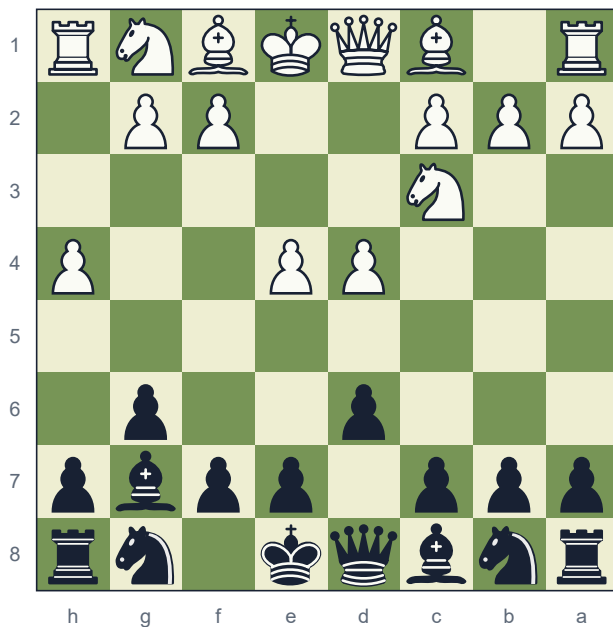
09 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

10 / OPENING RECALL

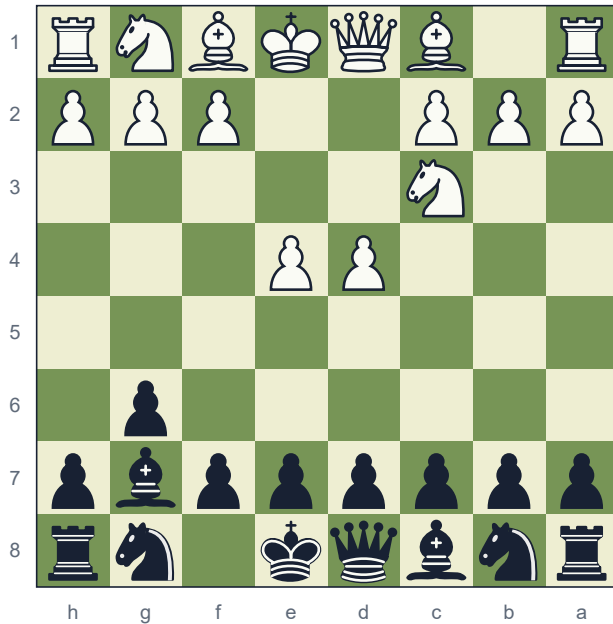
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 11-12



Black to move

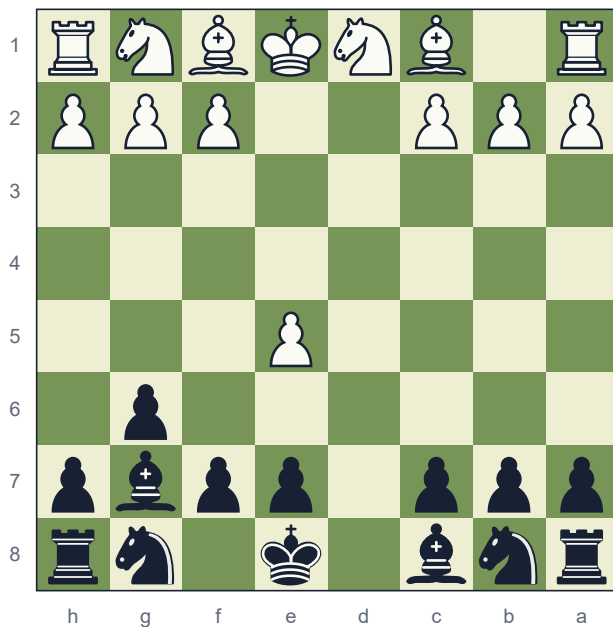
11 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

12 / OPENING RECALL

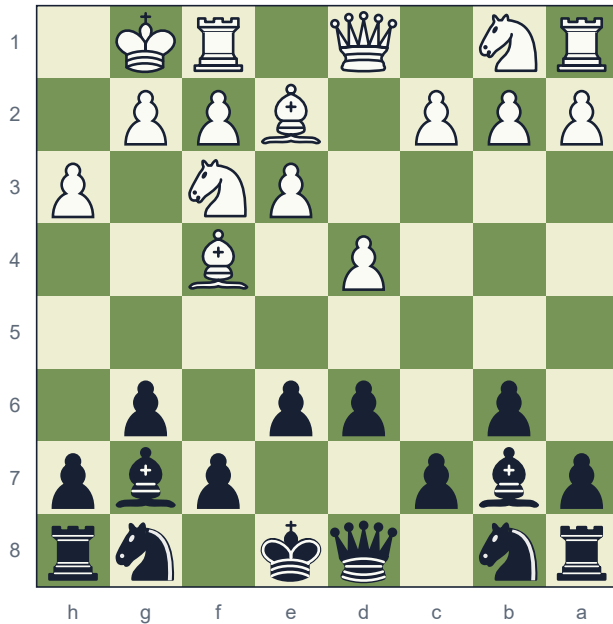
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 13-14



Black to move

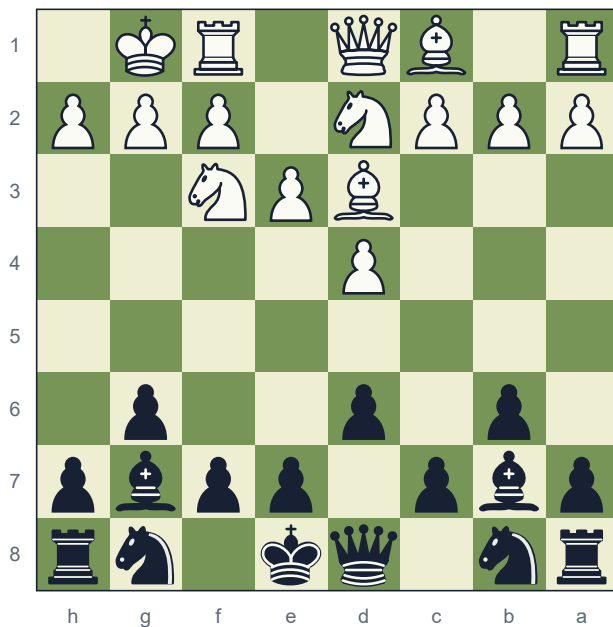
13 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

14 / OPENING RECALL

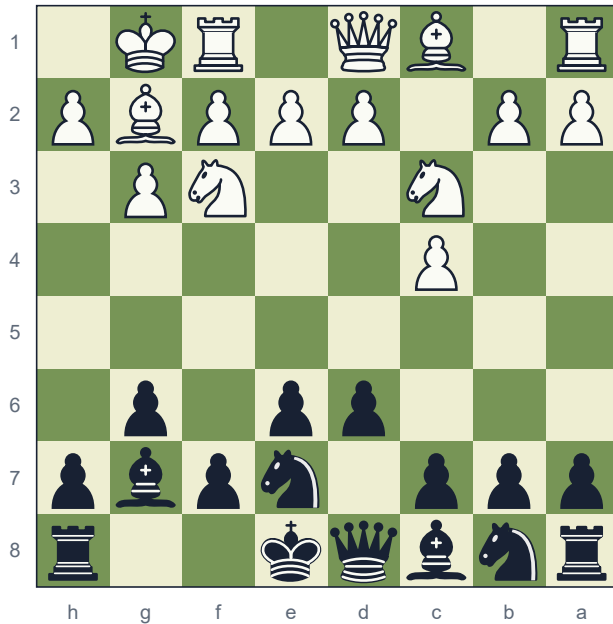
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 15-16



Black to move

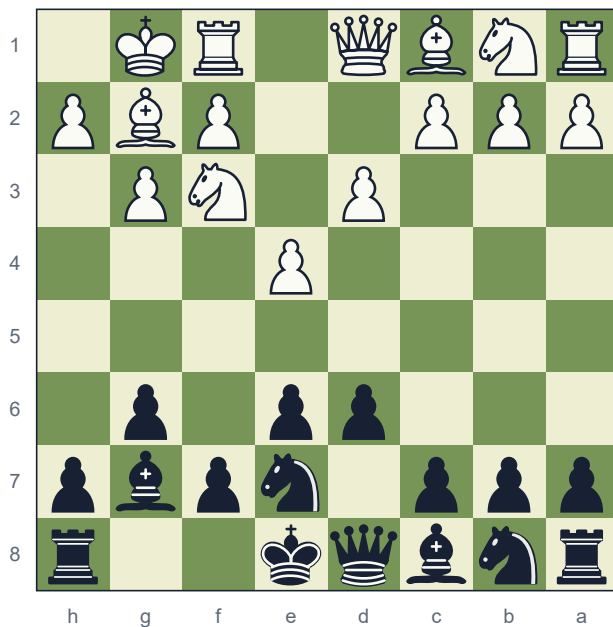
15 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

16 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 17-18



Black to move

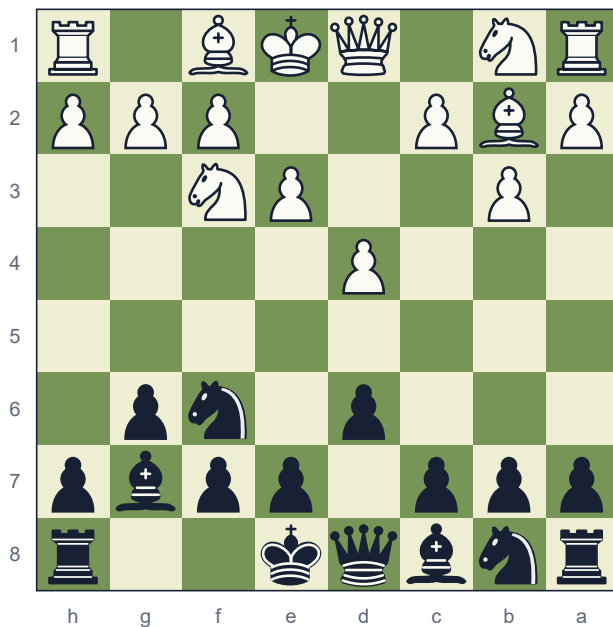
17 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

18 / OPENING RECALL

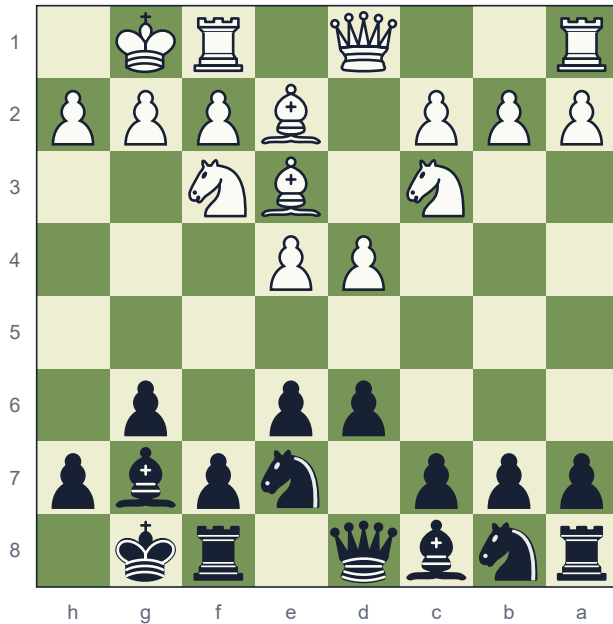
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 19-20



Black to move

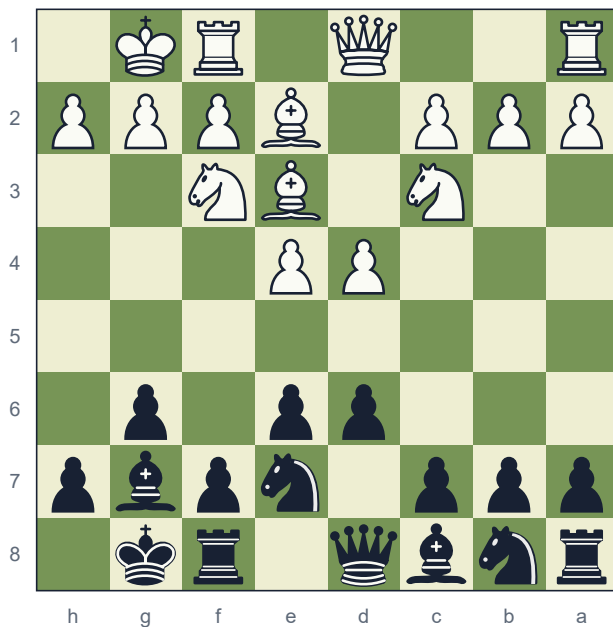
19 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

20 / OPENING RECALL

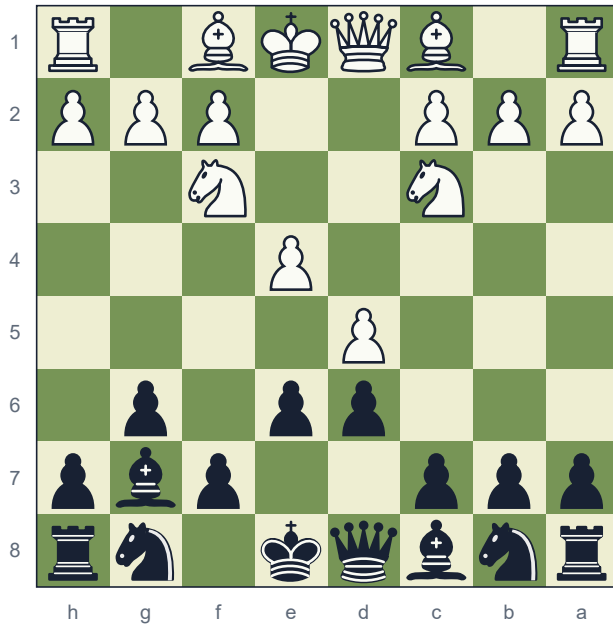
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 21-22



Black to move

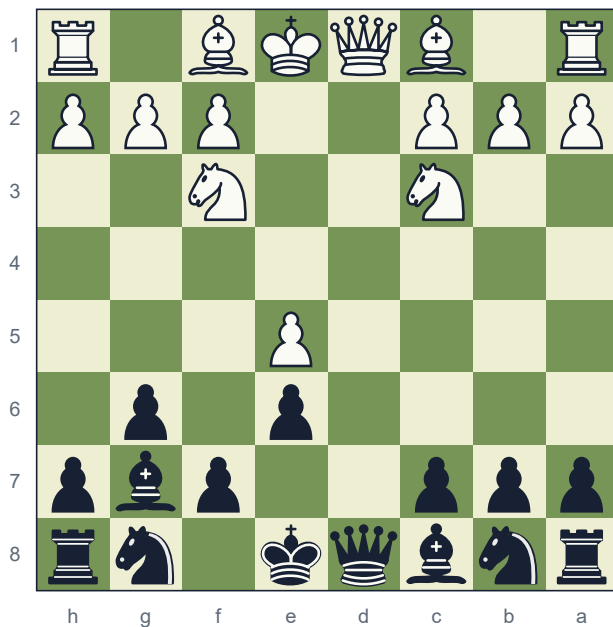
21 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

22 / OPENING RECALL

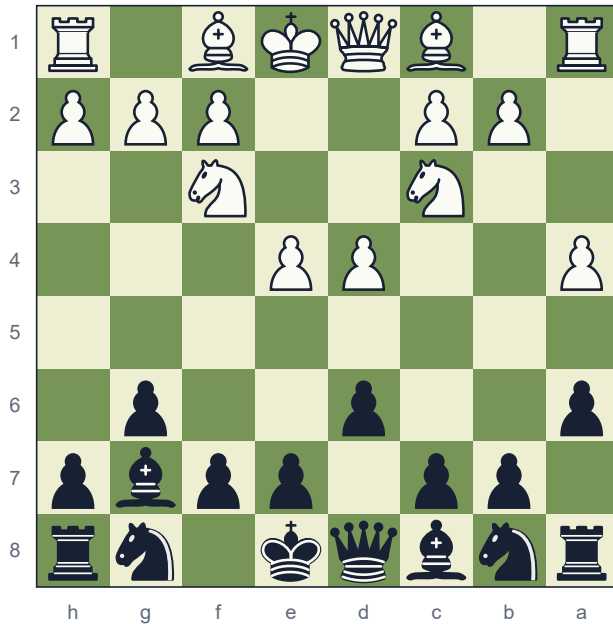
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 23-24



Black to move

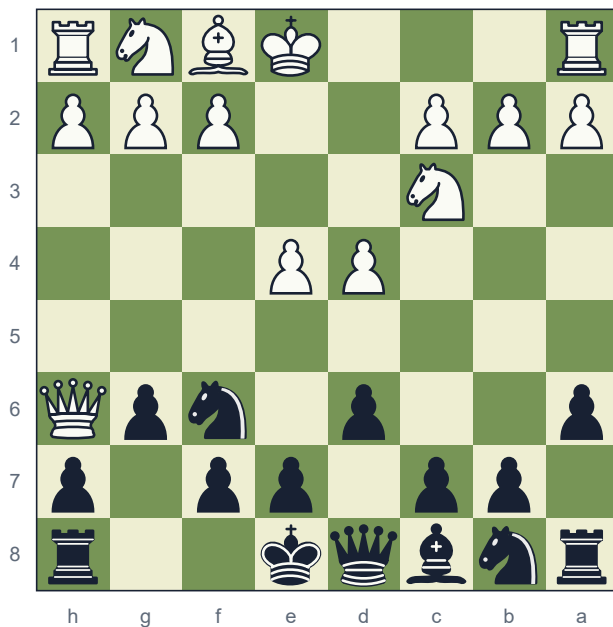
23 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

24 / OPENING RECALL

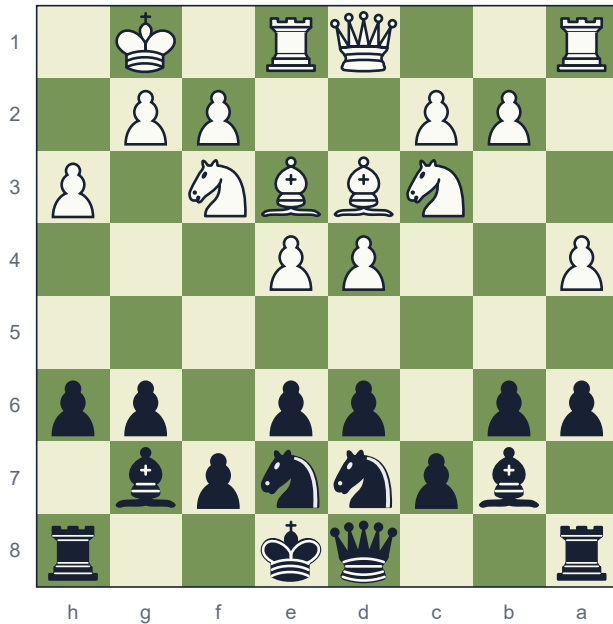
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 25-26



White to move

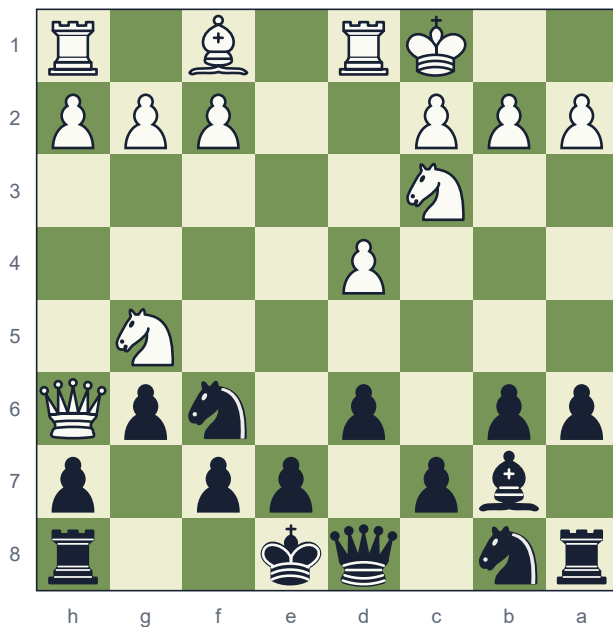
25 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

26 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

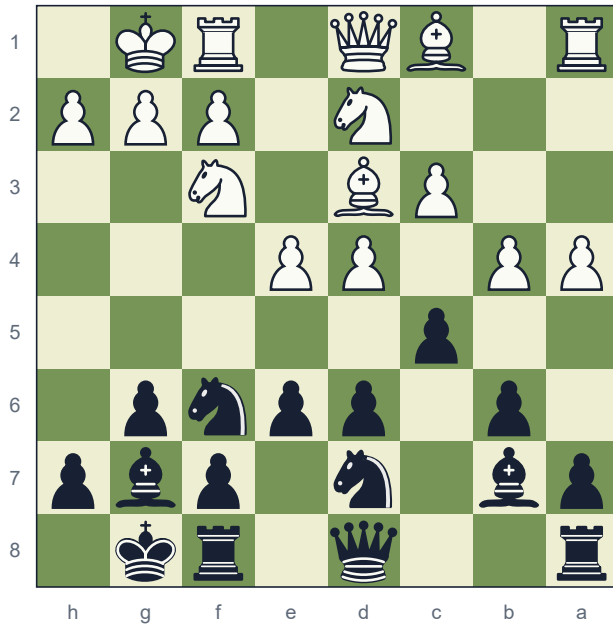
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 27-28



White to move

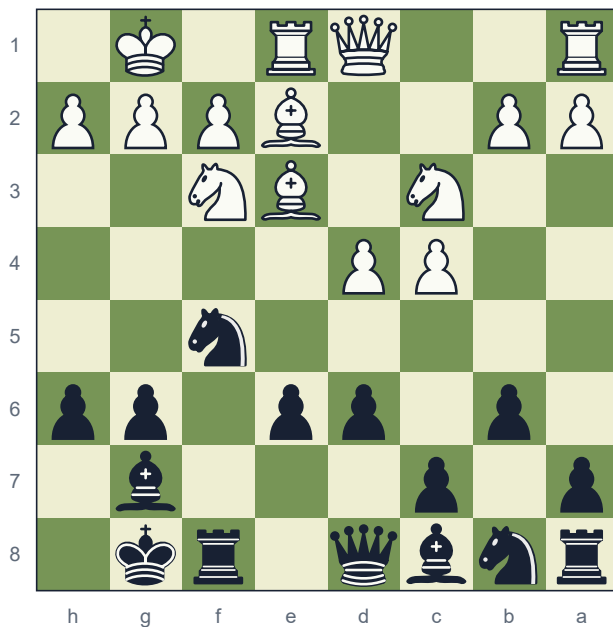
27 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

28 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

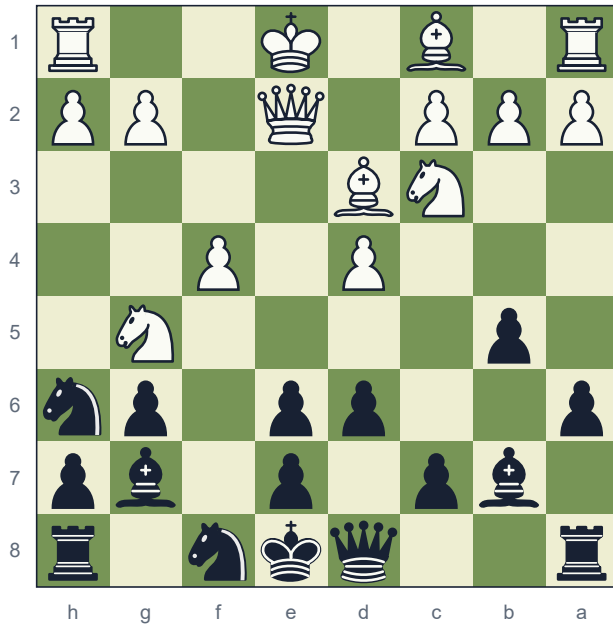
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 29-30



White to move

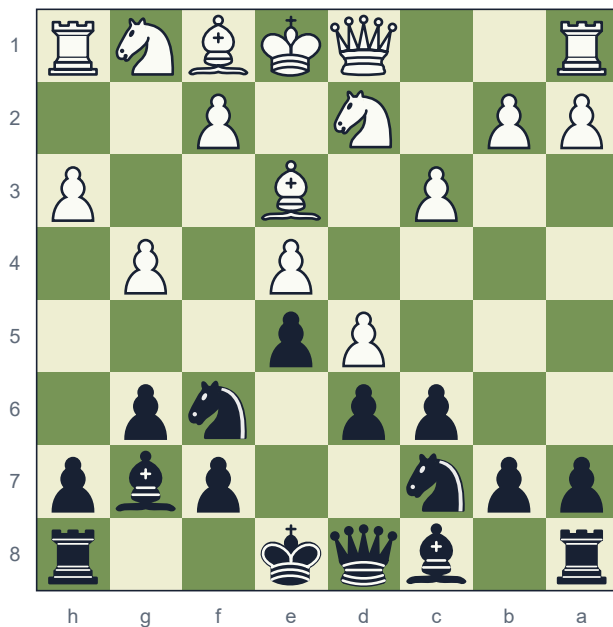
29 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

30 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

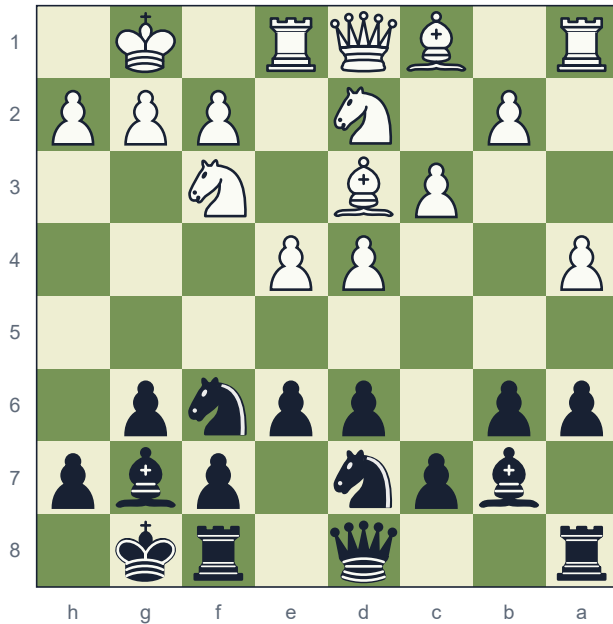
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 31-32



White to move

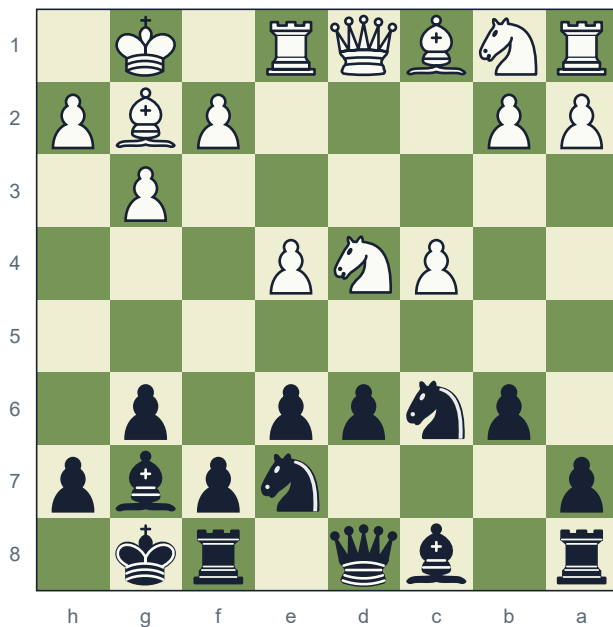
31 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

32 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

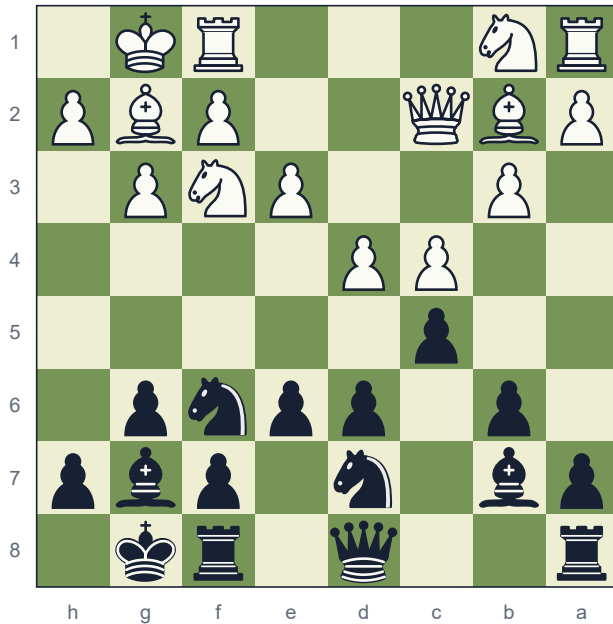
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 33-34



White to move

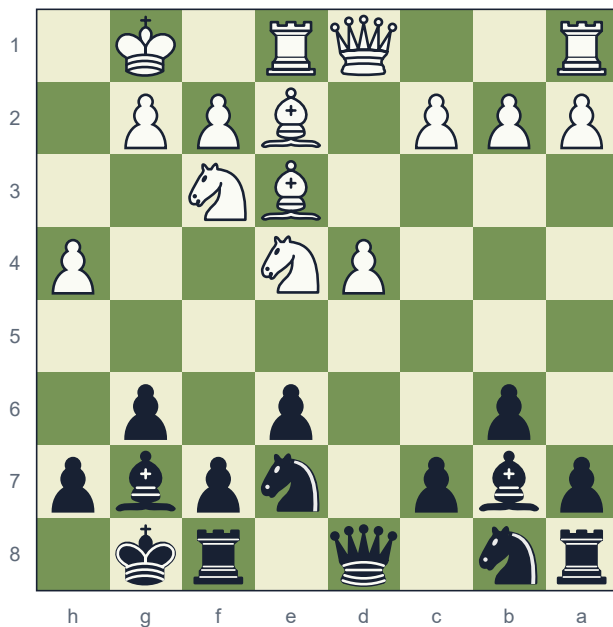
33 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

34 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

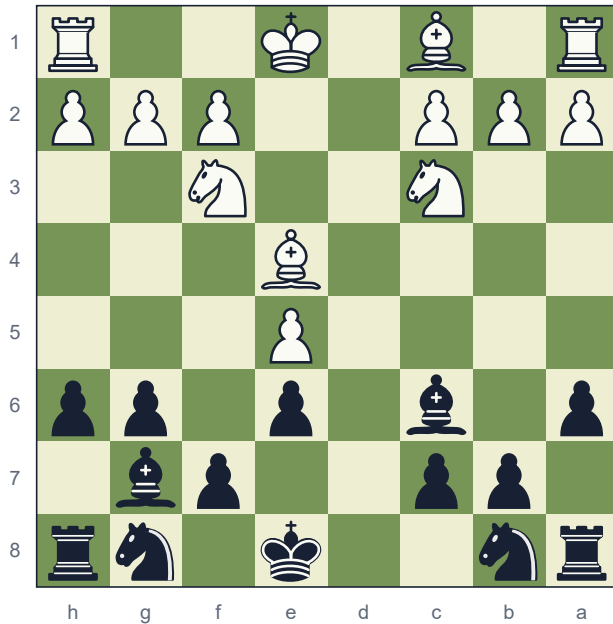
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 35-36



White to move

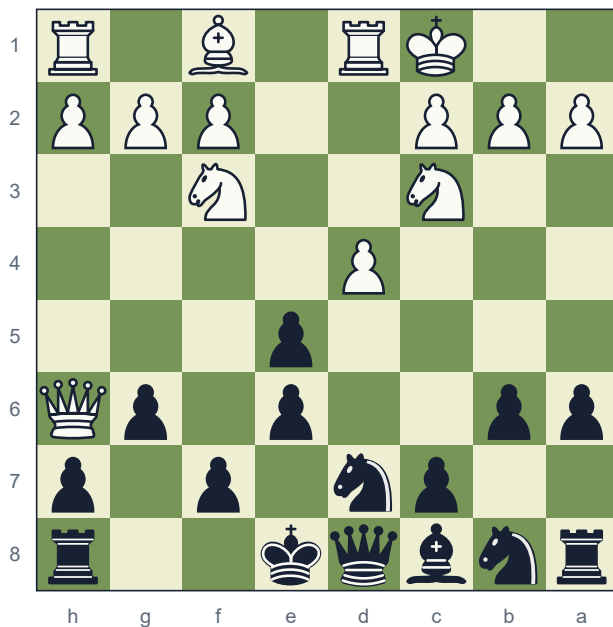
35 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

36 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

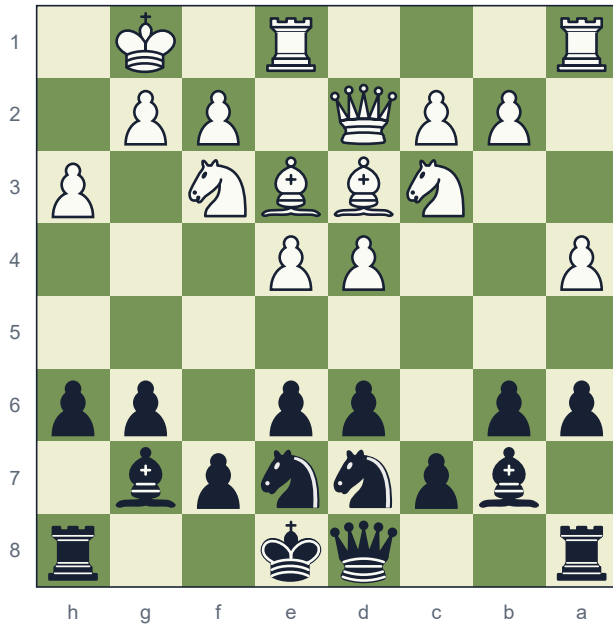
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 37-38



Black to move

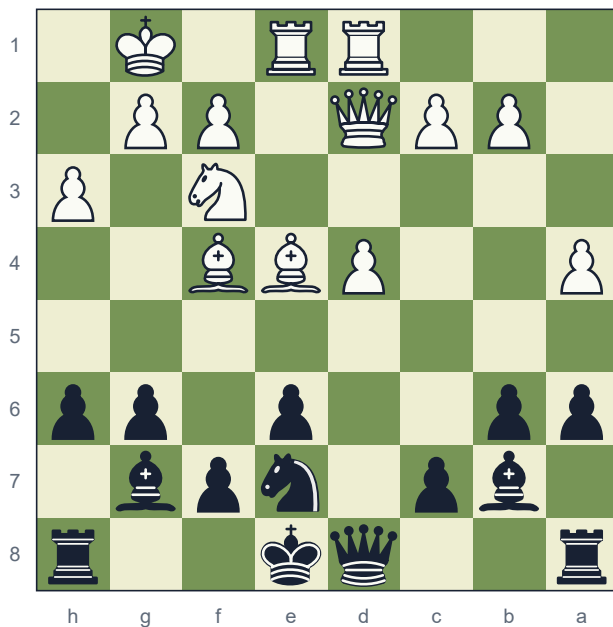
37 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare d5 with Nf6. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

38 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

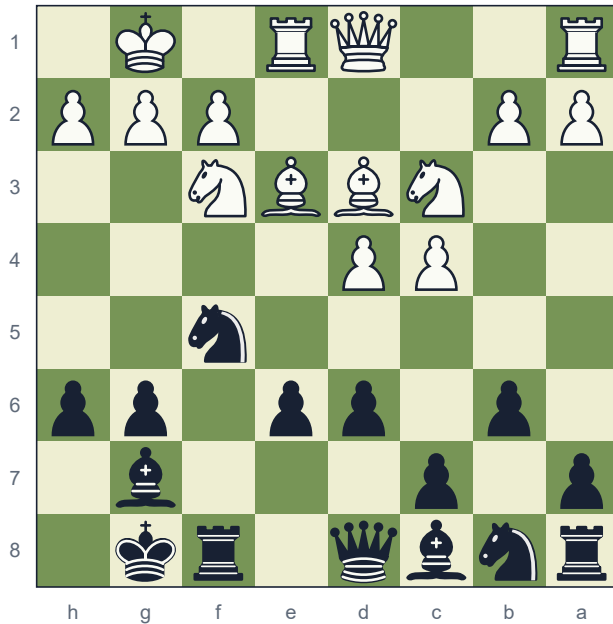
Compare Bxe4 with Bd5. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 39-40



Black to move

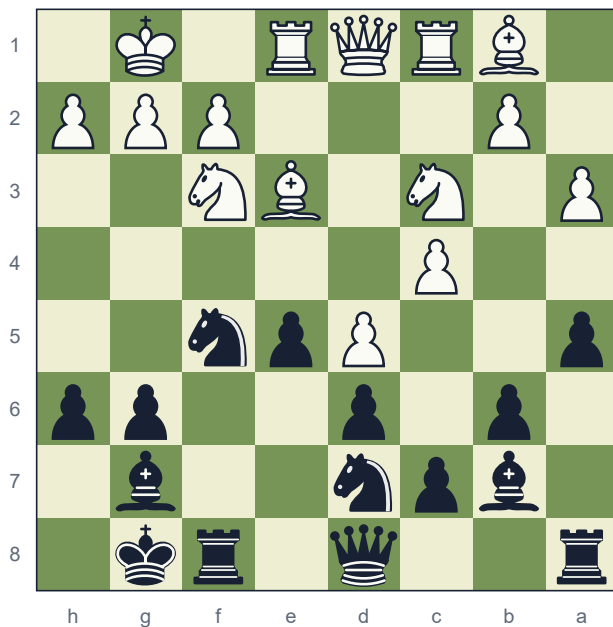
39 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Nc6 with Nd7. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

40 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

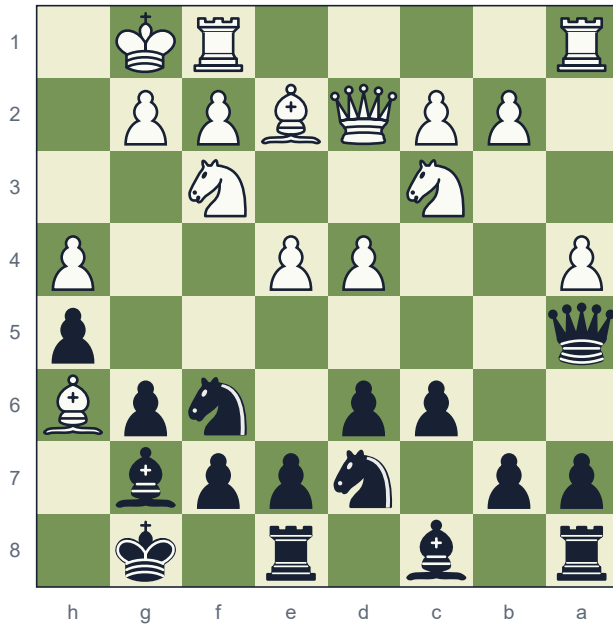
Compare Nf6 with Ba6. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 41-42



Black to move

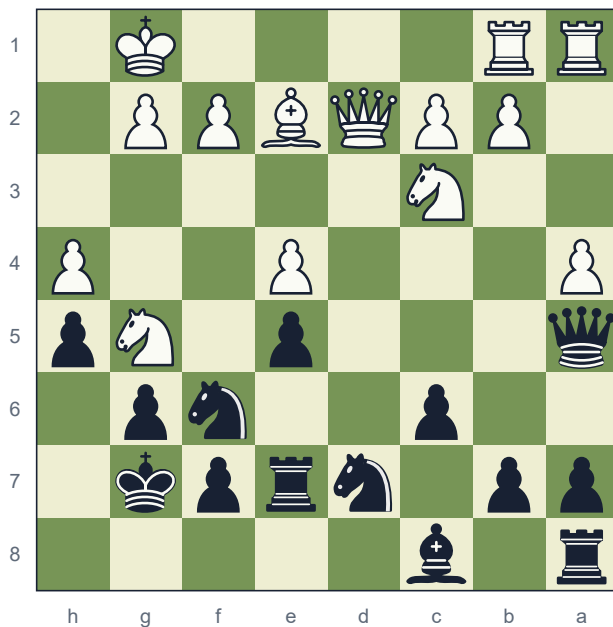
41 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Nf8 with e5. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

42 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

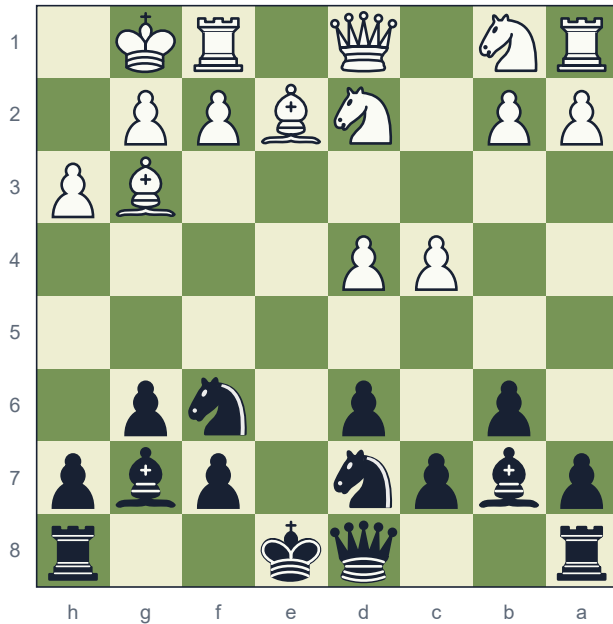
Compare Qc7 with Nf8. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 43-44



Black to move

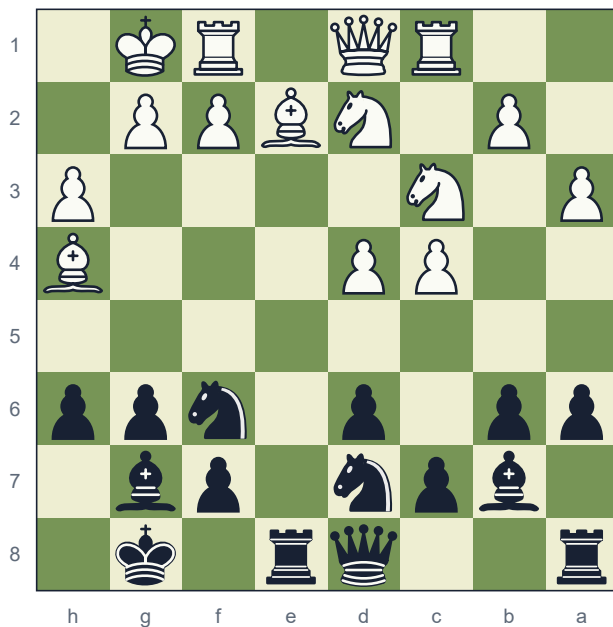
43 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare h6 with O-O. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

44 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

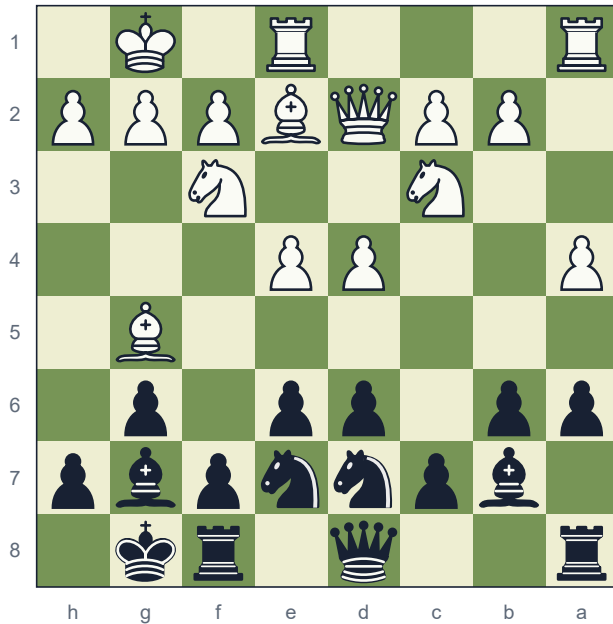
Compare Nf8 with Qc8. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 45-46



Black to move

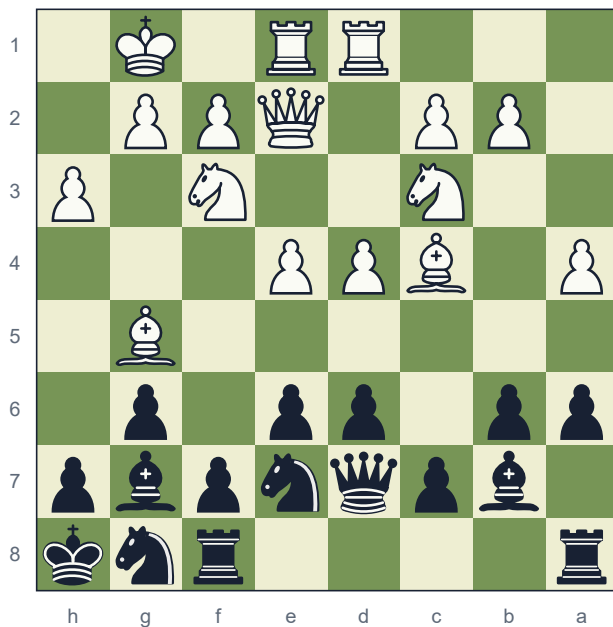
45 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Re8 with Kh8. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

46 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

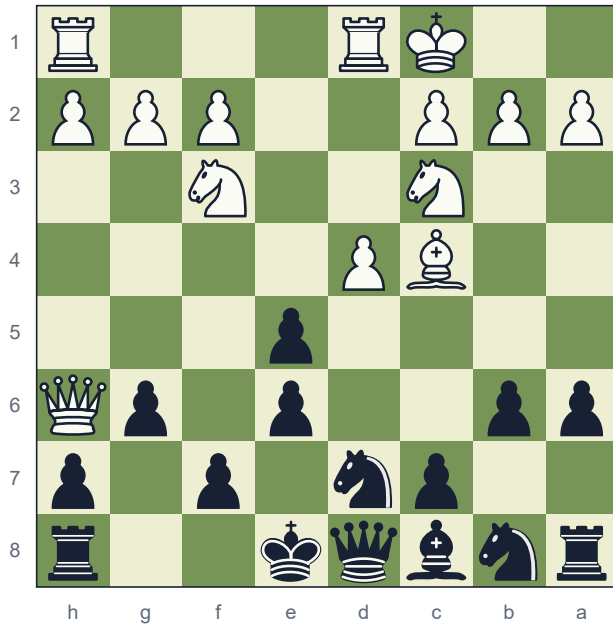
Compare f6 with h6. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 47-48



Black to move

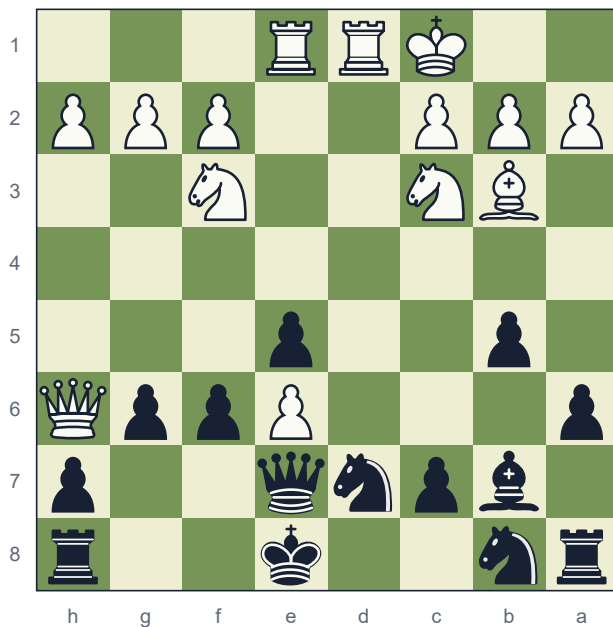
47 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare b5 with Bb7. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

48 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Nb6 with Nc5. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Answers 1-2

01 / HB-01

Course move: 10... Ne7. This illustrative route shows the recognizable formation when White develops quietly. The knights avoid blocking the fianchetto bishops, but Black has used many pawn tempi and is still uncastled.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

10... Ne7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White owns more space and can prepare d5, e5 or a wing attack. Finishing the diagram is not a strategic achievement if Black then has no active move.

02 / HB-02

Course move: 7... e6. The bishop on e2 is less directly aimed at h7 than on d3, but White can support a central advance without exposing pieces. Black preserves flexibility.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7... e6 8. Be3 Nf6 9. e5 dxe5 10. Nxe5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White may use Bf1, a4 and d5 to squeeze. A lack of immediate threats is not permission for unlimited waiting.

Answers 3-4

03 / HB-03

Course move: 6... Bb7. White prepares flexible castling and may seek Bh6 to exchange the g7 bishop. Black must notice the attacking setup before automatically playing ...h6.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6... Bb7 7. O-O-O Nf6 8. Bh6 Bxh6 9. Qxh6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can castle long and push h4. Removing the fianchetto bishop may weaken dark squares around a castled black king.

04 / HB-04

Course move: 7... e6. Both sides have long-diagonal bishops, but White has more central space. The g2 bishop creates pressure against b7 when the center opens.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7... e6 8. e4 Nd7 9. Re1 h6 10. h4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can advance d5 or e4 with good support. A quiet fianchetto can still produce a strong squeeze.

Answers 5-6

05 / HB-05

Course move: 7... Nd7. Without c4 White has less queenside space but a compact center. Black can develop flexibly and often challenge d4 with ...c5.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7... Nd7 8. e4 Ngf6 9. a4 O-O 10. b4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

e4 can suddenly build a broad center and threaten e5. The modest e3 setup may be a preparation rather than a permanent concession.

06 / HB-06

Course move: 6... Qxd1+. Central exchanges can open the d-file and permit a queen trade. Black is no longer building a full Hippo and should value development and king activity accordingly.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6... Qxd1+ 7. Nxd1 b6 8. Bb5+ Bd7 9. Be2

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White retains space and can develop quickly. Queenless positions still punish undeveloped pieces and weak pawns.

Answers 7-8

07 / HB-07

Course move: 6... O-O. White occupies c4-d4-e4. Black chooses a partial formation and castles instead of insisting on both fianchettos before addressing the center.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6... O-O 7. O-O h6 8. Re1 b6 9. Be3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can gain more space with d5 or build a kingside attack with f4. Do not add ...a6 and ...h6 automatically under a development deficit.

08 / HB-08

Course move: 6... O-O. White adds f4 and may push e5 or f5. Black prioritizes development and king safety; a full Hippo is not the automatic answer.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6... O-O 7. Be3 Nd7 8. Qd2 a6 9. Bf2

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White's attack may become dangerous if allowed to consolidate every pawn. You need a break, not merely a compact-looking position.

Answers 9-10

09 / HB-09

Course move: 5... b5. Black uses a partial formation with immediate queenside activity. ...b5 aims for ...Bb7 and may question Nc3 with ...b4; it is a concrete response to White's central ambition.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5... b5 6. Bd3 Bb7 7. Qe2 Nd7 8. e5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

e5 can arrive with tempo against Black's pieces. A queenside expansion does not excuse ignoring the central breakthrough.

10 / HB-10

Course move: 4... h5. ...h5 stops the immediate h4-h5 lever. Black accepts a fixed kingside structure rather than allowing White to open the h-file by force.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

4... h5 5. Bg5 Nf6 6. Qd2 c6 7. a4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

g4 can attack the new h5 hook. A blocked h-pawn does not mean the king side is permanently safe.

Answers 11-12

11 / HB-11

Course move: 3... d6. White spends time on a wing attack before completing development. Black must calculate central action instead of reacting only on the attacked wing.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

3... d6 4. g4 Nc6 5. d5 Nd4 6. h3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A careless ...h6 can provide the exact hook White wants. Do not complete a decorative pawn wall while the g-pawn advances.

12 / HB-12

Course move: 6... Nc6. Black opens the center and trades queens, then develops with pressure on e5. The immediate central decision takes precedence over any plan to double fianchetto.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6... Nc6 7. f4 f6 8. Bb5 Bd7 9. exf6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can defend e5 and use the space advantage. A queen trade is a transition to a playable struggle, not proof that Black has won a pawn.

Answers 13-14

13 / HB-13

Course move: 7... Nd7. White's bishop develops outside the pawn chain and may support e5. Black uses the double fianchetto while keeping the central break flexible.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7... Nd7 8. c4 Ngf6 9. Nfd2 e5 10. Bg3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can use Nbd2, c3 and e4 to expand. The London label does not guarantee that White will remain passive.

14 / HB-14

Course move: 6... e6. White has achieved e4 and threatens to gain more space. Black must reassess the center at once instead of treating the earlier e3 structure as unchanged.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6... e6 7. e4 Nf6 8. a4 a6 9. Re1

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

e5 can attack a developed knight or open attacking diagonals. White's bishop on d3 already aims toward the king side.

Answers 15-16

15 / HB-15

Course move: 6... O-O. White keeps d4 and e4 flexible. Black can choose a partial Hippo without spending time on both wing pawn pairs.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6... O-O 7. d3 c5 8. d4 Nbc6 9. d5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can choose d4 in one move and open the center quickly. A slow complete formation may allow a favorable central transformation for White.

16 / HB-16

Course move: 6... b6. White adopts a King's Indian Attack shape. Black can double fianchetto but should watch whether e5 would gain space with a useful tempo.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6... b6 7. d4 O-O 8. Re1 c5 9. c4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White may switch to c4 or e5 depending on Black's center. The system is not immune to a change of plan.

Answers 17-18

17 / HB-17

Course move: 6... b6. White's f-pawn gives kingside space but also changes the e3 and e4 squares. Black's g7 bishop can become useful against the long diagonal.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6... b6 7. c3 Bb7 8. e4 O-O 9. Be3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can push e4 and f5. Do not wait until every break has become difficult.

18 / HB-18

Course move: 5... e6. The bishop on b2 already attacks g7 along an open diagonal. Black first develops Nf6 to block that line before placing an undefended bishop on g7.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5... e6 6. g3 b6 7. Bg2 Bb7 8. O-O

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Playing ...Bg7 immediately after Bb2 would simply leave that bishop en prise. A normal-looking fianchetto is not safe in every move order.

Answers 19-20

19 / HB-19

Course move: 7... Nd7. Black develops the queen knight before forcing a central break. In this exact position an immediate ...c5 allows strong white play; a thematic move still needs preparation.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7... Nd7 8. Qd2 a6 9. a4 b6 10. Rfe1

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can improve with Qd2 or advance in the center. Do not assume that a break becomes good simply because it belongs to the opening's vocabulary.

20 / HB-20

Course move: 7... d5. ...d5 directly challenges e4 but creates a new pawn contact and can be captured. Black chooses activity instead of preserving the original d6-e6 shell.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7... d5 8. Re1 dxe4 9. Nxe4 b6 10. h4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A premature ...d5 can leave a weak isolated pawn or open lines before development is ready. Calculate all forcing replies.

Answers 21-22

21 / HB-21

Course move: 5... e5. Black meets d5 with ...e5 and closes the center. This gives a clear pawn-chain structure but also restricts the g7 bishop.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5... e5 6. Be2 Ne7 7. Be3 Nd7 8. g4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can expand with c4 and b4 or attack on the king side. A blocked center gives maneuvering time, not unlimited time.

22 / HB-22

Course move: 6... Qxd1+. Black exchanges the advanced pawn and uses the open d-file to trade queens. In this exact move order, blocking with ...d5 gives White a stronger bind and attacking chances.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6... Qxd1+ 7. Nxd1 Bd7 8. Nc3 a6 9. Bd3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White retains space and can consolidate the advanced pawn. A queen trade changes the type of struggle rather than ending it.

Answers 23-24

23 / HB-23

Course move: 5... b6. White restrains ...b5. Black can still develop the bishop through b7, but should not force the pawn advance through a well-controlled square.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5... b6 6. Bc4 e6 7. h4 h6 8. d5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White may use a5 to fix queenside weaknesses. A pawn move intended as flexibility can become a target.

24 / HB-24

Course move: 7... b6. Black develops Nf6 before this bishop-exchange sequence. White removes the fianchetto bishop and places the queen near the king side, creating a real dark-square concern.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7... b6 8. e5 Nfd7 9. Nf3 e6 10. O-O-O

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

If the black knight were still on g8, Qxh6 would lose the queen to ...Nxh6. The developed knight is an essential detail in this line.

Answers 25-26

25 / HB-01

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, e4. Black king e8; central-file pawns d6, e6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Decide on king safety and a central break. Examine ...c5 against d4 and ...d5 against e4; neither move is compulsory or safe in every version.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White owns more space and can prepare d5, e5 or a wing attack. Finishing the diagram is not a strategic achievement if Black then has no active move. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

26 / HB-03

White to move. White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns d6, c7, e7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Compare ...e6 and ...Nd7 while choosing a safe king destination. If Bh6 is possible, decide whether to exchange, retreat or create central counterplay.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can castle long and push h4. Removing the fianchetto bishop may weaken dark squares around a castled black king. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 27-28

27 / HB-05

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c3, d4, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c5, d6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Decide whether the f8 knight belongs on e7 or f6. Prepare castling and use ...c5 when the resulting exchanges do not expose your king.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

e4 can suddenly build a broad center and threaten e5. The modest e3 setup may be a preparation rather than a permanent concession. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

28 / HB-07

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c4, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns d6, e6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Prepare ...c5 or ...d5 with enough support. A bishop on b7 is useful only if its diagonal and the required tempi justify it.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can gain more space with d5 or build a kingside attack with f4. Do not add ...a6 and ...h6 automatically under a development deficit. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 29-30

29 / HB-09

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d4, f4. Black king e8; central-file pawns d6, e6, c7, e7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop the bishop and calculate e5 before each slow move. If the center opens, choose piece development and king safety over completing the usual pawn bank.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

e5 can arrive with tempo against Black's pieces. A queenside expansion does not excuse ignoring the central breakthrough. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

30 / HB-11

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns f2, c3, e4, d5. Black king e8; central-file pawns e5, c6, d6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Examine ...c5 or ...h5, checking captures and king safety. Develop with threats when possible; the center is the natural place to test a premature wing expansion.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A careless ...h6 can provide the exact hook White wants. Do not complete a decorative pawn wall while the g-pawn advances. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 31-32

31 / HB-14

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c3, d4, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns d6, e6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Consider ...Ne7, ...Nd7 and a timely ...c5, checking e5. If a pawn exchange frees a bishop, compare that activity with the loss of central restraint.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

e5 can attack a developed knight or open attacking diagonals. White's bishop on d3 already aims toward the king side. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

32 / HB-16

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c4, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns d6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop ...Bb7 and ...Nd7, then choose a central break. If White remains restrained, improve pieces before deciding the king side.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White may switch to c4 or e5 depending on Black's center. The system is not immune to a change of plan. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 33-34

33 / HB-18

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns f2, e3, c4, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c5, d6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop the queen side and choose a central break. This move order uses Nf6 instead of the standard Ne7 because a concrete threat determines the piece placement.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Playing ...Bg7 immediately after Bb2 would simply leave that bishop en prise. A normal-looking fianchetto is not safe in every move order. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

34 / HB-20

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns e6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Compare exd5 and e5, including the effect on the bishops. Reposition pieces toward the opened files instead of clinging to their original squares.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A premature ...d5 can leave a weak isolated pawn or open lines before development is ready. Calculate all forcing replies. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 35-36

35 / HB-22

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns e6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop actively and challenge e5 with pieces. King activity and pawn targets now matter more than recreating the full Hippo formation.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White retains space and can consolidate the advanced pawn. A queen trade changes the type of struggle rather than ending it. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

36 / HB-24

White to move. White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns e5, e6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop with attention to king safety and central counterplay. Choose the king's destination from the concrete threats instead of castling automatically toward the queen.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

If the black knight were still on g8, Qxh6 would lose the queen to ...Nxh6. The developed knight is an essential detail in this line. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 37-38

37 / HB-LAB-01

The finite search prefers Nf6 (-1.12 from Black's perspective), compared with d5 (-1.16 from Black's perspective). Develops the king knight toward e4 and d5. Its location also blocks some long-diagonal bishop attacks, but makes it a possible target of e5.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11... Nf6 12. Rad1

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11... d5 12. Bf4 g5 13. Bg3 O-O 14. e5 c5 15. h4

38 / HB-LAB-01

The finite search prefers Bxe4 (-1.21 from Black's perspective), compared with Bd5 (-1.41 from Black's perspective). The bishop captures a bishop on e4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15... Bxe4 16. Rxe4 Nd5 17. Be5 Nf6 18. Rf4 g5 19. Bxf6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15... Bd5 16. c4 Bxe4 17. Rxe4 c6 18. b3 b5 19. Re2

Answers 39-40

39 / HB-LAB-02

The finite search prefers Nd7 (-0.76 from Black's perspective), compared with Nc6 (-0.80 from Black's perspective). Develops a knight toward central supporting squares. Keep a useful onward route so the compact setup does not become overcrowded.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11... Nd7 12. Be4 Rb8 13. h3 a6 14. Qd2 g5 15. Rac1

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11... Nc6 12. Be4 Bb7 13. d5 Ne5 14. Nd4 Nxe3 15. Rxe3

40 / HB-LAB-02

The finite search prefers Nf6 (-0.72 from Black's perspective), compared with Ba6 (-0.77 from Black's perspective). Develops the king knight toward e4 and d5. Its location also blocks some long-diagonal bishop attacks, but makes it a possible target of e5.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15... Nf6 16. h3 Bc8 17. Bd2 Bd7 18. Nb5 Rc8 19. a4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15... Ba6 16. b3

Answers 41-42

41 / HB-LAB-03

The finite search prefers e5 (-0.59 from Black's perspective), compared with Nf8 (-0.64 from Black's perspective). Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11... e5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11... Nf8 12. Bxg7 Kxg7 13. Ng5 e5 14. f4 exd4 15. Qxd4

42 / HB-LAB-03

The finite search prefers Qc7 (-0.25 from Black's perspective), compared with Nf8 (-0.27 from Black's perspective). Places the queen on c7. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15... Qc7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15... Nf8 16. b4

Answers 43-44

43 / HB-LAB-04

The finite search prefers O-O (-0.47 from Black's perspective), compared with h6 (-0.48 from Black's perspective). Moves the king toward shelter and brings a rook toward the center. Check the resulting open lines before assuming the king is safe.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11... O-O 12. Nc3 Re8 13. Bh4 h6 14. a4 a6 15. Rc1

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11... h6 12. Nc3 O-O 13. Qc2 Nh7 14. Bf3 Bxf3 15. Nxf3

44 / HB-LAB-04

The finite search prefers Nf8 (-0.51 from Black's perspective), compared with Qc8 (-0.54 from Black's perspective). Places the knight on f8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15... Nf8 16. f4 Ne6 17. d5 Nd4 18. Bd3 Bc8 19. Nb3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15... Qc8 16. Re1

Answers 45-46

45 / HB-LAB-05

The finite search prefers Kh8 (-0.76 from Black's perspective), compared with Re8 (-0.79 from Black's perspective). Places the king on h8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11... Kh8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11... Re8 12. h4 Nf6 13. Bd3 h5 14. e5 Nh7 15. Ne4

46 / HB-LAB-05

The finite search prefers f6 (-0.70 from Black's perspective), compared with h6 (-0.81 from Black's perspective). Places the pawn on f6, attacking bishop on g5. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15... f6 16. Bc1 g5 17. Bb3 Ng6 18. Qd3 Qf7 19. Ne2

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15... h6 16. Bf4

Answers 47-48

47 / HB-LAB-06

The finite search prefers Bb7 (-2.09 from Black's perspective), compared with b5 (-2.14 from Black's perspective). Places the bishop on b7, attacking knight on f3. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11... Bb7 12. d5 Qe7 13. Rhe1 b5 14. Bb3 f6 15. dxe6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11... b5 12. Bb3 Qe7 13. d5 Qf8 14. Qh3 Nc5 15. Nxe5

48 / HB-LAB-06

The finite search prefers Nb6 (-2.49 from Black's perspective), compared with Nc5 (-2.64 from Black's perspective). Places the knight on b6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15... Nb6 16. h4 Nc6 17. h5 Qf8 18. Qe3 Rd8 19. Ne4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15... Nc5 16. Nd2 Nxb3+ 17. Nxb3 b4 18. Nd5 Bxd5 19. Rxd5

A 12-week course you can repeat

WEEKLY WORKLOAD

Aim for four study sessions of 30-45 minutes and two slow practice games. If that is too much, stretch each week to two weeks. Consistency and review matter more than finishing on a deadline.

A 35-MINUTE SESSION

Spend 5 minutes recalling yesterday's position, 10 minutes learning one decision, 15 minutes calculating or playing a position, and 5 minutes writing the lesson. Keep the answer hidden during recall.

USE A MASTERY GATE

Move on when you can reconstruct the main branch, explain its plan and name the opponent's counterplay on two different days. If not, repeat the decision with a changed opposing reply.

DO NOT STUDY EVERY BRANCH EQUALLY

Prioritize the first line of each family and the lines your opponents play. Optional alternatives are comparison material after the main repertoire is stable.

Weeks 1-3

WEEK 1 / BOARD SKILLS AND THINKING ROUTINE

00 foundations; practice coordinates, legal moves, notation and the blunder check. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 2 / FIRST OPENING FAMILY

01 family 1. Learn its main route, then two alternatives. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 3 / SECOND OPENING FAMILY

01 family 2. Compare the opponent's central choices. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 4-6

WEEK 4 / THIRD OPENING FAMILY

01 family 3. Add common deviations and one warning position. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 5 / FOURTH FAMILY AND BOUNDARIES

01 family 4. Distinguish the main repertoire from optional branches and bridges. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 6 / PAWN STRUCTURES

02 strategic lessons 1-4. Identify the correct break from the actual center. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 7-9

WEEK 7 / DEFENSE AND TACTICS

02 remaining lessons and calculation audits. Practice checks, captures and opponent resources. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 8 / FIRST THREE LABORATORIES

03 laboratories 1-3. Play each starting position from both sides. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 9 / LAST THREE LABORATORIES

03 laboratories 4-6. Compare candidates before revealing the engine lines. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 10-12

WEEK 10 / ENDGAME TRANSITIONS

02 endgames. Analyze one legal exchange sequence from your own game. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 11 / FULL RETRIEVAL TEST

04 questions 1-48. Write explanations before looking at answers. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 12 / CONSOLIDATE YOUR OWN REPERTOIRE

Repair recurring errors and build a small personal file of the positions you actually meet. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Pocket reference / 1

BUILDING THE FORMATION AGAINST A CLASSICAL CENTER

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

HB-01 The full formation as a study position

The formation is a starting point for decisions.

HB-02 White chooses Be2

Quiet opponents can win by restricting every break.

HB-03 White develops Be3 and Qd2

Identify the opponent's king choice before fixing yours.

HB-04 White fianchettoes the king bishop

Opening a diagonal can activate both bishops.

HB-05 White keeps the c-pawn on c2

Watch the next central expansion, not only the current one.

HB-06 An early queen exchange option

Once the center opens, leave the formation mindset.

Pocket reference / 2

LARGE CENTERS AND EARLY PAWN ATTACKS

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

HB-07 The three-pawn center

More opposing space demands earlier central action.

HB-08 The four-pawn center

Against four pawns, finish development and challenge them.

HB-09 The Austrian-style f4 center

Counterplay must arrive before the center breaks open.

HB-10 An immediate h-pawn attack

Stopping one lever creates a new contact to monitor.

HB-11 White plays g4 early

Counter a wing attack through the center when it is safe.

HB-12 White advances e5 early

Respond to a central break immediately.

Pocket reference / 3

OTHER FIRST MOVES AND POSITIONAL SYSTEMS

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

HB-13 Against the London bishop

The bishop on f4 changes the e5 square.

HB-14 Against the Colle structure

A prepared e4 changes the pace of the game.

HB-15 Against the English Opening

Flexible opposing pawns require flexible development.

HB-16 Against the Reti

Expect the opponent to change structures.

HB-17 Against the Bird

Identify which central square the f-pawn supports.

HB-18 Against 1.b3

Check the long diagonal before completing a fianchetto.

Pocket reference / 4

PAWN-BREAK CHOICES AND PARTIAL FORMATIONS

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

HB-19 Prepare ...c5 with development

Prepare the break and calculate its consequences.

HB-20 Use ...d5 to challenge e4

A central break is a concrete transformation, not a slogan.

HB-21 White closes with d5

A closed bishop needs a future pawn break.

HB-22 Meet the e5 advance by exchanging

Compare blocking with exchanging before fixing the center.

HB-23 A queenside space grab with a4

If a break is restrained, choose another useful plan.

HB-24 White tries Bh6

Check the knight's square before a queen recapture.

A practical game-analysis worksheet

GAME DETAILS

Date: _____ Opponent: _____ Time control: _____ Result: _____

FIRST UNFAMILIAR POSITION

Move number: _____ Relevant line ID: _____

What did the opponent's last move threaten? Write the FEN or save the position in your chess program.

MY CANDIDATES

Candidate A and a reply: _____

Candidate B and a reply: _____

Why did I choose the move I played?

DIAGNOSIS

Was the main error opening recall, missed tactics, the wrong pawn break, king safety, an exchange decision or time management? Choose the earliest cause that explains the later problem.

REPAIR

Write one concrete rule tied to the position. Add a short legal variation and schedule the next review. Do not add twenty engine moves that you cannot explain.

Glossary

ANCHOR

The authored move sequence defining a branch; later printed moves may be an illustrative continuation.

COMPENSATION

Activity, king pressure or structural advantages that may offset a material deficit.

COUNTERPLAY

Active threats or pressure that make the opponent address your ideas.

EN PRISE

A piece is available to be captured; check whether the capture is actually safe.

FIANCHETTO

Developing a bishop to b2, g2, b7 or g7 behind a moved b- or g-pawn.

INITIATIVE

The ability to pose threats that influence the opponent's replies.

ISOLATED PAWN

A pawn with no friendly pawn on either adjacent file.

Glossary / continued

MINORITY ATTACK

A pawn advance by fewer pawns against a larger pawn group to create weaknesses.

OUTPOST

A useful supported square for a piece, often difficult for enemy pawns to challenge.

PROPHYLAXIS

A move that anticipates and reduces the opponent's useful plan.

TEMPO

One move of time; useful tempi are gained when threats force helpful replies.

TRANSPOSITION

Different move orders reaching the same position with the same side to move and relevant rights.

ZWISCHENZUG

An intermediate move, often forcing, played before an expected recapture.

Sources and attribution

OPENING NAMES AND ROUTES

Lichess chess-openings is a CC0 reference for established names and entry move orders. The course commentary, study routes and practice curriculum are original. Some Hippo routes use descriptive teaching labels because opening-name databases use that term inconsistently.

<https://github.com/lichess-org/chess-openings>

ENGINE AND LEGAL-MOVE TOOLS

Stockfish 18 supplies finite tactical comparisons and illustrative continuations. python-chess 1.11.2 validates moves, positions and PGN.

<https://stockfishchess.org/download/>

<https://python-chess.readthedocs.io/>

PIECE ARTWORK

The Cburnett piece designs are by Colin M. L. Burnett, as distributed by python-chess. Adapted SVG sources, attribution and the GPL-2.0 license are included in Artwork_Credits_and_Sources. The palette and PDF drawing scale are adjusted; the original piece silhouettes are retained.

<https://python-chess.readthedocs.io/en/latest/svg.html>

Research scope and verification

HIPPO CONTEXT

The publisher's public description of The Hippopotamus Defence identifies a double-fianchetto system and partial formations. This course is independently authored; it does not reproduce that commercial book or its games.

<https://www.newinchess.com/the-hippopotamus-defence>

WHAT WAS CHECKED

All 130 course anchors across the five courses were legally replayed. Repertoire-side decisions after the opening commitment received 80,000-node best-move and played-move comparisons; apparent losses above 1.00 were rechecked at 600,000 nodes. Flagged choices were revised. Warning lines deliberately contain mistakes and are marked.

ILLUSTRATIONS AND LIMITS

Short anchors were extended to about move ten using 140,000-node searches. Endpoints used 400,000 nodes; laboratory positions used 500,000 nodes per search. These are finite checks, not proofs of equality or exhaustive modern theory. Optional gambits and full Hippo formations retain practical and strategic risks.

WHAT THE NUMBERS MEAN

Laboratory estimates are expressed from your course side's perspective, so higher is better for that side. They are not literal pawn counts or guaranteed winning probabilities. Close candidate values should be treated as comparable, and deeper analysis may change the ordering.

PUBLICATION CHECKS

PDF text, page geometry, board legality and PGN replay are checked. Every combined-volume page is rendered for visual review. The supplied verification manifest records the final page counts and file hashes.